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Census personnel help tackle tough queries

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Is youth anxiety fuelling protests?

Experts examine if youth are worried about future prospects

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Men in Blue look to continue domination

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INSIDE



Ukraine says at least 13 killed in Russian attack

KYIV
At least 13 people were killed when a Russian drone slammed into a platform at the Dnipro railway station, where a train was parked, Ukrainian authorities said on Thursday. Dnipro mayor Borys Filatov said that "a drone hit a civilian electric train". » PAGE 14



Kharge, Rahul to speak at CEC's 'impeachment'

NEW DELHI
The Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc's planned "public impeachment" of the Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar (CEC), will avoid imagery that could be seen as mocking Parliament as an institution. » PAGE 5

IndiGo reports ₹1,879 crore loss in second quarter

NEW DELHI
IndiGo narrowed its consolidated net loss to ₹1,879.1 crore in the second quarter of FY2027 (Q2FY27) from ₹2,582.1 crore a year earlier as higher passenger yields partly cushioned the impact of surging fuel costs amid geopolitical tensions in West Asia. Elevated crude oil prices kept pressure on the airline's earnings. » PAGE 12

SC proposes relief for digital arrest victims

- Court to examine new regulations proposed by RBI; it calls for inbuilt institutional safeguards
- Bench directs States to provide details of FIRs and status of the investigations and prosecutions
- Top court expresses 'frustration' that educated people still remain gullible to such scamsters

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday called upon the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to mandate financial institutions to fully indemnify digital arrest victims if the crime happened from a lack of institutional diligence.

Expressing "frustration" at digital arrest scamsters siphoning off crores from the national economy annually, the top court also questioned how educated people remained gullible enough to believe they can be detained over mobile phone calls.

Noting that over ₹800 crore fell into the hands of cyber fraudsters impersonating law enforcement agents in a year, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said, "We are really shocked... Why can't people understand? What is the issue with these victims? Are they not normal, sensible people?"

The court said it wanted to examine the proposed Reserve Bank of India (Know Your Customer) Amendment Directions, 2026, which are intended to curb cyberfraud.

It said systems must be in place within financial institutions to temporarily suspend transactions that uncharacteristically deviate from an account's transaction history.

Automated alerts of such transactions must be relayed to police authorities, followed by physical verifications and ascertainment of their genuineness, the court said.

The Bench directed the States to provide information on FIRs registered in digital arrest cases and the status of their investigation and prosecution. The court agreed to schedule the case again before November 30.

> Why can't people understand? What is the issue with these victims?... What is this fear of arrest? Can they not understand a basic thing that no one can be arrested over a mobile phone call... Just throw your mobile against the wall ...We feel frustrated... Why can't we stop this crime?
>
> **SURYA KANT**
> Chief Justice of India



'Several warnings'

A visibly anguished CJI said warnings against digital arrest scams were splashed across all media, besides in repeated orders passed by the top court.

Amicus curiae N.S. Nappinai said even educated people were falling for the trap. "What is this fear of arrest? Can they not understand a basic thing that no one can be arrested over a mobile phone call... Just throw your mobile against the wall," the Chief Justice said.

The *amicus curiae* pointed out that psychologists have said the victims may have undergone some sort of hypnosis.

The CJI questioned the state of mind of people who, rather than swinging into action to alert the nearest police officer, allow themselves to be victimised in a democracy.

He said digital arrest has turned into the "biggest financial fraud in the history of this country". The court said the "problem was [that] bank employees are involved". The CJI asked whether the RBI was "soft-pedalling" on bringing in regulatory measures.

Attorney-General R. Venkataramani, appearing for the Union government and the RBI, advised against haste, saying counter-measures cannot be put into effect with "a wave of the magic wand", but only through ongoing and exhaustive consultations between the central bank and stakeholders. He said the proposed RBI (KYC) Amendment Directions, 2026, would be notified by November 30 and operationalised by December 31.

Mr. Venkataramani said instances of digital arrests have reduced by 50% this year from the previous year's figures. He said money has been restored in over 11 lakh cases. Over seven lakh requests for restoration had been received. Authorities have passed orders in over 5.5 lakh cases. "The RBI is not sleeping over it," the A-G said.

"But despite all these good efforts, the net loss suffered by the country's economy is over ₹800 crore," the Chief Justice remarked.

The previous year, around ₹3,000 crore had been lost to digital arrests.

The CJI said digital arrests were perpetrated through by misusing the instant messaging platform WhatsApp.

Mr. Venkataramani said intermediaries' responsibilities would be part of the instructions to be issued by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology and the Department of Telecom.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for WhatsApp, orally submitted that the platform has already banned 9,400 suspicious accounts on its own.

He said efforts were under way to develop software to identify accounts impersonating law enforcement officials and government agencies, leaking profile photos, etc. The court allowed WhatsApp to intervene in the case and submit a response.

Battling currents



Cyclone fury: Rescue services personnel help a woman to safety amid floods triggered by Cyclone Arnab at Bhanjanagar in Odisha on Thursday. The weather system caused devastation across the State and Andhra Pradesh, marooning many villages and inundating low-lying areas. PTI (REPORTS: PAGES 3 & 6)

Israel to probe election after Netanyahu alleges fraud

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's bloc on Thursday piled pressure on Israeli Arab leaders over unproven accusations of foreign funding, in a push to neuter parties that could hold the key to forming a government after an inconclusive election.

Israeli President Isaac Herzog called for an investigation into allegations of fraud but cautioned against stigmatising the entire Arab Israeli community, who voted at unprecedented rates.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 14



Warning light: Ahead of Deepavali, top court takes note of effects of incessant bursting of firecrackers on public health. FILE PHOTO

Order on fireworks breached 'left and right', says top court

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday said its orders, year after year, to curb and even ban firecrackers during Deepavali, had been violated "left and right".

The right to religious freedom was also subject to public health and the protection of fundamental rights, a Bench of Justices M.M. Sundresh and P.B. Varale said while hearing a case on the increase in pollution as the festival drew near amid the loud bangs of firecrackers.

Justice Sundresh reminded that Deepavali is called the 'festival of lights', and said the incessant bursting of firecrackers takes a toll on the health of a large section of the population.

"The problem might have started with gunpowder," the judge said. "Our orders are breached left and right. How many contempt petitions can be filed? Every year we try to balance it out... But, armed with our orders, pollution still takes place," Justice Sundresh said.

'Not in favour of ban'

"We understand the sentiments of the public. If we think in a logical sense, celebrations do boost morale," he said.

The court also empathised with officers' hesitation to book criminal cases against ordinary people who were "enthusiastic" about celebrations.

Justice Sundresh said the court was not in favour of a complete ban.

"That may have a spiralling effect. But having said that, please do not push us to take harsh actions," the Bench said.

'Change from within'

The court asked Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, for the Centre and the Delhi government, to ensure enforcement against sellers of spurious and banned crackers who want to draw maximum profit from the seasonal business.

The top court said the change has to come from within the people.

"Traders will go by supply and demand... Your officers will have to forget their personal celebrations. They have to go out and see what is happening on the ground... So far, what are the measures you have taken... Show us your enforcement data... Be very serious in giving effect to our orders," the judge said.

The court proposed the Centre take the help of celebrities like cricketer Virat Kohli to spread awareness against firecrackers.

'BJP agent' files form to exclude long-time Muslim voters

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

Sajid Hussain has lived at the same address in the Dayalpur neighbourhood of Delhi's Mustafabad for over two decades. But on Wednesday, the tailor was shocked to learn that Form 7 applications have been filed to delete the names of his son and wife from Delhi's electoral roll during the ongoing claims and objections period as part of the special intensive revision (SIR).

Mr. Hussain said he had never heard the name of the person who filed the Form 7s against his son, Asad Raza Zaidi, and wife, Afsana Khatoon. The two were among the 28 voters in the neighbourhood against whom deletions were sought, citing 'absent/permanently shifted' or 'death' as the reason.

The applications were all filed by Chandra Shekhar Nainwal, a BJP-appointed booth-level agent-2, as per the records of the Election Comission of India (ECI).

However, all 28 electors were found to be living at their addresses during *The Hindu's* visit. All had submitted enumeration forms and were present on the draft roll published on August 31. *The Hindu* met and spoke with 19 of them or their immediate kin who had valid identity proofs, and none had heard Mr. Nainwal's name before.

These were the only Form 7s filled in polling booth 129; of these, 18 were listed on the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO)'s daily objections list (Form 10) on October 25, nine on October 21, and one on October 19.

These electors have yet to receive a notice generated after an objection is received by the Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) and displayed on Form 10.



Seeking justice: Afsana Khatoon, left, and Zaheer Ali against whom Form 7s have been filed during Delhi SIR. SURUCHI KUMARI

Not lone incident

Meanwhile, for Zaheer Ali, 76, the reason cited for deletion was 'death'. Shama Parveen, one of his family members, said, "We are being targeted probably because of our identities."

In the building next to Mr. Hussain's house, Abdul Jabbar's 22-year-old son Mohd. Huzefa and daughter Ayesha's names also featured on the deletion list.

Similar patterns emerged in other areas of the Mustafabad constituency, where electors' names were sought to be deleted even though they lived at their given addresses.

Mustafabad has seen the highest number of Form 7 applications, with 843 objections since August 31. Of the 597 forms filed by third parties, 96% name BLAs from the BJP as 'objectors'; 572 Form 7s filed by these BLAs are against Muslim voters.

Ten BLAs, so far, have filed more than 30 Form 7s and nine over 25 applications despite the ECI's October 9 directive mandating a cap of 10 such forms an individual elector can file online and offline.

While BLA-2s are permitted to submit 'bulk' forms not exceeding 10 a day, including Forms 6, 7 and 8 filled by other individual electors, they are required to submit a list of such applications along with an undertaking that they have verified the details. However, in all these cases, the BLAs themselves filed the forms as 'objectors'. "If the BLA is not submitting the forms with the BLA undertaking, and fills them as an 'objector,' then the rules and limits of an individual elector will apply to him," said a senior official.

In all these 572 Form 7s against Muslim electors, including those filed by Shashi (42 applications), Raman (35), Manoj Kumar (33) Mohan Madan (33), Sawar Singh (32) Raj Kumar (31), Himanshu (31), Kapil (30), Nitin Kumar (30), Robin Singh Dhama (30), Neeraj Sharma (29), Abhishek Mishra (28), officials confirmed all the objectors were registered as BLAs.

When contacted, Mr. Nainwal first identified himself as a resident of the constituency. However, when asked about the objections, he denied filing them, saying he is neither a BLA nor associated with any political party. He later said that his name was different and cut the call saying, "wrong number".

INBRIEF



Aaditya opposes floating hoardings along waterfronts

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Aaditya Thackeray has sought Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis's intervention against "floating hoardings" in Mumbai's seas, calling the decision to permit them highly irresponsible and warning that it would ruin the city's aesthetics. The Mumbai Maritime Board has decided to allow floating advertisements on barges along prominent waterfronts in the city. Mr. Thackeray said there has to be a hoarding policy to regulate LED hoardings that inconvenience citizens at night and limit their numbers. "Aesthetics over cartels must be the norm, but sadly this decision chooses contractors over aesthetics," he said. PTI

Punjab election: BJP seeks early MCC implementation

Punjab BJP leader Sunil Jakhar on Thursday wrote to the Punjab Governor, urging him to recommend to the Election Commission early implementation of the model code of conduct (MCC) in the State, alleging "deteriorating" law and order situation. In a letter to Governor Gulab Chand Kataria, Mr. Jakhar said the State government denied permission to hold an anti-drug marathon in Abohar, citing the prevailing law and order situation. "I wish to draw your attention to Punjab's deteriorating law and order situation, which the Bhagwant Mann government has now itself acknowledged by denying permission even for a marathon event," Mr. Jakhar wrote. PTI

Jamia students call off stir as union demand accepted

After 18 days of protests, Registrar issues order for May 15, 2027 as date by which constitution for union would be cleared; physical classes to resume soon; notices against protesters to be revoked

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

The Jamia Millia Islamia (JMI) administration on Thursday agreed to the protesting students' demands to set dates for drafting and approving the students' union constitution and holding elections for the same, following which the protesters called off their 18-day stir.

Vice-Chancellor Mazhar Asif and Registrar Mahtab Alam Rizvi approached the protesters near Gate No. 7 in Gulistan-e-Ghalib lawns and made the announcement, following which celebrations broke out across the campus, which had been closed during the protest for reinstating the students' union.

As per the Registrar's order, the constitution will be drafted and approved by May 15, 2027.

Following the order, the administration directed that classes, which had been shifted online last week, be held physically from November 2. It asked all departments to arrange offline examinations as per their timetables. The university directed students to strictly adhere to academic rules and regulations, adding that physical attendance would be mandatory.



Elated crowd: Protesting students at Jamia Millia Islamia celebrate on Thursday evening after calling off the stir. ANI

The development came on JMI's 106th Foundation Day, which the administration and the protesters celebrated separately.

'Democratic process'

Speaking about the composition of the panel that would draft the student union constitution, the Registrar said, "The drafting committee will not only have faculty members and legal experts but also student representatives so that their views come to us in a democratic manner. We will send the draft to all stakeholders for comments, then submit it to the Academic Council, the Executive Council and then finally to the Visitor Nominee for final approval."

He added that after the framework is approved, the university will issue a notification for the elections in accordance with the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations. The elections will be held within six weeks of July 16, 2027, the beginning of the next academic year.

In his order, Mr. Rizvi stated that all disciplinary notices against students in connection with participation in the agitation would be revoked.

Meanwhile, the police registered an FIR, the second since the protest began, against students on Thursday based on a complaint by the administration alleging vandalism on October 27. On the same day, a Special Executive Magistrate remanded two National Students' Union of India (NSUI) members, who were detained outside the campus on Wednesday, in three days' judicial custody. Three others arrested on October 26 were released on Thursday.

Ebin Basil, a third-year law student and general secretary of NSUI's Jamia unit, called off his hunger strike, saying, "The university administration has agreed to all the demands we put forward. A special thanks to [IUML MP] Haris Beeran sir. This is a victory for the students and a victory for democracy."

Talking to presspersons in the evening, the Rajya Sabha member said he met the V-C during the day with the students' demands. "The Vice-Chancellor, Registrar and the Dean held a meeting among themselves. Then they came out and said that they have accepted all the demands."

Allegations against me are baseless and malicious: BJP leader

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



L. Murugan

BJP leader L. Murugan, who recently resigned from his Rajya Sabha membership and as a Union Minister of State, on Thursday rejected certain allegations made against him in some sections of the media.

"These statements are baseless, absolutely fabricated, malicious, and politically motivated, with the sole aim of maligning my hard-earned reputation and creating unnecessary confusion among the public," he said.

Mr. Murugan said certain unwanted and derogatory statements had been made and circulated through various media platforms by those "unable to accept my present role to improve the party cadre at all levels".

The purpose of his resignation was "only to work for the cadre at the grassroots level to enable the party to face the 2029 Lok Sabha elections", he said. All the allegations and propaganda spread by certain people with political motives and malicious intent were far from the truth, he added.

"Making such statements is not only defamatory, but also concerning various other individuals, and thereby the very motive seems to be larger in scope to unnecessarily create unrest among the people of Tamil Nadu," the former BJP Tamil Nadu unit president said.

He called for the removal of all the content/posts/publications regarding his resignation.

"Such conduct cannot be permitted to continue. I call upon those responsible to issue a public apology for making and disseminating statements without any evidence, in an irresponsible manner and with malicious intent, thereby causing serious damage to my good name and reputation," Mr. Murugan said.

If such defamatory content was not removed, Mr. Murugan said appropriate legal action would be taken before criminal as well as civil courts.

NHRC seeks report from police for parading accused persons shirtless on Kolkata streets

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) on Thursday took suo motu cognisance of reports where three accused were paraded in semi-nude condition in city's Behala area and issued a notice to the Commissioner of Kolkata Police, calling for a detailed report on the matter within two weeks.

The commission observed that the contents of the news reports, "if true, raise serious issues of violation of human rights".

"A day before, an 18-year-old youth and his friend, who were reportedly seen with a minor girl, were beaten and humiliated by the girl's family at her house. The youth's father, whom the girl's family summoned, was also assaulted.

The commission took suo motu cognisance of the incident based on media reports

Subsequently, all three were stripped and forced to walk naked on the road at gunpoint," a press release by the commission stated.

The Kolkata Police on October 27 paraded two of accused who harassed the trio through the same neighbourhood in shorts, barefoot and with ropes tied around their waists, during a reconstruction of the alleged crime.

Civil rights organisations such as Association for Protection of Democratic Rights raised questions on the conduct of the police saying that police were trying to "normalise revenge" and give punishment which the courts must be doing.

This was not the first time that the police in West Bengal have paraded people semi-nude as a part of crime scene reconstruction. Several reports of accused persons being paraded in vest and undergarments with ropes tied to their waist had surfaced earlier from Howrah, Kolkata and other parts of the State.

'Can't humiliate people'

The arrests, mostly of accused against whom several allegations of extortion have been made, have taken place after the Bharatiya Janata Party came to power in the State.

On June 5, 2026, Calcutta High Court had observed that the State has the authority to arrest and prosecute individuals but cannot subject them to humiliation.

T.N. jailbreak: Prisons chief shifted days after 17 undertrials escape

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A couple of days after the sensational jailbreak in Theni district of Tamil Nadu in which 17 prisoners escaped and were later apprehended, the State government transferred the Director-General of Police, Prisons, Sandeep Rai Rathore.

He was posted as DGP/Chief Vigilance Officer, Tangedco, Chennai. K. Shankar, ADGP, Enforcement Bureau-CID, was posted as the ADGP, Prisons and Correctional Services.



Sandeep Rai Rathore

Second instance

The Theni jailbreak was the second instance of inmates escaping from a prison. Two prisoners escaped from Puzhal Central Prison on October 20, 2026, and were apprehended the next day. Seven assistant jailers were suspended for the alleged security lapses.

In the Theni district jail, 17 remand prisoners allegedly overpowered jail staff members and escaped on October 26. They were all nabbed and sent back to the prison. Dr. Rathore visited the jail and ordered the suspension of nine prison wardens for dereliction of duty.

Stalin demands apology from Vijay for academic's detention; TVK denies 'political vendetta'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin on Thursday condemned the brief detention of Kalaiyarasan, an associate assistant professor at the Madras Institute of Development Studies (MIDS), on Wednesday. Mr. Stalin claimed the academic was detained for highlighting the unprecedented price rise, describing it as the height of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam's (TVK) "fascist attitude".

He said Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay and the police department must apologise for the "arrest".

In a statement, Mr. Stalin said he was shocked by the "illegal arrest" by plainclothes police personnel.

Mr. Stalin said the academic was a professor at



A. Kalaiyarasan

one of Tamil Nadu's foremost research institutions and had obtained his Ph.D. from Jawaharlal Nehru University. "He is one of the authors of *The Dravidian Model*, published by Cambridge University Press. He was a member of the Central Planning Commission and played a major role in preparing an economic research paper for the Tamil Nadu government. He is still a member of the Department of Environment and Climate Change, headed by the Chief Minister," the former Chief Minister said.

Questioning the grounds for the "arrest", Mr. Stalin asked whether Prof. Kalaiyarasan had been targeted for highlighting the achievements of the 'Dravidian Model' government and exposing the unprecedented price rise under the TVK regime.

'Fake account'

The ruling TVK, however, denied any "political vendetta" in the police inquiry involving the MIDS professor, and said it was not related to his remarks on rising rice prices. In a post on X, TVK spokesperson Vivek Gananathan condemned the use of Mr. Kalaiyarasan's photograph on a fake social media account to post obscene comments.

Cheetah shooting: wildlife officials in M.P. raise questions over Chambal's 'gun culture'

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

Wildlife officials in Madhya Pradesh have raised questions about the prevalent gun culture in the Chambal region even as they continue their investigation into the killing of a 19-month-old cheetah cub which was found with five gunshot injuries on October 25.

The cub died on October 27 morning during treatment in Jabalpur.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, a high-ranking official said that the gun culture has emerged as a "crucial segment" in the probe and that the matter had been brought up with senior police officers of the region. The probe is yet to make a breakthrough.



A pair of cheetahs atop a tree at the Kuno National Park in Sheopur district of Madhya Pradesh. FILE PHOTO

"It's a very complex dynamics there with almost everybody owning a gun. So, we will have to target this culture too going forward. There is need to review the criteria of issuing a gun license in the region and we hope there is some discussion about this at the government level," the official said requesting anonymity, while calling for a crackdown on the illegal gun manufacturing in the region.

The conversation on gun culture coming up in the probe was confirmed by State's Chief Wildlife Warden (CWLW) Sameeta Rajora.

Ms. Rajora said that all possible angles, including poaching, revenge killing or self-defence, were being explored in the probe.

Pellet wounds

On the evening of October 25, a cheetah monitoring team found the cub, that was wearing a radio-collar for tracking, in a still position in the compartment no. 748 of the Sheopur Territorial Forest Division on the border of Sheopur and Morena districts, about 50 kilometres from Kuno's boundaries. During treatment in Jabalpur, five firearm metal pallets were recovered from its body, including one from his lung.

The two districts fall under the Chambal region that was once infamous for its vast ravines and the dacoits hiding in them.

'Mother of the world': citing Manusmriti, court gives life term to 3 for cow slaughter

Press Trust of India
GANDHINAGAR

A court in Gujarat's Gandhinagar district has sentenced three persons to life imprisonment in a cow slaughter case after they were found in possession of 277 kg of beef, citing Hindu scriptures to underscore the religious significance of the cow.

Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi hailed the verdict, calling it a clear message that the law will never spare those who commit cow slaughter in the State.

In his judgment on Monday, Additional Sessions Judge B.R. Rajput also imposed a fine of ₹3 lakh on the convicts, Vasim Qureshi, Mohammad Rafiq Qureshi, and Asfaq Baheem. Quoting the Manusmriti, an ancient Sanskrit text, the court observed that the cow is not merely an animal but is regarded as a pillar of material prosperity and 'dharma' (righteousness).

Through a 2017 amendment, Gujarat govt. had enhanced punishment for slaughter of cows

"Sage Manu entrusted the primary responsibility for the protection and care of cattle to the 'Vaishya' class. Furthermore, in the context of 'Arsha Vivaha' (a traditional form of Vedic marriage), the pair - a cow and a bull - holds special significance," the judge said.

Further quoting the Vedas and other Hindu scriptures, the court said that when drops of 'amrita' (nectar) fell to the earth through the power of penance, the divine cow Kamadhenu emerged and came to be regarded as the progenitor of all bovine species on earth.

'Four legs, four vedas'

"The cow is regarded as the 'mother of the world', serving as an abode for 33 crore deities. Her four legs are symbolic of the four Vedas, the court said.

According to the prosecution, six persons were arrested with 277 kg of beef and tools allegedly used to slaughter cows and buffaloes and a vehicle meant to transport the meat after a raid on a house in Jamla village of Gandhinagar district on August 22, 2024.The prosecution said a father-son duo would purchase weak or non-lactating cows and buffaloes. They would then bring four individuals from Ahmedabad to their home and have the animals slaughtered in a cruel manner for beef, all for the sake of financial gain. Citing the investigation, the prosecution said the accused intended to sell the beef to one Ghulam Moin. After the trial, the court found three of the six men guilty.

Through a 2017 amendment to the Gujarat Animal Preservation Act, 1954, the Gujarat government had enhanced punishment for those found guilty of cow slaughter to life imprisonment, making it the first State to do so.

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Naidu puts cyclone loss at ₹4,600 cr.

Central team to visit worst-hit districts of Konaseema and West Godavari today; A.P. requests Telangana to send 1,000 staff for power restoration work; announces compensation for coconut and oil palm growers; IMD forecasts another depression

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Andhra Pradesh has suffered an estimated loss of ₹4,600 crore due to Cyclone Arnab, as per the government's preliminary assessment, Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu said on Thursday.

Mr. Naidu made an aerial survey of cyclone-hit areas in the Krishna and Godavari regions. He inspected the areas on the way to Cheyyeru village in Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema district, one of the worst-affected areas.

Seven dead

After interacting with flood victims at Gacchakayala Pora village, Mr. Naidu told the media that the cyclone preparedness had helped check the loss of lives. Seven people had died in cyclone-triggered incidents in the State.

The Chief Minister said that he had briefed Union Home Minister Amit Shah about the cyclone damage. "A Central team will arrive in Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema and West Godavari districts on Friday to assess the damage," he said.

8,000 poles uprooted

He said the State had requested Telangana to depute 1,000 staff to ensure speedy restoration of power supply.

"If need be, we will request Tamil Nadu and Karnataka to send 2,000 personnel for the power restoration work, mostly in the Godavari region. Power restoration work will be finished quickly, and the supply will resume by Saturday," Mr. Naidu said, adding that at least 8,000 electric poles were uprooted in Konaseema district alone.



Battered crop: A farmer shows banana plants damaged by Cyclone Arnab at Tadepalli mandal in Guntur district on Thursday. G.N. RAO

Machines would be brought from other States to ensure speedy installation of poles, he said.

"A compensation of ₹1,500 will be given for each coconut and oil palm tree that fell under the influence of the cyclone. The compensation and input subsidy will be decided after the enumeration of the damage to crops," the Chief Minister said.

A ₹25-kg rice bag and cash would be given to the families who were shifted to relief camps.

More rain likely

The State may see another spell of heavy rain from November 1, as a low-pressure area formed over the south Andaman Sea may strengthen over the next three days. According to the India Metereological Department (IMD), Amaravati, the low-pressure area will move west-northwestwards and concentrate into a depression over the southeast Bay of Bengal and adjoining areas of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands around October 31.

Thereafter, it is likely to intensify and move west-northwestwards towards the Andhra Pradesh coast by November 2. The system is likely to bring heavy rainfall to the coastal places on November 1 and 2.



Extensive operation: Searches under way at former Minister K.N. Nehru's residence in Tiruchi on Thursday. M. MOORTHY

DVAC teams search residence of former T.N. Minister Nehru

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI/TIRUCHI/ NAMAKKAL/COIMBATORE/ VELLORE

Multiple teams of the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) conducted searches at the residence of former Tamil Nadu Minister K.N. Nehru in Tiruchi, and four other places in the district on Thursday in connection with the alleged multi-crore cash-for-jobs scam. Searches were also conducted at multiple locations across the State.

Headed by a Deputy Superintendent of Police of the agency, the searches at the DMK leader's residence at Thillai Nagar in Tiruchi commenced around 7 a.m. Several DMK members gathered in front of his residence. The searches came against the backdrop of the Madras High Court clearing the decks for the DVAC to investigate the case filed against the former Minister.

During the nearly eight-hour operation, investigators seized a tablet computer and a few documents connected with the case, DVAC sources said. Mr. Nehru, who was the Municipal Administration Minister in the DMK government of 2021-2026, was present at the time.

Similar searches were conducted at the residence of DMK town secretary Murali at Thuraiyur in Tiruchi district, and the residence of a person named Mohanraj at Manapparai. Searches were also conducted at the residences of two individuals at Srirangam and Tiruvanaikoil in Tiruchi, police sources said.

DVAC officials also conducted searches on the premises belonging to Mr. Nehru's brother on Tiruchi Road and at GV Residency in Coimbatore.

The DVAC had registered a case against Mr. Nehru and others on the basis of a complaint filed by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED).

Mr. Nehru said the searches at his residence could be a diversionary tactic by the TVK-led government in the wake of a spike in crimes in the State and a jailbreak in Theni.

Kerala HC directs police not to arrest judge in car crash probe

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court on Thursday directed the police not to arrest an additional district judge, father of the 17-year-old boy who drove the car involved in a car accident at Cheranalloor, near here, until further orders.

Justice Kauser Edappagath orally remarked that the court could not succumb to public opinion, saying that "the law has to be strictly followed".

The court allowed the family members of the victim to be added as parties to the anticipatory bail petition moved by the judge.

The court held that since the petitioner was a serving judicial officer, there was no question that he would abscond or evade the process of law.

Evidence tampering

Senior lawyer P. Vijayabhanu argued for the petitioner that he had cooperated with the investigation and the search conducted at his home. He contended that he was unaware that his son had taken the vehicle from his house, and only realised it upon receiving a call from his son about the accident.

The State, represented by special government pleader C. Rasheed, contended that within 30 minutes of receiving the call, the judge and his wife had reached the site, and remained there for an hour to tamper with evidence.

SC axes Karnataka law validating 'corrupt' hiring

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday declared unconstitutional a Karnataka State law, which validated the 2011 selection of Gazetted Probationers made through what the court described as a "corrupt" and "blatantly nepotistic" recruitment process conducted by the State Public Service Commission.

A Bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K. Vinod Chandran held that the Karnataka Civil Services (Validation of Selection and Appointment of 2011 Batch Gazetted Probationers) Act, 2022, was enacted clearly with the intent to countermand the judgments of both the Karnataka High Court and the Supreme Court. The courts had upheld the decision to cancel the entire 2011 recruitment process for 362 posts of Group 'A' and 'B' Officers. The legislature does not have the power to nullify the judgments, Justice Chandran said.

The court highlighted how the State government, represented by senior advocate Kapil Sibal, constantly changed its position over a decade. The State had, over the years, swung between supporting the cancellation of the entire recruitment process and enacting the 2022 law, leaving the hapless candidates caught in the crosshairs of shifting political whims and systemic failure. "Six appellants who would be over-aged now have relentlessly pursued their cause in their zeal to join the Karnataka Civil Services," Justice Chandran observed.

'Gross manipulation'

The 2011 recruitment process saw 1,38,307 people apply. Two years later, a Criminal Investigation Department inquiry found "gross manipulations" in the process, and "the irregularities in evaluation of answer scripts were found to be shockingly disgraceful".

On Thursday, the Supreme Court upheld the cancellation of the entire recruitment based on a 2011 notification.

It directed the State government to notify the recruitment for the vacant posts in the Group 'A' and 'B' services. Appointed candidates who were not found tainted, the six appellants before the Supreme Court, and the petitioners before the Karnataka Administrative Tribunal would be granted age relaxation to appear in the recruitment process as a one-time opportunity.

INBRIEF



Keralam Ministers, MLAs set to get hike in salaries, perks

The salaries and allowances of Ministers in Keralam will go up from a monthly ₹1.08 lakh to approximately ₹1.3 lakh and the allowances of MLAs from ₹70,000 to ₹98,000. The 16th Kerala Assembly passed the Payment of Salaries and Allowances (Amendment) Bill, 2026, and the Kerala Payment of Pension to Members of Legislature (Amendment) Bill, 2026. The revisions will take effect from November 1. The allowances and other benefits were last revised in 2018. Both Bills were cleared by the Cabinet on Wednesday.

Karnataka hikes Nandini milk prices by ₹8 a litre from Nov. 1

Just ahead of the Deepavali season, the Karnataka Cabinet on Thursday approved a hike in the selling price of Nandini milk by the Karnataka Milk Federation (KMF) by ₹8 a litre, effective from November 1. The price of basic toned milk, sold in blue packets, will go up from ₹46 to ₹54. While ₹7 of the hike would go to milk-producing farmers, the remaining ₹1 would be used by the milk cooperatives to handle their expenses. Hotel owners have indicated that the prices of coffee, tea and other items would be hiked.

Keralam to probe role of expired drug in Nipah deaths

Keralam will constitute a medical board to investigate whether use of an expired drug, Remdesivir, drug given to COVID-19 and Nipah patients, led to the deaths of Nipah patients, Health Minister K. Muraleedharan said on Thursday. It is suspected that the drugs given to patients in 2023, 2024, and 2025 had expired. Of the six Nipah cases reported in 2023, two died, while in 2024, of the two cases reported, both died. In 2025, of the three cases reported, two died.

From well to wild



Happy ending: An elephant that fell into an abandoned well in a rubber plantation in Thrissur district, Keralam, on Thursday, was rescued after hours-long joint efforts by the State Forest Department, Fire and Rescue Services personnel, and local residents. The elephant suffered no major injuries and later rejoined its herd. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

37% pre-SIR Form 6 rejected in Telangana due to declaration rule

Swathi Vadlamudi
HYDERABAD

Shifting goal posts by the Election Commission of India (ECI) with regard to the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls have resulted in rejection of lakhs of application forms for new voter enrolments in Telangana.

A large number of applications for fresh voter registration, submitted through Form 6 before the start of the SIR process, got rejected because they were not accompanied by a declaration form mandated as a prerequisite for enrolment. The declaration form, which was an attachment to the Form 6 exclusively for the SIR process, sought details of the voter or the voter's parents/relatives from 2002 SIR. In the absence of such details, the applicants were required to submit any of the listed 12 documents as proof of their citizenship.

As per data obtained from the office of the Telangana Chief Electoral Officer, a total of 5,20,331 applications were received for new enrolments during the pre-SIR period between January 1 and June 14They were not accompanied by the declaration form. Of the total pre-SIR Form 6 applications, only 3,22,785 were accepted as new enrolments till October 28. A total 1,92,574 were rejected, clocking a 37% rejection rate.

17 lakh kg of diverted PDS grain seized in Karnataka; 215 held

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Nearly 238 FIRs have been registered across the State over the past three months

As part of a crackdown on the illegal diversion of ration supplies across Karnataka, officials from the Food, Civil Supplies, and Consumer Affairs Department seized 17.78 lakh kg of rice and other foodgrains meant for public distribution over the past three months.

Since August 1, officials inspected vehicles transporting ration commodities and searched private warehouses in various districts. Belagavi district accounted for more than 5 lakh kg of the seized foodgrains, followed by Kolar with 3.5 lakh kg. More than one lakh kg of rice and other foodgrains each were seized in Bagalkot and Vijayapura districts.

The department has registered 238 FIRs at police stations across the State, and arrested 215 persons. It has also confiscated 156 vehicles allegedly used to transport ration commodities illegally.

UDF, LDF slam airlines for festival fare increase

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The ruling United Democratic Front (UDF) and the Opposition Left Democratic Front (LDF) in Keralam on Thursday slammed airline companies for jacking up airfares during festival seasons.

Speaking in the Assembly, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said his government has again written to the Centre drawing attention to the issue. "Airlines continue to fleece non-resident Keralites despite successive governments in Keralam urging Centre to place a cap on airfares," he said.

Eight Keralam panchayats to revive traditional *surangam*

The Hindu Bureau
KASARAGOD

A comprehensive project to rejuvenate Keralam's traditional underground water tunnels, known as "*surangams*", is set to be implemented in eight grama panchayats in Kasaragod district to improve groundwater recharge, conserve rainwater, and maintain water flow in rivers amid declining rainfall and increasing drought risks.

The project will initially cover Kayyur-Cheemeni, Kodom-Belur, Kallar, Pallikkara, Bedadka, Puthige, Chengala and Kumbla grama panchayats.



*Surangam*s are horizontal tunnels excavated in laterite hills. FILE PHOTO

The project will make extensive use of workers under the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G).

Surangams are a distinctive traditional water harvesting system found in Kasaragod. They are horizontal tunnels excavated into laterite hills, allowing groundwater to seep naturally into the passages and flow out for collection and use. Rainwater percolates into the ground during the monsoon and emerges through the tunnels during the summer, making them a traditional means of sustaining water supply.

Experts from the Kerala Regional Office of the Central Groundwater Board (CGB) have held detailed discussions with VB-G RAM G officials on the restoration, conservation and scientific maintenance of the tunnels, according to Regional Director Dr. D. Gnanasundar.

SC reserves verdict on ED plea for CBI probe in I-PAC case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The ED had blamed Mamata Banerjee for removing records and devices from the sites of the raids

The Supreme Court on Thursday reserved judgment in a petition filed by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) for a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into the alleged obstruction of its raids at the offices of political consultancy firm I-PAC and its co-founder Pratik Jain in Kolkata by then West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, State officials and other individuals.

A Bench headed by Justice Prashant Kumar Mishra closed the final arguments in the case even as senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Ms. Banerjee, said power in West Bengal had changed hands. The current dispensation could very well take a call on whether or not to transfer the case to the CBI, Mr. Sibal said.

The ED had arraigned the State of West Bengal, Ms. Banerjee, the State's Director-General of Police, the Kolkata Police Commissioner, and the Deputy Commissioner of Police, South Kolkata, along with the CBI.

The agency had blamed Ms. Banerjee for removing records and devices from the sites of the raids. She had at the time countered that the raids were a deliberate attempt to derail the Trinamool Congress ahead of the Assembly election in 2026.

I-PAC had helped the party shape its electoral and political strategy in the 2021 Assembly election and subsequent elections in West Bengal.

Coal smuggling probe

The anti-money laundering agency had argued that the intervention of Ms. Banerjee had upset a lawful investigation into coal smuggling.

The sites of the raids had descended into scenes of a "showdown" through the illegal intervention of the State machinery, the ED has submitted in its petition before the apex court.

Census trainers tackle tough queries

Hundreds of sessions being carried out across U.P. and 3 more States before door-to-door enumeration begins on December 1; this phase involves 40 questions, 13 of them new; trainers urge enumerators to exercise caution and sensitivity when seeking responses on caste and Aadhaar details

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI



Mammoth task: Enumerators being trained on Census operations in Ghazipur this week. @DCO_UP/X

At a large hall being used for a training session for Census enumerators in Uttar Pradesh on Thursday, a field trainer explains the importance of question number 37, which seeks the respondent's Aadhaar.

"If any respondent creates an issue, they need to be told that the particular question is only to find out how many people have an Aadhaar. They are to be told clearly that we are not seeking their bank account details and Aadhaar cannot be used without biometrics anyway," the trainer announces on a microphone as more than 50 enumerators, mostly schoolteachers, listen with rapt attention.

This is one of hundreds of training sessions being carried out across Uttar Pradesh and three other poll-bound States, before they begin door-to-door enumeration on December 1, for the second phase of Census 2027. The rest of the country will undergo the same exercise in February 2027. In preparation for the challenging task ahead, trainers flag the thorniest questions, including new queries on caste, age and place of birth of parents, and of course, Aadhaar.

'Citizenship proof'

At one particular session attended by *The Hindu* – its precise location has been withheld to protect the identity of Census officials – the trainer suggests that enumerators offer hesitant respondents an interesting incentive to coax them to share their Aadhaar data.

"At present, there is no single document that proves citizenship. If we get the accurate information during Census, then in the future, this document may act as a proof of citizenship," the trainer says, adding that any information provided during the Census is confidential.

The government has consistently maintained that Aadhaar is not a proof of citizenship, and a senior Census official told *The Hindu* that "no such instructions" have been passed to the trainers.

"There is no instruction to link Aadhaar with citizenship test. The question is optional, if a person says that he or she has or even does not have Aadhaar, it will be recorded as such. The enumerator will ask for the Aadhaar and if the respondent does not want to provide the number, the question can be skipped. The particular field trainer may have had some misconception," the Census official said.

13 new questions

This population enumeration phase involves 40 questions, and enumerators must spend at least 20 to 25 minutes with each respondent, unlike the first houselisting operations phase which only took a few minutes. Each enumeration block comprises 750 to 800 people.

There are 13 questions being asked for the first time: caste (other than Scheduled Tribe/Scheduled Caste), religion, place and date of birth of both parents, number of bank accounts, spouse's name, nationality, digital literacy, permanent residential address, place of COVID-19 vaccination, passport number, driving licence availability, and mobile, Aadhaar, and voter ID numbers, if available.

Question 10 C

Another question that enumerators were told to be cautious about was question number 10 C, which asks the caste of the respondent.

"You have to manually write the caste, as what is being told to you, there will be no dropdown option. It is a sensitive question and your job is not to argue or do any kind of commentary on the issue. You have to navigate this question in a sensible way," the field trainer tells the enumerators. To a pointed question from the audience, the trainer responds, "There will be no separate column for OBCs [Other Backward Classes]."

Other than Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes who can choose the names from a pre-determined drop box, all others will have to type the caste name in an open column. This is Independent India's first caste enumeration. Question number 10 (C) says: "If not SC/ST in this State/UT-Enter Caste name." There are two other options: "Does not want to declare Caste", and "No Caste." The data fields on caste are marked "mandatory".

Age estimation method

The trainer explains to enumerators how they are to determine the age of the parents of elderly respondents.

"For senior citizens, who may not remember the date of birth of their parents, an estimation method may be applied. The age can be approximately calculated by taking into account the age of their siblings, etc. If the place of birth is in India, then the details are also to be recorded," the trainer says.

This is India's first digital Census, meaning that around 34 lakh enumerators will capture respondents' data using an app on their personal phones.

Ready to provide counterterrorism expertise to ASEAN countries: India

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI



Collective approach: Defence Minister Rajnath Singh at the 13th ASEAN Defence Ministers' meeting in Cebu, Philippines. PTI

India is committed to collective regional security and the eradication of terrorism in all its forms and is ready to share its battle-tested counterterrorism expertise with ASEAN partners to strengthen joint capabilities, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Thursday.

Addressing the 13th ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting-Plus (ADMM-Plus) in Cebu, Philippines, Mr. Singh said India's counterterrorism experience was not theoretical knowledge but had been acquired through decades of confronting complex security challenges, including cross-border terrorism.

He said India's strategies had been tested and refined through real-world operations, with Operation Sindoor demonstrating the country's proactive counter-terrorism doctrine.

During the operation, India dismantled terrorist infrastructure and enforced a firm red line against state-sponsored terrorism, he said. Emphasising that terrorism knows no borders, Mr. Singh said India was prepared to share its operational experience with ADMM-Plus partners through joint exercises, capacity-building programmes and intelligence sharing.

Counterterrorism remains an important area of cooperation under the ADMM-Plus framework, with India and Malaysia co-chairing the Experts' Working Group on Counter-Terrorism for the 2024-2027 cycle.

In a significant proposal to deepen regional engagement, Mr. Singh called for the establishment of a dedicated defence 'Youth Bridge' to strengthen institutional people-to-people connectivity between India and ASEAN countries. The ASEAN members appreciated the move. The initiative would promote digital innovation and capacity building, while providing greater opportunities for young people to contribute to regional peace and security.

Highlighting the importance of maritime security, Mr. Singh said India had designated 2026 as the ASEAN-India Year of Maritime Cooperation and had conducted the second ASEAN-India Maritime Exercise. He reiterated India's commitment to freedom of navigation, international maritime law and the security of global sea lanes.

Misri to travel to Nepal ahead of Balendra Shah's India visit

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI



Vikram Misri

In a visit to fine-tune the details of Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah's planned trip to India, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri is expected to reach Kathmandu on November 4, along with newly designated Indian ambassador Sudhakar Dalela, a Nepali diplomatic source has told *The Hindu*.

Mr. Shah is expected to visit India by the end of the year, even as his seven-month-old government continues to deal with the aftermath of the devastating floods in the Bhote Koshi River while also planning a slew of administrative and political reforms.

If it materialises, this will be the first bilateral visit abroad by Mr. Shah, who rose to prominence during the September 2025 Gen-Z uprising in Nepal that overthrew the government of former Prime Minister K.P. Sharma Oli.

The Hindu had earlier reported that Mr. Shah, who belongs to the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) led by former media personality Rabi Lamichhane, had vowed to focus on domestic priorities while deprioritising foreign interlocutors. In fact, Mr. Misri was earlier scheduled to travel to Kathmandu to meet Prime Minister Shah in May but the visit was postponed, ostensibly because of the new leader's resolve to focus on domestic challenges.

Subsequently, RSP chairman Mr. Lamichhane was hosted in New Delhi and met Prime Minister Narendra Modi on June 3, after which Nepal's Foreign Minister Sisir Khanal visited Delhi on June 5, in the first Minister-level representation to India from the new government, and met his Indian counterpart S. Jaishankar. This was followed by the visits of Nepal's Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle in September and Home Minister Sudan Gurung, who participated in the BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) Home Ministers' meeting held on October 13.

Election body extends SIR timeline in several States

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Thursday revised the schedule for the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Maharashtra, Delhi, Andhra Pradesh, Haryana, Telangana, and Nagaland.

In Maharashtra, the deadline for filing claims and objections has been extended from October 26 to November 13.

The notice phase and disposal of claims will now run until November 25, and the final roll will be published on November 30. The draft roll came out on August 31, and disposals had earlier been fixed for November 10.

In Delhi, claims and objections can now be filed until November 25, instead of October 30.

Shutdown in Manipur over two missing Kuki youth

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Committee on Tribal Unity (CoTU), an organisation of the Kuki-Zomi communities, has announced a 48-hour shutdown in Manipur's Kangpokpi district, condemning the alleged abduction of two Kuki youth and demanding their safe and unconditional release.

The shutdown began at 5 p.m. on Thursday and will continue until 5 p.m. on October 31.

According to the CoTU, the two youth went missing around 5.30 p.m. on Wednesday while travelling between Hengbung and Taphou Kuki villages in the district.

Non-Kuki extremists are suspected to be involved in the "abduction" of Thangginlun Chongloi and Paominlal Chongloi, both 20-year-olds.

Rally in Arunachal Pradesh seeks release of protesters detained for stir against Siang dam

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI



A view of the charred remains of a vehicle after a protest against the proposed dam turned violent in East Siang on Saturday. ANI

Members of several youth and social organisations carried out a solidarity rally in Arunachal Pradesh's capital, Itanagar, on Thursday, demanding the release of people detained for opposing the push for a mega dam as a counter to China's massive hydropower project on the Yarlung Tsangpo.

More than 30 people were detained after a violent protest in the State's Siang region on October 23 and 24 against the proposed 11,200-megawatt Siang Upper Multipurpose Project (SUMP) on the Siang river. Local people say the project would spell disaster for the land and its people, but the government claims it would minimise the impact of a 60,000-MW project China is building across the border.

The Yarlung Tsangpo flows into Arunachal Pradesh as the Siang, which meets the Dibang and Lohit to form the Brahmaputra in Assam.

Protection of land

The protesters, who converged at Itanagar's Indira Gandhi Park, demanded protection of land, rivers, indigenous identity, and the locals' rights. They said they were not against dams, but they could not allow the government to bulldoze its way to build massive structures that threaten the people's existence.

"We, the victims of the proposed SUMP, are fighting for the protection of our land, fundamental rights, culture and existence. We are peace-loving Indians, but the government is treating us like second-class citizens," a leader of one of the local groups said.

'Drop the project'

The protesters asked the government to drop the SUMP plan and withdraw security personnel from the Siang region. "The government is trying to conduct the pre-feasibility survey for the SUMP by militarising the area," a protestor said.

A week ago, mobs opposing the proposed SUMP set fire to an office of the NHPC, which has been entrusted with preparing the pre-feasibility report for the project, and vandalised the houses of three politicians, including two MLAs. At least four women were injured in clashes with the police. The anti-SUMP agitation spread to the Upper Subansiri district, bordering China, where the NHPC is pursuing the proposed 1,605-MW Subansiri Upper Hydroelectric Project, also called the Menga Dam. Violence was reported from several areas, including Upper Subansiri district headquarters, during a 12-hour shutdown against the project on Monday.

Meanwhile, the Arunachal Christian Forum (ACF) expressed deep concern over the tensions surrounding the SUMP, appealing to Chief Minister Pema Khandu to take timely, constructive steps to maintain peace and promote dialogue among the parties concerned.

"We appeal to the government to initiate a process of meaningful and constructive dialogue with the Siang Indigenous Farmers Forum along with other concerned stakeholders to address apprehensions, reduce misunderstandings and prevent further escalation of tensions," the forum said in a statement addressed to the Chief Minister.

Corporate Ministry 'hijacked' NCLT staff appointments: SC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court of India on Thursday orally expressed concern that the Ministry of Corporate Affairs has "hijacked" staff appointments at the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT).

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said the power to make staff appointments must remain with the NCLT president, and an employer-employee relationship must prevail between the staff members and the tribunal.

'Hiring outsourced'

Senior Advocate Meenakshi Arora said the process of appointing staff members has been outsourced.

"I know how contractors play their hands. They don't care about judicial/technical members. Complete autonomy must be with presidents. They can take UPSC/SSC. The tribunal has been completely hijacked by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs. That is impinging on the autonomy of the institution. That is the problem. The Ministry wants to have a complete grip. That is most unfortunate," the Chief Justice orally remarked.

The observations were made while hearing a plea by contractual employees working in the NCLT and the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal.

The court directed the presidents of the two tribunals to submit within four weeks comprehensive proposals on infrastructure, buildings and staffing required to bolster the institutions' day-to-day functioning.

Kharge, Rahul to speak at CEC 'impeachment' event

Former Lok Sabha Speaker Meira Kumar to preside over proceedings; Opposition bloc to avoid imagery that could be seen as mocking Parliament; people affected by SIR to take part in event

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI



Key event: Former Lok Sabha speaker Meira Kumar, Congress leaders Jairam Ramesh, K.C. Venugopal and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and others during a meeting of INDIA bloc leaders on Thursday. PTI

The "public impeachment" of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar planned by the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) over alleged electoral manipulation through the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls will avoid imagery that could be seen as mocking Parliament as an institution.

Sources told *The Hindu* that there are unlikely to be any impersonations, posters, or banners depicting the Prime Minister, the Home Minister, and the CEC. The programme is also likely to avoid any symbolic representation of the Treasury Benches.

However, there is no official word on how the event, intended as a curtain-raiser for the Sunday rally, will unfold on Friday afternoon at Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge's official residence here.

Sources said former Lok Sabha Speaker Meira Kumar is likely to preside over the proceedings, while Mr. Kharge, who is also the Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, is likely to move the motion against the CEC. Congress leader and MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra is said to be supervising the finer details of the public impeachment.

Timing for speech

Both the LoPs will get about 20 minutes, while the Samajwadi Party and Mamata-Trinamool Congress will get 10 minutes during these proceedings. Other parties will get five minutes each. Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi is likely to be the last speaker, the sources added.

Representatives of civil society, leaders of student organisations and people whose names have been left out of the electoral rolls are expected to attend the event. One leader from each political party is likely to speak on the issue.

On Thursday, Mr. Gandhi released a video appeal urging people to join the INDIA bloc's Chalo Dilli march at the Ramlila Maidan on Sunday.

"Don't worry about the police, don't worry about lathis – the BJP will not have the guts to try any of their antics. Come march with us – we will walk together to protect the Constitution, to protect the Indian nation," he said.

"I urge all student groups, regardless of your political affiliation – if you feel that India is under attack, if you feel you are under attack, your expression, your ideas, your way of thinking is under attack, come, and join us," he said.

BJP has lessons to learn from Uttar Pradesh Legislative Council elections

NEWS ANALYSIS

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI



The BJP bagged six out of the 11 MLC seats that went to the polls in Uttar Pradesh. Votes were counted on Wednesday. ANI

The results of the Legislative Council elections to 11 seats in Uttar Pradesh, including both Graduates' and Teachers' constituencies, have given the BJP much to ponder ahead of the Assembly election scheduled to be held early next year. The outcome suggests that the party may have to jettison more than half of its sitting MLAs going ahead.

The BJP bagged six seats and the Samajwadi Party five. Within this meta narrative, however, are worries for the BJP.

The first big takeaway for the BJP is that the results of the elections demonstrate that the 2024 Lok Sabha results may not be a fluke, when the SP, with 37 seats, brought down the BJP's handsome tallies of 71 seats in 2014 and 62 seats in 2019 to 33 seats in 2024.

In this Legislative Council elections, the SP not only retained the Varanasi Teachers' and Graduates' constituencies, it also won the Lucknow Graduates' constituency and the Agra Teachers' constituency that were previously held by the BJP.

Even in the Gorakhpur-Faizabad seat, the pocket borough of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the victory margin for the BJP was just 307 votes. There appears to be an overhang of certain grievances carried over from the 2024 Lok Sabha election that have not been addressed yet.

A BJP district office-bearer from Agra, speaking to *The Hindu*, said that the party's loss of seats in Agra and Lucknow was worrying.

"Congress not doing well is no surprise, just like a student who only studies on the eve of the exams, but the BJP is that *padakhu* [studious] student who studies through the year, so this performance does not match the preparations we make," he said.

Internal analysis

An analysis within the BJP after the 2024 election concluded that not changing many MP candidates may have cost the party. Therefore, there is talk that many sitting MLAs may be dropped in the party's final candidate list, amounting to a *tabula rasa* (clean slate) for the party.

This is just one part of the lessons from the Legislative Council elections for the BJP. They are a limited electoral exercise compared with the Assembly or Lok Sabha elections, but the educational qualifications required to both stand for the elections and vote in them point to the elite discomfiture with the BJP.

In the specific instance of Agra, the SP fielded Akash Agarwal, from the upper caste Vaish community, usually considered the backbone of the BJP's voter base. SP chief Akhilesh Yadav later even claimed that the letter 'A' in his formulation of PDA (*Pichhda* or backward, Dalit, and *Alpsankhyak* or minority) could be expanded to include the Agarwal/Vaish community. Some analysts feel that the anger among the upper castes on the University Grants Commission's social equity regulation is still simmering.

More than identity politics, the results also point to local irritations and anxieties. From estimations of what could be brewing beneath the surface, a course correction, which BJP never shies away from, may well be in order.

Cong. needs broader strategy to take on govt.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Amid a pause in the agitation seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and opposing the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls because of festivals, the Congress is preparing for a show of strength at the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) rally at the Ramlila Maidan in Delhi on Sunday.

Beyond the rally, however, the Congress and the wider Opposition bloc may need to recalibrate their strategy on the alleged "vote *chori* (theft)" campaign, which has overshadowed issues that affect voters' everyday lives – inflation, unemployment, youth distress, and alleged corruption.

The Congress Working Committee (CWC), which met on August 19 in the aftermath of students' protests against paper leaks and demands for the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as the Union Education Minister, had identified several core issues.

These included the "plight" of the youth, alleged donation theft at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, reports of Chinese incursions into Arunachal Pradesh, and concerns over E20 petrol's lower mileage, compatibility risks and the loss of consumer choice.

Focused on SIR

However, the principal Opposition party and the INDIA bloc have focused almost entirely on alleged vote theft and electoral manipulation through the SIR since reports emerged that two Election Commissioners differed with the CEC over the implementation of the electoral roll revision exercise.



Congress leaders Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi during a protest against CEC.

On October 12, Rahul Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, likened the Opposition's protests against vote theft to Lord Shiva's *tandav* (cosmic dance). "There is no need for a plan. A dance is going on, Lord Shiva's dance. And anyone can join Shivji *ki baraat* [the wedding procession of Lord Shiva]," he said.

While the Opposition parties have continued their street protests against the CEC and the SIR, there is also a realisation that the fight against constitutional bodies such as the Election Commission of India is likely to be a prolonged one. The Opposition also needs to raise issues that are closer to people's everyday realities or have the potential to put the government on the defensive in the immediate term.

The U.P. story

In Uttar Pradesh, for instance, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav is keen to focus on donation theft in Ayodhya alongside the SIR.

At a tea party on October 13 at Mr. Gandhi's official residence, Opposition leaders discussed raising other issues but agreed to keep the vote theft campaign at the forefront to avoid losing momentum.

Recent social media posts by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, however, reflect a subtle shift, with inflation during the festive season being linked to "vote *chori*". "The Modi government, desperate to strip away voting rights, now wants to eliminate the right to live as well. Amidst festivals, back-breaking inflation is gobbling up every single penny of earnings," Mr. Kharge said in on X on Wednesday.

On Thursday, responding to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's jibe over the Congress's performance in ballot-based MLC elections across 28 seats in four States, Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh asked him to reflect on the BJP's losses in Varanasi, his parliamentary constituency, and Nagpur, an RSS stronghold.

The Congress leader urged Mr. Modi to address inflation, unemployment, and stalled private investment. "Drop the arrogance and reflect on these issues!" Mr. Ramesh said.

Cong. questions delay in framing charges in temple donation case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Questioning the delay in framing charges against the eight accused over alleged donation theft at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, the Congress on Thursday also asked why former temple Trust officials Champat Rai and Anil Mishra were witnesses and not accused in the case.

Charges could not be framed for the third time, Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said in a post on social media platform X, while questioning the delay in providing the complete CCTV footage and audio recordings.

"Whose secrets will be exposed if the full video footage and audio of the Ram Mandir come to light?" Mr. Ramesh said, alleging that the Bharatiya Janata Party government was protecting those responsible for the alleged misappropriation.

Mr. Ramesh said CCTV footage had captured 105 instances of donation money being removed. He also cited audit warnings issued in 2020, a video of the alleged theft that surfaced on June 4, and an FIR registered on June 25.

The Congress demanded an independent and impartial investigation under the Supreme Court's supervision and sought a comprehensive account of the donations. Targeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi for his silence, Mr. Ramesh asked why he was avoiding accountability despite taking credit for the temple's construction.

Modi to release PM-Kisan funds today

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will release the 24th instalment of the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-KISAN) on Friday in Banaskantha, Gujarat.

Over ₹18,690 crore will be transferred directly to the bank accounts of more than 9.34 crore farmers, the Union Agriculture Ministry said on Thursday.

The Prime Minister will also inaugurate 521 units established using the Agriculture Infrastructure Fund to strengthen agricultural storage, processing and related infrastructure, and 12 horticulture clusters to promote high-value horticultural crops. The previous instalments of PM-KISAN transferred more than ₹4.47 lakh crore to farmers.

Azam Khan, son get bail in dual PAN cards case

Press Trust of India
PRAYAGRAJ

The Allahabad High Court on Thursday granted bail to Samajwadi Party leader Azam Khan and his son Mohd. Abdullah Azam Khan in the 'fake' passport and dual PAN cards case. The court also suspended their sentence but refused to stay the conviction. Justice Samit Gopal passed the order allowing their applications seeking suspension of sentence.

The case stems from an FIR lodged in 2019 by BJP leader Akash Saxena, now an MLA, alleging that Abdullah Khan had two PAN cards containing different dates of birth and gained undue benefits through their use. In November last year, additional chief judicial magistrate of the Rampur court had pronounced them guilty of forgery, cheating, using forged documents and criminal conspiracy.

Congress beats BJP in Nagpur as MVA wins 3 MLC seats

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The illusionary bubble of Modi and Fadnavis has burst, says Maharashtra Congress chief

In a setback to the BJP, the Congress on Thursday won the Nagpur Division Graduates' constituency. The results were declared in the early hours. Nagpur is home to the headquarters of the RSS.

Of the four other Maharashtra Legislative Council constituencies that went to the polls, the NCP (SP), which is part of the Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi, won two, while Mahayuti allies BJP and Shiv Sena won one each.

While the NCP (SP) called for going back to ballot papers for holding elections, the BJP called for introspection among the alliance partners.

"The illusionary bubble of Modi and Fadnavis has burst. MVA has registered a resounding victory in three seats in the Legislative Council elections," Maharashtra Congress chief Harshawardhan Sapkal said.

He said that despite having money and muscle power, the BJP stood defeated."In the city of RSS headquarters, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, the Congress has defeated the BJP for the second consecutive term," he said. The Opposition hit out at the BJP over its "arrogance" and "overconfidence". It targeted Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis over a deleted post on X, which had responded to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's post asking how many seats Congress had won in the elections held on ballot paper.

Journey to a Viksit Bharat depends on participation of citizens too: former V-P

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



> By 2047, we must ensure there is no hunger, atrocity, discrimination, or disparity...Progress is reflected not merely in economic metrics, but in societal well-being, unity
>
> **M. VENKAIAH NAIDU**
> Former Vice-President

Former Vice-President M. Venkaiah Naidu on Thursday called on citizens to uphold constitutional duties, civic values, and collective responsibility in nation-building.

Delivering the keynote address at Mantrana, the flagship discussion series of think-tank Bharat Ki Soch, Mr. Naidu said India's journey towards 'Viksit Bharat by 2047' depended as much on citizen participation as on governance and economic progress.

"Policies provide the vision, but citizens' actions determine the pace and success of the outcome," he said. While the government must ensure effective governance, infrastructure, and growth opportunities, citizens must also share the responsibility of upholding constitutional values and fulfilling their civic duties, he added.

"By 2047, we must ensure there is no hunger, atrocity, discrimination, or disparity. True progress is reflected not merely in economic metrics, but in societal well-being, equity, and unity," said Mr. Naidu.

He said true patriotism lies in diligently performing one's duties, and he urged the youth to dream big, work hard, and actively contribute to national development.

Stating that India's demographic dividend would be vital to its journey towards a Viksit Bharat, the former Vice-President encouraged young people to acquire global skills, gain international exposure, and bring that expertise back to fuel the nation's growth.

He added that putting the nation above all differences was key.

Mr. Naidu felicitated the winners of the Jan Chetna 2026 debate and essay competitions.

RJD and BJP share MLC poll honours; rumblings in JD(U)

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) in Bihar won the Darbhanga Graduates' constituency in results announced on Thursday, with its candidate Anil Jha defeating the BJP's Sarvesh Kumar.

The win put the principal Opposition party on a par with the ruling BJP at two seats each, even as Janata Dal (United) and Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) won one seat each and Independent candidates triumphed in two of the eight seats at play in the Bihar Legislative Council election held on October 23.

Differences within the JD (U) surfaced on Thursday when its winner, Neeraj Kumar, refused to seek blessings of senior party leader and Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh.

Mr. Lalan Singh did not



Neeraj Kumar

campaign in support of Mr. Neeraj, who will become an MLC for the fourth successive time from the Patna Graduates' constituency, and was seen as being soft on MLA Anant Singh after being asked to mediate over the legislator campaigning against Mr. Neeraj and in support JSP candidate Anuj Singh. On October 24, Mr. Anant Singh and his wife Neelam Devi were expelled from the JD(U) for six years.

JD(U) working president Sanjay Kumar Jha said the party will take action against more rebel leaders soon.

INBRIEF



HC seeks ED stance on Lalu's plea in money laundering case

The Delhi High Court on Thursday asked the Enforcement Directorate to respond to RJD leader and former Railway Minister Lalu Prasad's petition challenging a trial court order on the framing of money laundering charges against him in a case related to the alleged IRCTC hotel scam. The court issued a notice to the agency on Mr. Prasad's petition against the trial court's September 10 order. The ED case arises from an FIR by the CBI, which has alleged that Mr. Prasad entered into a criminal conspiracy with the owner of Sujata Hotels and IRCTC officials for "undue pecuniary advantage to himself and others" between 2004 and 2014.

29 unrecognised parties from Gujarat record ₹510-cr. income

Twenty-nine Registered Unrecognised Political Parties (RUPPs) from Gujarat recorded the highest reported income of ₹510.41 crore during the Financial Year 2024-2025. This was followed by ₹218.48 crore by 73 parties in Delhi and ₹173.36 crore by 23 RUPPs in Rajasthan, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR). Together, the three States accounted for nearly 80.67% of the total reported income of ₹1,118.494 crore of all 734 RUPPs whose audit and contribution reports were available on the respective State Chief Electoral Officer's websites. The ADR report analyses the status of submission of annual audit reports and contribution reports of RUPPs as well as their electoral performance.

Post-cyclone, heavy rain wreaks havoc in Odisha

More than 200 villages in 22 blocks across Ganjam and Gajapati districts severely affected; roads washed away, villages marooned, three rivers in spate, and paddy crops nearing harvest damaged

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR



A drone view of a flooded area in Berhampur in Ganjam district of Odisha on Thursday. PTI

Heavy rain triggered by Cyclone Arnab wreaked havoc in Ganjam, Gajapati, and Kandhamal districts of Odisha on Thursday, washing away roads, marooning villages, and triggering landslides, as State officials struggled to restore normalcy.

The rainfall recorded in the three districts was among the highest ever recorded. "Exceptionally heavy rainfall occurred over south Odisha during the past 24 hours, ending at 8.30 a.m. on Thursday. The highest rainfall of 546 mm was recorded at Patrapur (Ganjam), followed by 503 mm at Sorada (Ganjam), 462 mm at G. Udayagiri (Kandhamal), 458 mm at Mahendragarh (Gajapati), 388 mm at Sanakhemundi (Ganjam) and 309 mm at Chikiti (Ganjam)," the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said.

A stretch of the National Highway 326 connecting Berhampur with Mohana was washed away by swirling floodwaters, disrupting road connectivity. Road infrastructure also suffered extensive damage in Gajapati district. The hilly terrain compounded the situation, as torrents of rainwater rushed downhill into low-lying areas, triggering landslides and damaging infrastructure.

In Ganjam district alone, 42,500 people were marooned by floodwaters, while 11,000 people were shifted from vulnerable areas to designated shelters.

Coast Guard steps in

With roads cut off and hundreds of villages inundated by floodwaters in Ganjam, the State government roped in the Coast Guard to airlift stranded people.

"In response to a distress call received from the Ganjam district administration on the morning of October 29, 2026, the Coast Guard Air Enclave, Bhubaneswar, scrambled an ALH Mk-III helicopter despite severe weather conditions," the Coast Guard said in a statement.

"Despite challenging conditions, the aircrew located the heavily inundated Public Health Centre in Jagmohan, where people were stranded by floodwaters following the storm. Hovering precisely over the submerged area, the crew successfully winched six people, including two women, two children and an elderly person, to safety," the statement said.

The cyclonic storm triggered widespread rainfall across the southern and southwestern districts of Odisha. More than 200 villages in 22 blocks across Ganjam and Gajapati districts were severely affected. The Rushikulya, Vansadhara and Mahendratanaya rivers were in spate.

Besides disrupting normal life and transport, the floods also damaged paddy crops nearing harvest in parts of southern Odisha, dealing a blow to farmers.

Petition filed in SC against post-NALSA regulatory regime

Abhinay Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The PIL argues that document change regime 'dilutes' the rights, protections, and entitlements meant for 'biological females'

A public interest litigation (PIL) plea in the Supreme Court has argued that the regulatory regime developed in India on the back of the landmark 2014 *National Legal Services Authority* (NALSA) judgment that recognised transgender identity is "grossly discriminatory" against "biological females".

The PIL plea filed by the India chapter of the U.K.-based Women's Declaration International (WDI) argued that the document change regime also "dilutes" the rights, protections, and entitlements meant for "biological females," and further impinges on the right to freedom of speech and expression by compelling all citizens to "express belief in gender identities".

The trust, which describes itself as a "feminist, non-partisan, all-volunteer and all-female organisation advocating for the rights, dignity, safety, and freedom of women", is seeking to overrule key portions of the *NALSA* judgment, specifically, the portion that ruled that legal recognition of gender identity constituted a part of the right to dignity and freedom guaranteed by the Constitution of India.

A Bench led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Wednesday issued notices to the Union Ministries of Social Justice and Empowerment, Law, and Health and Family Welfare on the plea. The WDI has argued that while people have a right to "believe in gender identities and hold and express these internal experiences", the regulatory regime that has developed in India through the years since the 2014 judgement has legally recognised gender identity by "overwriting the sex marker in official documents with the person's professed internal experience". It added that this change in "sex marker" has been allowed to propagate into other identity documents like Aadhaar, voter ID, passports, and birth certificates, which has "come at the cost of women's rights to equality, dignity and freedom".

Cancer drug price cuts must reach patients, says former National Health Authority chief

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI



Indu Bhushan

The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority's (NPPA) decision to cap trade margins on 137 anti-cancer medicines is an important step towards reducing the financial burden of cancer treatment, but its success will depend on whether the savings reach patients, Indu Bhushan, healthcare policy expert and former CEO of the National Health Authority, said.

In an exclusive interview with *The Hindu*, Dr. Bhushan said the intervention could substantially reduce costs for patients requiring prolonged treatment. The revised prices are to take effect from November 9.

"The immediate priority should be ensuring that hospitals and pharmacies pass these benefits directly to patients," he said, stressing that uninterrupted availability of medicines is equally important.

The government has introduced the reduction through trade margin rationalisation rather than a direct cut in manufacturers' prices. Under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order, 2013, the NPPA has capped trade margins at 30% of the maximum retail price, excluding applicable GST, for the identified non-scheduled anti-cancer medicines. The measure targets excessive mark-ups across the distribution and retail chain.

However, affordability remains a major challenge. According to a 2023 study involving over 12,000 cancer patients in India, the average annual out-of-pocket expenditure was approximately ₹3.31 lakh per patient. Costs vary depending on the type and stage of cancer, treatment requirements, and the hospital providing care. Families also face expenses on travel, accommodation, and lost income.

India could make cancer care more affordable without compromising medicine quality or pharmaceutical innovation by leveraging generic drugs, biosimilars and domestic manufacturing, while ensuring that lower prices do not weaken manufacturing and testing standards.

For expensive patented medicines, Dr. Bhushan advocates negotiated prices, voluntary licensing where appropriate, and assessments of the additional clinical benefit offered by new treatments.

"The objective is not simply the cheapest medicine. It is the best health outcome at a price that patients and the health system can sustain," he said.

Drawing on his experience in implementing Ayushman Bharat-Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PM-JAY), Dr. Bhushan said financial protection cannot be achieved through price regulation alone. Cancer treatment often extends over months or years, with substantial expenditure incurred outside hospital admissions on medicines, diagnostic tests, consultations, and follow-up care.

Strategic purchasing is also essential, with treatment packages reflecting clinical complexity, quality, and the actual costs of care. Rates set too low could discourage good hospitals from participating, while poorly designed packages could encourage unnecessary procedures or inappropriate treatment.

Dr. Bhushan also stressed the need for greater public investment in cancer prevention, early detection, pathology, radiotherapy, and specialised cancer centres.

"The ultimate objective should be straightforward – no patient should be denied effective cancer treatment because of an inability to pay, and no family should be pushed into poverty because someone has cancer," he said.

Female tiger relocated to Bengal reserve on Oct. 2 moves to Assam

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA



The tigress crossed the Sankosh river and a road in Assam likely in search of a suitable habitat.

A three-year-old female tiger which had been relocated to the Buxa Tiger Reserve in West Bengal from Bihar on October 2 has crossed into the Raimona National Park in Assam, officials say.

According to the officials, the female tiger, BTR-TF-1 (T-138), crossed the Sankosh river and a road in Gosaigaon in Assam to enter Raimona on Sunday, mostly in search of a suitable habitat.

"Once relocated, it takes a tiger a few times to explore its surroundings and establish its own territory. This female Royal Bengal tiger is also just exploring," West Bengal Forest Minister Manoj Oraon said.

Forest officials from Assam and West Bengal, along with a team from the National Tiger Conservation Authority, are monitoring its movement through the radio collar. The Minister said there was no plan yet to tranquillise it and bring back to Bengal. "It is a tiger's natural habit to explore. We don't want to disturb the tiger or restrict its movement immediately," he said. Buxa was declared a tiger reserve in 1983, but over the past few years there was no tiger presence in the region.

Bengal bars teachers from contesting elections

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Newly appointed teachers in government-run and government-aided schools will no longer be able to engage in politics directly and contest elections in West Bengal. This decision was taken at a cabinet meeting led by Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari in Nabanna on Wednesday.

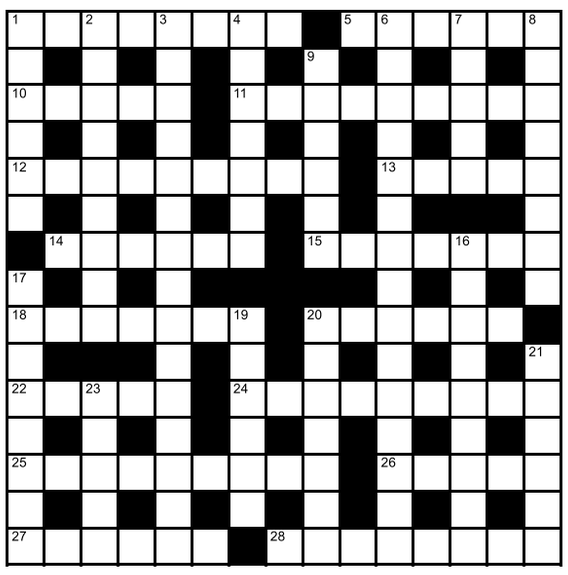
"We have made a very important decision. In other states of the country, government teachers cannot directly participate in politics. The West Bengal government took a historic decision in the cabinet today. From today onwards, all the new teachers who will be appointed through the School Service Commission will not be able to participate in any direct politics," Mr. Adhikari said.

TH CROSSWORD + 14936

(set by Dr. X)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

1 Screams hysterically about a murder (8)
5 Associate works out after gaining weight every time (6)
10 Cavort with European after consuming cocaine (5)
11 Marshal protects a witness (9)
12 Crazy men entering a dangerous Indian city (9)
13 US-Canada defence org. destroyed a drone leaving base (5)
14 Rubbish heap outside fine flat at entrance (6)
15 Recital at opening with medley of flutes is soothing (7)
18 One way or another, escort entertains old male on vacation (7)
20 Former US president's overture to Epstein in tabloid article (6)
22 Starts to holler about vile oppressor causing mayhem (5)
24 The best thing on menu - our rolls (6,3)
25 One captivated by perfect maiden (9)
26 Nervous novice lacks confidence, primarily sheepish (5)
27 Robust model eating special pork meatloaf (6)
28 Come to rest after hosting large shindig at centre from dusk till dawn (3-5)

Down

1 Monsieur's wife is nuts about me (6)
2 Fantastic singers receiving close to twenty million for working together (9)
3 Where paunchy person's belt buckle might be better than average (5,2,3,5)
4 Upset about blood relation being ridiculous (7)
6 Start to dance in the raw, loosen up! (3,4,4,4)
7 Concerning some daft errors (5)
8 Sit astride seat, holding sides of tusker (8)
9 Ogle after drinking whiskey on date, becoming more lascivious (6)
16 Presenting extremely fine American code-breaker (9)
17 Like a small hotel acquired by firm (2,6)
19 Improvise with cleverness to enthral stylish girl (4,2)
20 Modify social media clip about member's retro party (7)
21 Secret desire to have a little romp (6)
23 Repairs anatomical vessel to save military policeman (5)

SUDOKU

	1	4	6			3		
		7					1	
	6			1		9	2	
7			3		9	5		
3			8		5			1
		6	2		1			9
	7	9		5			6	
	3					7		
		8			6	2	5	

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

S	T	O	P	C	O	C	K	
C		D		A		O		N
H	O	O	D	L	U	M		E
I		U		U		M		A
S	C	R	U	M		O	B	N
M		S		N		N		D
			A	I	R	F	R	E
A		S		E		R		R
S	A	T	I	S	F	A	C	T
S		O				C		H
O	R	C	H	E	S	T	R	A
R		K		V		I		L
T	H	E	R	E	T	O		M
E		R		N		N		A
D	E	S	I	S	T		I	N

W	H	I	L	S	T			
	E		A		R			
E	L	L	I	P	S	E		
	I		J		A			
N	O	X	I	O	U	S		
D				I		U		
E	S	H	E	N	E	R		
R		O		T		Y		
C		H		K		A		S
A		N	E	P	A	L		
		O		L		E		
M	A	S	T	O	I	D		
A		E		M		G		
I	N	E	D	I	B	L	E	

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

4	7	6	3	5	8	9	2	1
3	9	5	1	2	4	7	8	6
8	2	1	6	7	9	5	3	4
5	3	7	2	4	1	8	6	9
1	6	9	5	8	7	2	4	3
2	4	8	9	6	3	1	5	7
9	8	3	4	1	5	6	7	2
7	1	2	8	3	6	4	9	5
6	5	4	7	9	2	3	1	8

FAITH

Mercy of Lord Srinivasa

Swami Vedanta Desika in his composition "Dayasatakam" describes Lord Srinivasa's quality of *daya* (mercy). Valayapettai Ramachariar Swamy said in a discourse that praising the Lord's mercy is equivalent to praising the Lord Himself. Dayasatakam begins with the word *Prapadye*, which refers to *saranagati* (surrender), takes the form of a salutation (*namaskriya*), or denotes supreme faith (*maha vishwasam*), as mentioned in the Rahasya Trayasaram. He takes refuge in an insentient mountain (*girim*) which lacks consciousness and cannot grant boons. Why does he surrender to a mountain? Will it help in accomplishing a goal? Doubt arises.

Swami Desika answers in just two words: *tam girim*, meaning "that mountain." *Tam* (that) in the Upanishads refers to the Supreme Lord of Tirumala Hills. Tirumala is not an ordinary mountain. It is known as Venkatam. *Vem* means sins, *katam* means driving away. It burns away all our sins. Periyazhwar praises Lord Srinivasa as honey, milk, sugar-candy (*kannal*), and nectar. Lord Srinivasa is compared to sweet sugarcane (*kannal*).

The juice of that sugarcane is *daya* (mercy). That mercy overflowed, settled, and crystallised into a rock candy (*kalkandu*). That rock candy is none other than the Tirumala hill. Throughout the Dayasatakam, the quality of mercy is narrated by various names: *daya, kripa, karuna*, and *anukampa*. Lord Srinivasa trembles out of empathy when His devotees suffer. Swami Desika does not surrender to ordinary stone, but to the crystallised embodiment of Lord Srinivasa and Goddess Mahalakshmi, which is the combined mercy of *divyadampatis* (the divine couple).

Can new fortified potato variety help with India's hidden hunger problem?

Kufri Jamunia is a purple skinned and fleshy potato with higher levels of certain nutrients compared to regular potatoes; at present, however, taking into account its production costs, pricing, uptake in the market and its ability to deliver these nutrients, it is unclear if it can help with hidden hunger

Vasudevan Mukunth

Scientists at the ICAR-Central Potato Research Institute (CPRI) have developed a new potato variety called 'kufri jamunia' that has higher levels of anthocyanins, vitamin C, and certain micronutrients than regular potatoes. The Central government has been promoting it of late as a means to address hidden hunger, i.e. when people consume enough calories but still do not receive the necessary nutrients.

Usually, experts who fortify foods, focus on items like rice and iodised salt, which a large number of people in India consume, often throughout the year, thus ensuring the added nutrients are delivered to a significant chunk of the population. Kufri jamunia is however a potato, which people in India generally consume much less consistently than rice or salt, and the micronutrient intake depends on preparation methods and how the body absorbs them.

Kufri jamunia offers nutritional advantages, but they are substantial in some aspects more than others. Questions also linger about its ability to resist disease and retain nutrients through different Indian cooking methods.

The variety reportedly has a mealy texture. In one CPRI assessment involving 64 people, 95% rated its overall acceptability 'good to excellent' and 56% said its taste was very good. This study cohort, though, is too small to generalise the results. CPRI researchers themselves have proposed that kufri jamunia can be used in curries, parathas, soups, baked goods, and dehydrated flours.

Importantly, kufri jamunia potatoes also have purple skin and flesh, which could affect consumer interest. Research on other biofortified foods has already shown that while people are generally willing to pay modest premiums – the national average cost of ordinary potatoes purchased wholesale is around ₹17/kg – whether they accept a new variety depends on its appearance, their awareness, taste, and of course local preferences.



Solving an issue: The variety reportedly has a mealy texture. CPRI researchers themselves have proposed that kufri jamunia can be used in curries, parathas, soups, baked goods, and dehydrated flours. THULASI KAKKAT/PIB

How was is developed

The CPRI team developed the kufri jamunia variety by crossing two potato lines, MS/8-1148 and CP4242, in 2015. MS/8-1148 is high in vitamin C whereas CP4242 had purple skin and flesh. The result, formally called MSP/16-307, could naturally accumulate higher concentrations of specific nutrients as it grew. The team then conducted trials, including multi-location testing, in 2021-2023.

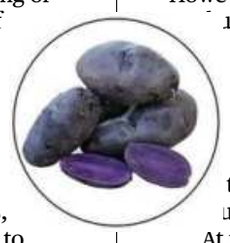
Based on the trial data, the Central Sub-Committee on Crop Standards, Notification and Release of Varieties for Horticultural Crops approved the variety in mid-2024 and the government notified it in November that year. The variety's plants produce 10-12 medium to large tubers each and mature in around 90 days. The purple colour comes from anthocyanins – organic compounds also found in jamun and blueberries.

According to the Press Information Bureau, 100 g of kufri jamunia flesh contains around 42.75 mg of vitamin C (versus 23.15 mg in regular potatoes), 42.05 mg of anthocyanins, 2.28 mg of zinc (versus 0.28 mg), 3.22 mg of iron (versus 0.57 mg), and 161 micrograms of carotenoids. And per the CPRI team's findings themselves, published in *Potato Journal* in 2025, 100 g of kufri jamunia was found to have a range of carotenoid levels, from 15.6 micrograms in Kanpur to 298.4 micrograms in Raipur, during the multi-location trials. Kufri jamunia also contains slightly less zinc than kufri neelkanth and slightly less iron than kufri manik; the latter are other coloured potato varieties developed at the Institute.

Anthocyanins are known to have antioxidant properties, although whether the same benefits will accrue when delivered by kufri jamunia potatoes is not known. And in the absence of similar studies, the same caveat goes for iron and zinc. A 2016 study in *Food Chemistry* examined purple-fleshed potatoes and reported that steaming and microwaving generally preserved more of the nutritional substances than stir-frying did.

A 2016 study examined purple-fleshed potatoes and reported that steaming and microwaving generally preserved more of the nutritional substances than stir-frying did

However, again, research specific to kufri jamunia is not available.



Cultivation factors

Nutrient availability and delivery constitutes one half of a biofortification programme; the other half is determined by cultivation.

At the Modipuram research station, according to the *Potato Journal* paper, the team recorded an average yield of 49.01 tonnes per hectare after three months, across three seasons, whereas subsequent multi-location trials, including at Modipuram, recorded an overall mean of 31.96 tonnes per hectare across north (36.77 tonnes), central (33.79 tonnes), and eastern (25.91 tonnes) India.

On the other hand, at these locations, kufri manik yielded 31.52 tonnes per hectare and kufri neelkanth 36.61 tonnes per hectare. Further, kufri jamunia could moderately resist late blight, a disease caused by the water mould *Phytophthera infestans*, in laboratory conditions but has been reported as 'susceptible' in the field. Late blight is a devastator of potato crops and the CPRI team has already recommended that farmers apply fungicide.

Next, the multi-location trials also produced 29.19 tonnes of marketable potatoes per hectare, versus 33.48 tonnes for kufri neelkanth. So if the costs of cultivation were equal, kufri jamunia farmers could need a 15% premium on the selling price to attain the same gross revenue. (A study published by a CPRI in *Indian Horticulture* in 2020 estimated that, for regular potatoes, the seed material accounted for 40-50% of the production costs vis-a-vis regular potatoes, with a per-hectare seed cost of around ₹60,000-75,000 per hectare.)

Taken together, there are many unknowns about kufri jamunia at this point to assess its overall cost-benefit ratio, including the cost of seeds and disease management, pricing, its uptake in the market, and how efficaciously it will deliver iron and zinc to the population. It would be premature as a result to deem kufri jamunia to be a proven solution to address India's hidden hunger.

(mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in)

THE GIST

The CPRI team developed the kufri jamunia variety by crossing two potato lines, MS/8-1148 and CP4242, in 2015. MS/8-1148 is high in vitamin C whereas CP4242 had purple skin and flesh. The result, formally called MSP/16-307, could naturally accumulate higher concentrations of specific nutrients as it grew

The variety reportedly has a mealy texture. In one CPRI assessment involving 64 people, 95% rated its overall acceptability 'good to excellent' and 56% said its taste was very good. This study cohort, though, is too small to generalise the results. CPRI researchers themselves have proposed that kufri jamunia can be used in curries, parathas, soups, baked goods, and dehydrated flours

Nutrient availability and delivery constitutes one half of a biofortification programme; the other half is determined by cultivation. Taken together, there are many unknowns about kufri jamunia at this point to assess its overall cost-benefit ratio

SNIPPETS

Latest updates from the world of health

Open access to peptides



Reuters

U.S. Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. has pushed forward a policy allowing licensed pharmacies and physicians to compound certain unapproved peptides while regulators consider whether to formally permit their use in compounded medicines.

Published in the Federal Register as Mr. Kennedy's "enforcement discretion policy," it enables U.S. compounding of six peptides, including the BPC-157 and TB-500 – popularly known as the "Wolverine stack" – without fear of FDA reprisal.

U.S. funds for Ebola vaccine



Reuters

IAVI, a biomedical research organisation, said on Wednesday it was awarded $36 million under a U.S. government contract worth up to $99 million to advance development of its single-dose vaccine candidate against the Bundibugyo strain of the Ebola virus.

The number of confirmed Ebola cases in Democratic Republic of Congo has risen above 10,000, government data showed on Tuesday, making the Bundibugyo outbreak the country's largest and deadliest outbreak.

Dutch govt.'s bird flu curbs



Reuters

Farmers across the Netherlands have been instructed to keep poultry indoors following three reported bird flu outbreaks.

"The risk of further infections is significant. To prevent as much suffering as possible for both animals and business owners, I have decided to implement a nationwide requirement to keep birds indoors or otherwise shielded," Minister Silvio Erkens said.

Detections typically increase during the fall and spring, when migrating birds can spread virus to domestic poultry.

How brain imaging offers a crucial window to identify, assess and treat wake-up strokes

Serena Josephine M.

Time is brain, when it comes to the treatment of strokes. But a stroke occurring during sleep may go unnoticed until a person wakes up with symptoms, leaving doctors without a clear timeline of its onset. This is where brain imaging helps doctors identify patients with wake-up strokes and assess the extent of injury to pave the way for prompt treatment. Neurologists underscore the need to seek medical care immediately to ensure timely treatment.

M. Radha, head of department and professor of neurology, Government Kilpauk Medical College (KMC) Hospital, Chennai, said that the prevalence of wake-up strokes is 20% – one in five ischaemic strokes is a wake-up stroke. "This means a person wakes up from his/her sleep with symptoms of stroke. The symptoms include facial drooping, difficulty speaking, sudden vision problems and weakness on one side of the body," she said.

If a patient arrives at a hospital within 4.5 hours of stroke symptoms, then thrombolysis can be done, she said, adding: "However, in wake-up stroke, we cannot calculate the time of the onset of symptoms. We do not know the window. So, acting fast is important. In case of any symptoms, patients should reach the hospital on time."



BE FAST is the acronym to spot the signs of a stroke: Balance, Eyes, Face, Arm, Speech and Time. GETTY IMAGES

Role of imaging

In wake-up strokes, imaging helps give a clear picture for the doctors. "An MRI brain scan should be taken immediately. If it is not available, a CT angiogram should be taken. The scans help us assess the extent of brain injury and blood flow to different parts of the brain. They can determine whether there is diffusion-perfusion mismatch. The difference may represent brain tissue that is still salvageable and can be potentially saved. Like in regular strokes, 'time is brain' in wake-up strokes too, making prompt diagnosis and treatment crucial," she explained.

Shubha Subramanian, senior consultant - neurology, Kauvery Hospitals, Chennai, said that in ischemic strokes, thrombolysis is used to dissolve the blood clot if a patient presents within 4.5 hours of symptom onset. "In cases involving a large vessel occlusion, mechanical thrombectomy is performed within 24 hours of symptom onset, depending on the patient's eligibility. In wake-up strokes, we do not know when the stroke started; it could be at night or early in the morning. What we do next is crucial. This is why we rely on imaging techniques," she added.

"MRI has a lot of sequences. If you compare the diffusion-weighted imaging and FLAIR (Fluid-Attenuated Inversion Recovery) imaging, a mismatch in that shows that the brain tissue is still salvageable. So even if we do not know the time of onset of stroke, we can still go ahead and thrombolyse the patient. In the same way, MRI perfusion or CT perfusion studies will also give us a clue regarding salvageable brain tissue. This will help us in taking crucial decisions regarding thrombolysis or mechanical thrombectomy or whether to go for conservative management," she elaborated.

Under the Tamil Nadu Accident and Emergency Care Initiative and Stroke Care and Rapid Intervention with Plasminogen activator and Thrombectomy (SCRIPT) programme implemented by the State government and with facilities available at the new JICA building at KMC, patients with with wake-up strokes are regularly treated, Dr. Radha noted.

"There is effective coordination between the administration, the emergency department, radiology and neurology departments. We have a green channel in place. As a result, once the patients with symptoms of stroke enter the Emergency Department, the neurologist is intimated. Our doctor goes to the radiology department which has significantly reduced the door to needle time," she said.

BE FAST is the acronym to spot the warning signs of stroke, denoting Balance, Eyes, Face, Arm, Speech and Time. "We do see that the awareness of stroke symptoms is increasing and the referral system has also improved," Dr. Radha said.

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Deemed ineligible

The Supreme Court has pointed to the SIR's flaws by design

At Wednesday's hearing of a petition on the Delhi SIR in the Supreme Court, Justice Joymalya Bagchi asked questions that cut to the heart of the Election Commission of India (ECI)'s SIR of electoral rolls. If an existing voter was "lax, inert or did not respond" to enumeration forms, was that a ground for the ECI to "forfeit his or her right to vote forever"? The Bench headed by the Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said that the ECI was in "error" to force such voters, struck off for not returning enumeration forms, to reapply on Form 6 as if they were new voters. It asked why voters who had shifted residences could not just disclose details and why deleted voters could not fill enumeration forms belatedly. This is the central design flaw of the SIR as it shifts the burden of enrolment from the state to the elector, including those who have voted before, and treats a mere change of address as ground for deletion. The share of draft deletions recorded as "shifted" or "absent" rose from 55% in Bihar to 72% in States/Union Territories in Phase 3. In Karnataka, about 84 lakh electors were deleted, marked as "shifted" or "absent" during enumeration. But only a net of 8.2 lakh, including new electors, were added during the claims phase, with the final roll being 64.5 lakh short of the projected adult population. Requiring moved voters to re-register as fresh applicants defeats the ECI's historic mandate of widening the franchise, which was inherent in the 2002-03 intensive revision, where enumerators enrolled shifted voters at their new homes and the Chief Electoral Officer reconciled the old entries.

Justice Bagchi also mentioned that the Bihar judgment was not a "binding precedent" and that the legality of "logical discrepancy" checks, allowed only as an "interim arrangement" in West Bengal, had not been finally adjudicated. No statute or rule provides for judging a voter's eligibility on the basis of family size or the age gap between voters and parents, which were two of the ECI's ludicrous and algorithm-driven "logical discrepancy" checks. In West Bengal these checks resulted in massive disenfranchisement and *The Hindu*'s analysis found that in Delhi, Muslims were disproportionately flagged. But the Court should not merely issue managerial fixes such as extended deadlines or displaying printed lists in blocks, as it has in the past. The final SIR rolls are erroneous as deletions flowed from a flawed design rather than just lapses by the ECI. The dead and duplicate entries that the SIR identified should be removed and newly eligible electors added. Voters wrongly removed from draft rolls must be included again. The larger questions over the Commission's SIR conduct and how its members are appointed must also be settled.

Open to probe

Public functionaries must not use privacy to seek exemption from scrutiny

The Digital News Publishers Association's (DNPA) challenge to the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, and its Rules, has drawn attention to concerns that a law to safeguard informational privacy risks creating a serious chilling effect on the media. The absence of a specific exemption for journalistic activity could subject reporters investigating official misconduct or corruption to the obligations of a "data fiduciary", requiring them to notify and seek consent from the very individuals they are investigating. Such onerous requirements could affect investigations undertaken in the public interest. The implications extend to routine newsgathering too, where personal information is integral to reporting. The omission is particularly consequential because the drafts in 2018, 2019 and 2021 carried a journalistic exemption. The Act already provides exemptions for certain forms of data processing, including for research and statistical purposes, making the denial of similar protection to journalists difficult to justify. Non-compliance can attract penalties of up to ₹250 crore, posing an existential threat to smaller and independent newsrooms. The DNPA petition also challenges Section 44(3), which amended the RTI Act, 2005, removing the earlier public-interest qualification concerning disclosure of personal information. The protection of personal information must not be absolute; an overriding public interest must remain a legitimate ground for disclosure, particularly when the information is held by public authorities. Investigations into corruption often rely on asset disclosures and tender documents containing personal data. Restricting access to these records risks reducing journalism to merely reproducing government releases.

The Supreme Court, while issuing notice on the petition, rightly emphasised the need to balance press freedom with the right to privacy. Although journalists in India enjoy no specific statutory protection for their work, freedom of the press is constitutionally protected under Article 19(1)(a). The Court has also shielded newspapers from arbitrary state restrictions. However, growing mistrust of legacy media and the rise of independent content creators have made it difficult to determine who receives such protection. The Centre has also flagged this concern. Yet, carving out distinct categories is no easy task – a 2026 Reuters Institute report shows that the proportion of 18- to 24-year-olds identifying social media as their primary source of news rose from 21% in 2015 to 39% in 2025. A purely legalistic determination of these competing concerns may perhaps prove too onerous. Stakeholders must build consensus on a mutually acceptable framework where public functionaries and those handling public funds are not insulated from scrutiny under the guise of privacy. Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw's indication that he would meet editors is a welcome step towards consensus.

The examination overload, its enormous cost



Furqan Qamar

Vice Chancellor of the Integral University Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh. He was the Secretary General of the Association of Indian Universities (AIU), Vice Chancellor of the Central University of Himachal Pradesh and University of Rajasthan, and Adviser (Education) in the Planning Commission

Once upon a time, not very long ago, students could focus on their education, confident that their academic results would determine admission to higher education and career opportunities. Today, millions of young Indians face not one examination but a cascade of them – a seemingly endless series of entrance examinations. Besides board examinations, aspiring engineers and doctors generally face entrance tests such as the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE) and the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET), respectively. Architecture and law aspirants must also navigate examinations such as the National Aptitude Test in Architecture (NATA) and the Common Law Admission Test (CLAT). Others must take the Common University Entrance Test (CUET) or institution-specific examinations. With affordable, quality higher education in short supply, many candidates make repeated attempts. Even a good bachelor's degree does not guarantee postgraduate admission.

Postgraduate aspirants face examinations such as the Graduate Aptitude Test in Engineering (GATE), Common Admission Test (CAT), Common University Entrance Test for Postgraduate Programmes (CUET-PG) and various university-level entrance tests. Research aspirants face further qualifying examinations, including the National Eligibility Test (NET). The ordeal continues during recruitment. Academic qualifications merely establish eligibility, while employment often depends on examinations conducted by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), State Public Service Commissions, Staff Selection Commission (SSC) and Institute of Banking Personnel Selection (IBPS). The proliferation of entrance and recruitment examinations has turned education and employment into a relentless cycle of competitive testing.

The cost of competition

Each of these layers of examinations demands months of separate preparation, payment of separate coaching fees, and unexplainable suffering and distress. Somewhere in this labyrinthian relay race, the very examinations that were supposed to certify students' learning, abilities and achievements have been rendered irrelevant. It is time to ask a blunt question: why do we need all these additional gates when the school and university leaving examinations already exist to measure merit?

Separate examinations for admission and jobs were declared inevitable because school board and university examinations were argued to suffer from a lack of uniform standards and their susceptibility to manipulation and rampant use of unfair means. The argument assumes that the new layers of examinations would be free from these deficiencies. The on-the-ground experience has only proven that the designed cure is worse than the disease itself.

Public examinations are marred by allegations of paper leaks and other unfair practices, such as dummy candidates, mark manipulation, and merit garbling, leading to repeated cancellations. Each incident wastes public money, delays admissions and recruitment, and erodes faith in the fairness of the system.

> India's obsession with layers of examinations must end, and the focus must return to the forgotten value of sustained academic performance

Centralised counselling for seat allotments complicates the process. They also multiply anxiety, stress and mental trauma. Layering examination upon examination rather than distributing this pressure forces students to spend their entire adolescence running an unbroken loop of a preparatory marathon.

Additionally, such examinations entail exorbitant costs that ultimately fall disproportionately on families who can ill afford them. Children from the economically weaker and marginalised sections of society struggle to manage and often cannot. Far from being neutral arbiters of merit, these examinations have come to reward the ability to pay for preparation rather than raw ability or diligence in school.

Youth frustrations may have reached a tipping point, compelling them to take to the streets. Several States have seen protests of varying scales. It remains to be seen whether the proposed strengthening of the law against unfair practices in public examinations and the recommendations of the high-powered committee constituted in July 2026 will address these systemic deficiencies.

The present system of layered examinations suffers from design defects and systemic deficiencies. The National Testing Agency's continuing difficulties, despite a comprehensive review by a committee headed by a former space scientist in 2024, have raised questions about the effectiveness of the reforms. The constitution of another high-powered committee, in 2026, underscores the persistence of these concerns.

We are still thinking only of reforming this broken system without stopping for a moment to ask a critical question: how can we trust centralised public examinations conducted by agencies that have repeatedly failed to fulfil their responsibilities when we cannot trust years of assessment by teachers throughout a student's course of study?

Why bear such a heavy burden when, academically speaking, these layers of examinations cannot possibly substitute for the regular assessment of knowledge acquired over years of study? At most, they can evaluate candidates on a much narrower, often more coachable skill: ticking off the answer choices quickly under pressure in a specific question format, while disregarding years of demonstrated cumulative academic performance.

The result is a strange inversion. Students no longer study to learn; they study to clear filters. Classroom teaching has been relegated in favour of coaching-centre drilling. The board examination becomes a formality, and we have ended up with a system where the credentialing examination that ought to matter most – the one tied to actual classroom learning – now matters the least.

Merit already exists, use it

It makes sense to fix the school and higher education system, which has long been broken and continues to be hammered, causing further damage. Now is the time to focus on restoring the credibility of school and university examinations. Whatever their imperfections, these examinations are not arbitrary, as they assess knowledge acquired over years of study, involve continuous evaluation and are moderated by boards and universities with established standards. With some investment, they can become far better and more reliable measures of merit.

A student's Class XII marks or university Cumulative Grade Point Average (CGPA) already reflect years of consistent performance – a far more holistic and harder-to-game measure of ability and diligence than a single high-stakes examination. If board and university examinations are inconsistent across States or institutions, the answer is to standardise and strengthen them through normalisation, common moderation frameworks, external audits and periodic score equating, rather than building an entirely separate examination system on top of them. If admission committees and employers doubt the rigour of certain boards or universities, those doubts should be addressed by reforming the assessment standards of these institutions, rather than requiring every student in the country to run a second, third or fourth race, regardless of where they studied.

Admissions to higher education institutions ought to be based on standardised and moderated school-leaving examination results. Scholarships and fellowships should be awarded on the basis of academic performance and track records. Recruitment to public services could be based on verified academic records and structured interviews. At most, a single national test at each exit level of the educational hierarchy could be conducted to assess students' scholastic aptitude, with the scores used to moderate board or university examination results.

Global practices

This is not a radical proposal by international standards. Many countries admit students to university primarily based on their school-leaving results, supplemented by references and essays, with marginal weight assigned to scores in language and scholastic aptitude tests. It is India's exceptional layering of tests, often to assess the same competency, tested repeatedly by different bodies, that is the outlier.

The argument for dismantling India's entrance and recruitment examination pyramid is not an argument against standards. It is an argument that standards already exist, embedded in the school and university systems which India has spent enormous public resources building, and that repeatedly re-testing the same students for the same underlying competencies wastes money, invites corruption, and causes real harm to the wellbeing of young people. Reforming and trusting the examinations India already has would do more to promote genuine merit than adding yet another layer of examinations ever could.

A security deal, but not the end of the Arctic contest



Sakti Prasad Srichandan

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The agreement signed between the United States, Denmark and Greenland on September 22, 2026, marks an important moment in the changing geopolitics of the Arctic. Greenland is an autonomous part of the Kingdom of Denmark. Under the 2009 Self-Government Act, it has extensive control over its domestic affairs, while foreign, defence and security policy remain with Denmark. Greenland came into the news this year because of the Trump administration's repeated interest in gaining control over the island. What began as a territorial controversy gradually became a wider debate about sovereignty, security and the future of the Arctic.

The agreement, signed at the United Nations, expands the American military presence in Greenland while reaffirming Danish sovereignty and Greenland's right to self-determination. It brings, at least for now, an end to the unusual tensions between Washington and Copenhagen over the future of the strategically important island. The agreement's entry into force is subject to the completion of the necessary parliamentary procedures in Denmark and Greenland.

Not a territorial deal

The agreement is essentially a security deal, not a territorial deal. The U.S. has, for the moment, moved away from its earlier demand to acquire Greenland. Instead, Washington has secured greater military access to the island. The agreement allows the expansion of the existing Pituffik Space Base and provides for additional American defence facilities at Narsarsuaq in southern Greenland and Mestersvig in the east, subject to mutually agreed arrangements. American aircraft and ships will have wider access to Greenlandic territory and waters for defence purposes. The important point is simple. Greenland has not changed hands. But the American military presence there is likely to become much larger. The agreement shows how quickly the Arctic is becoming a strategic region. Greenland sits in a crucial location between North America and Europe, a geography that matters for missile warning, space surveillance and the security of the North Atlantic. It is becoming more important as Arctic sea routes open up and competition over resources grows. The agreement includes cooperation related to the proposed Golden Dome defence system. It also places restrictions on investments from countries outside the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), NATO partner countries and the European Union (EU) in certain sensitive sectors. Economic activity in the Arctic is therefore increasingly being viewed through the lens of national security.

> The Greenland agreement strengthens American security while raising sovereignty concerns

Denmark's balancing act

For Denmark, the challenge was particularly difficult. Copenhagen had to protect its sovereignty over Greenland while avoiding a prolonged confrontation with Washington. The agreement gives Denmark a way to do both.

American military involvement will increase, but within an arrangement that formally recognises Danish sovereignty and Greenlandic self-determination. Greenland's Prime Minister Jens-Frederik Nielsen has also stressed the importance of NATO in Arctic security. The deal brings greater American involvement into Greenland without formally changing its political status.

Yet, the question of sovereignty remains complicated. The agreement recognises Greenland's right to self-determination. It refers to respect for Greenlandic society and its traditional way of life. At the same time, it gives the U.S. extensive military access and introduces restrictions on foreign investment in sensitive areas. The agreement has no expiry date. Some of its provisions would also remain in place even if Greenland becomes independent in the future, creating an unusual situation.

The Arctic's transformation

The Greenland episode tells us something about the future of the Arctic. The region is no longer only about climate change, scientific research and polar exploration. It is now closely linked to missile defence, critical minerals, infrastructure, shipping routes and space security. Russia's military presence and China's growing economic and scientific interests have already changed the strategic environment. But Arctic competition can also create tensions among allies themselves.

For Denmark and Greenland, the agreement provides a way out of a difficult diplomatic situation. For the U.S., it provides greater strategic access without formal annexation. For NATO, it underlines the growing importance of the High North.

But the real test will come later. The question is whether greater American military involvement can strengthen Greenland's security without reducing Greenlanders' control over their future. As Greenland is likely to remain important, its people will have to balance the opportunities that greater international attention brings with the risks of becoming the centre of great-power competition. The way Denmark, the U.S. and Greenland manage this balance will shape the island's future. The answer to that question will ultimately determine the real importance of this agreement.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The right to vote

While maintaining an updated electoral database is a administrative necessity, transforming procedural non-compliance into a mechanism for permanent disenfranchisement is inherently punitive. To dictate that an individual's temporary oversight or bureaucratic inertia should result in the absolute forfeiture of their fundamental right to vote is a distortion of the constitutional mandate. The franchise is an unalienable democratic pillar, not a conditional privilege to be revoked under the guise of rectifying a "logical discrepancy". Furthermore, compelling historically validated citizens to reapply under the strictures reserved for completely new electors creates an artificial hurdle that undermines civic participation. The judiciary's timely intervention (Page 1, October 29) serves as a critical reminder that administrative efficiency must never be achieved at the altar of citizen disenfranchisement.

Nagarajamani M.V.,
Hyderabad

Lathering up excuses

The assertion by the Tamil Nadu Environmental Minister that the massive blankets of toxic foam floating on the Noyyal river in Tiruppur are caused by soap and shampoo used in households is not only the height of comedy but also a sign of his ignorance. This bizarre narrative is a desperate, risible deflection from the real culprits: the rampant, unregulated discharge of untreated effluents from local dyeing and textile units (Tamil Nadu, October 29).

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Are youth worried they will be worse off than their parents?

PARLEY



Gilles Verniers

is a political scientist and researcher at CERI Sciences Po, Paris



Rohit Azad

teaches at JNU and specialises in political economy

Europe is seeing a wave of protests against economic inequalities and poor living standards. The immediate causes vary across countries, from the housing crisis in Spain and issues with the education system in France to public anger over perceived corruption in Serbia and Albania. But one thing is common: youth at the vanguard. Europe always had space for democratic dissent and has seen major protests to influence state systems and public policy. But with more and more youth taking the streets across the continent and beyond, are these protests merely reactionary, or is there a generational, existential anxiety at play? Are youth worried they will be worse off than their parents? Gilles Verniers and Rohit Azad discuss in a conversation moderated by **Vighnesh P. Venkitesh**. Edited excerpts:

Is the current wave of protests a cyclical outburst of generational aspirations, and can it be compared to developments in previous generations like the 1968 protests in Paris?

Gilles Verniers: There are, of course, parallels between the May 1968 Paris revolt and the current wave of protests that are happening in France. Like 1968, it started with students protesting about conditions in educational institutions before gradually spreading into a broader revolt. What began in mid-September with a high school student protesting teacher shortages and so forth has become a nationwide movement about inequality and the cost of living. That said, there is a key difference between 1968 and now: one wanted more freedom; the other wants a future.

Is there an economic stagnation happening around the continent and maybe beyond, and is that what is translating into these protests?

Rohit Azad: Unlike 1968, there is a withdrawal of the State now. The Left was in ascendance then; you had Vietnam fighting a war against U.S. imperialism. The 1968 protests were about pushing a welfare state further to the left. Whereas now, forget about the welfare state; people are demanding basic facilities that the state should provide. It is a crisis of the neoliberal model. So, the two contexts are completely different. In France, the unemployment rate among those aged 15 to 24 is slightly above 20%. That, along with the rising cost of living, falling real wages, and severe cutbacks in public expenditure, definitely becomes the backdrop against which today's movement is taking place.



A call for change: French school and university students protest, demanding better school conditions and government action, on October 15. REUTERS

GV: I completely agree with that. The context in which young people have grown has been a succession of crises. It is what one calls a polycrisis mindset. This generation has lived through the 2008 financial crisis, COVID-19, climate disasters, war in Europe, and now AI, and they are yet to turn 25. And so what they are seeking, first and foremost, is more protection from the state and not more freedom from the state, as it used to be the case before.

Several state systems that exist now have been shaped by the post-war situation in Europe and the fall of the Soviet Union. Is there a generation gap that exists between the current system and youth, creating a rift?

GV: There is a generational gap, not just in terms of age, but in terms of values, priorities, and ways of organising. Older institutions are hierarchical. The youth movements now are leaderless. The gap between the age of the political class and the median age in a country is often very wide. In Europe, you have a large majority of voters who are ageing and want to protect the pension system and the welfare state while schools crumble, literally. There is strong divergence in terms of needs.

RA: I would stress the fact that digital life itself amplifies anxiety, because you are constantly comparing across generations, your global peers, and with the elites. The information gap that would have been there when you did not have a digital life versus what you have now – you can see the inequality right in your face.

GV: And it is a good illustration that social media cuts both ways. Obviously, they function as an amplifier of anxieties. But they also provide a space and the instruments for organisation and

> The context in which young people have grown has been a succession of crises. It is what one calls a polycrisis mindset
> **GILLES VERNIERS**

counter-mobilisation. What is really interesting in this movement is the constant reinvention of new modes of organising and resistance against illiberal regimes, far-right movements, and so forth. The very instrument that sort of generates and amplifies anxieties is also the instrument that allows youth to combat it.

Talking about Serbia and the leaderless aspect of the movements, the current wave has seen students or youth coming together at the spur of the moment. How will a leaderless movement fare against the established state systems?

RA: Even though it was a leaderless movement, the Serbian protests continued for two long years in terms of mobilisation. There were ups and downs, like Lenin said, "One step forward, two steps back," but they were at it no matter what. That is not to say leadership does not matter, but I think when people are up in arms, the leadership question kind of recedes into the background.

GV: And being leaderless proves to be an asset way more than a liability, because the moment you have designated leadership, they become targets. The Serbia case is very striking because they succeeded in toppling down democratically a right-wing illiberal regime. It creates a precedent. But every movement is confronted with very specific national context and conditions, and they may not necessarily produce the same outcomes everywhere.

We see there is a pessimism setting in around AI interventions and the looming climate crisis. Every generation has had its own anxieties, like the Cold War or the fear of a nuclear apocalypse in the 1960s and 1970s. Are the anxieties a cycle, or are youth justified in envisioning a bleak future?

GV: The pessimism in some aspects has a factual, scientific basis. We have data about the rise of inequalities, concentration of wealth and power, climate disruption, and so forth. And we know, at least in Europe, many young people expect to do worse than their parents on housing and pensions and job security. As I said before, their experience of the world is that of a polycrisis. What is sort of different today is that even the conventional avenues for upward social and economic mobility are affected. In the current situation, particularly with AI, it is entry-level, white-collar jobs – the traditional first rung of the 'ladder '– that look more exposed. And that sort of adds to that sentiment of bleakness. Now you have the 'elite segment' of the population who have started to struggle as well and use their social capital to build or participate in these movements. But the struggle for people has been very long in the making.

RA: As far as AI is concerned, there is a double whammy for the youth. One, it has come on top of general economic stagnation, which means low employment generation to begin with. Two, whatever little growth is there, it is increasingly becoming capital-intensive. For both these reasons, the youth see a bleak future.

Coming to the climate crisis, I would say that is the biggest example of generational injustice. The older generations have contributed the most to global warming, but it is the young who are going to suffer the most. I think that creates a kind of resentment against the older generation.

In a late-stage capitalist system or structure, is the youth movement acting as what Lenin put it as a vanguard party?

GV: I think the historical conditions are different. Those vanguard parties of the old days had very coherent ideological clarity that these movements do not necessarily have. The movement today has an element of an alliance of students and workers, but we are not talking about factory workers anymore in Europe. We are talking about a completely scattered, anomic, precarious, salaried class, which has been at the wrong end of the effects of neoliberalism. And so, I would say the conditions are a little bit too different for seeing it as a simple repetition of history.

RA: I do not even know why history should be repeated. I would say that vanguardism had a role at that point in time. Maybe we need a different kind of politics, which is more inclusive, which may have the ideology of the left or broad issues that the left would like to raise, but something which is not centralising in terms of either ideology or in terms of organisation.

To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
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NOTEBOOK

The changing address of power

T.N.'s search for a new Secretariat has spanned successive governments; TVK's latest proposal to build one near the coast has revived the debate

B. Kolappan

Covering the Secretariat beat and the Assembly proceedings was traditionally reserved for senior journalists in every newspaper. But at *Dinamani*, its editor, RmT Sambandam, did not believe in rigid rules. He sent a bunch of rookies, including me, to Fort St. George, known as *kottai*, which housed the Secretariat, to cover the Assembly proceedings.

He would send us off with one instruction: "Go and introduce yourself to the man sitting in the first seat in the journalists' lobby." He was referring to the *The Hindu* journalist, invariably the seniormost among the organisation's journalists and, in a sense, among those covering the Assembly. The next seat was allotted to *The Indian Express* – now *The New Indian Express* – followed by *Daily Thanthi*, and then *Dinamani*.

I covered the last session of the AIADMK regime in 1995 and started going to the Assembly regularly after the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) was elected to power in 1996, with M. Karunanidhi, fondly called Kalaignar, occupying the Chief Minister's seat. Jayalalithaa, who had been defeated, was not in the House. I missed the face-to-face exchanges between Karunanidhi and his political rival, Jayalalithaa. Still, we had a great time.

The Tamil Maanila Congress (TMC), launched by G.K. Moopanar and an ally of the DMK, had occupied the main Opposition benches. The bonhomie between the two parties eventually turned bitter. The TMC launched a new front during the 1999 Lok Sabha elections and joined hands with Jayalalithaa's AIADMK in the 2001 Assembly election.

By then, I was representing *The New Indian Express*, sitting next to *The Hindu* in the Assembly.

It was then that the construction of a new Secretariat became a matter of concern for journalists. When Jayalalithaa announced plans to shift the seat of power to Tiruvidanthai on the ECR, journalists, including me, dreaded the prospect of travelling miles to cover the Assembly proceedings and the Secretariat beat. But she gave up the proposal in the face of opposition and instead sought to build a Secretariat complex on the site where Queen Mary's College now stands. That also met with stiff resistance, and she decided to continue functioning from Fort St. George.

After he won again in 2006, Karunanidhi began looking for a place to construct a new Secretariat and Assembly complex. The DMK government zeroed in on the site where the old Admiralty House and MLA hostels stood, just opposite *The Hindu* on the arterial Anna Salai. By the time I joined *The Hindu*, I had moved into the first seats in the journalists' lobby.

The construction of the new complex progressed at a breakneck pace, as Karunanidhi wanted to occupy it before the 2011 election. The dome crowning the building was not ready in time for the inauguration, so art director Thota Tharani was brought in to create a replica.

The Secretariat proved extremely convenient. But the journalists' lobby was shifted to the first floor.

During the last session of the Assembly, when O. Panneerselvam was functioning as Chief Minister after Jayalalithaa was disqualified by the courts, he declared that his party would return to power and that the new government would function from Fort St. George. His words proved prophetic.

There was no talk of a new Secretariat or Assembly complex for the next 10 years. Even when the DMK returned to power in 2021, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin chose to work from Fort St. George. He planned to move the seat of government to Pooncheri, a place near Mamallapuram. But that did not materialise.

Now, once again, the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) government has proposed constructing a new Secretariat, this time close to the Chennai seashore. But the proposal has already run into rough weather.

It remains to be seen whether the government will heed the Opposition's objections and shelve the plan or go ahead with it. I, however, will be spared the prospect of travelling to a new building, as I will no longer be in service by the time its construction is completed.

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PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Battling the waves



Disaster response personnel restore a road washed away by waves during Cyclone Arnab at Uppada coastal village in Kakinada district, Andhra Pradesh on Thursday. V. RAJU

FROM THE ARCHIVES
The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 30, 1976

Indian Navy Submarine in Madras

Madras, Oct. 29: Even as preparations are under way for the Navy Day celebrations, INS Karanj, one of the larger submarines of the Navy is on a routine visit to Madras.

The Russian-made INS Karanj which is described as an advanced conventional submarine belongs to what is perhaps the most powerful arm of the Indian Navy. It has mine-laying capabilities and with its torpedoes packs a lot of punch. It came into the harbour two days ago.

A submarine is said to be more vulnerable than other ships, and it is essential that all the systems in it are continuously monitored and that any defect is set right immediately.

The crew is kept on their toes throughout with emergency drills.

The boat is powered by diesel engines when it cruises on the surface, but underwater it has to draw power from its batteries. For sighting, it is equipped with a periscope, radar, and sonar equipment.

Going into a submarine through its hatch is like going down into a deep mine. The cigar-shaped boat is divided into watertight segments and is so crammed with machinery that there is hardly any space to move about.

For the crew, life on board is very different from that in other warships. Here they are tightly packed and sleep on bunks placed between pieces of machinery.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 30, 1926

Depression in cotton industry

Bombay, Oct. 29: Representatives of the Ahmedabad Millowners' Association were examined by the Tariff Board (Cotton Textile).

Replying to the Chairman, they stated that during the last two or three weeks the condition of the textile industry had changed for the worse. Owing to the heavy drop in cotton prices, cloth merchants had lost their confidence. The purchasing power of the agriculturists was also going down and the phenomenal fall in American cotton prices had accentuated depression in the cotton industry, but did not affect textile industries of America and Japan to any extent. On the other hand, they were making profits. The drop in cotton prices during the last two or three years had been gradual, and it was admitted that the bumper cotton crop of America accentuated the depression.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Worth of spices seized by Maharashtra FDA till October 29

19.70 in ₹ crore. The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has seized 11,963.87 quintals of spices and spice products worth ₹19.70 crore after inspecting 1,057 establishments between April 1 and October 29, officials said on Thursday. The FDA also said it has issued 557 improvement notices during the period. PTI

Special buses to be operated by Himachal ahead of Deepavali

266 The Himachal Road Transport Corporation will operate a total of 266 special buses on November 6 and 7 to help people of the State reach their homes during the Deepavali festival, Deputy Chief Minister Mukesh Agnihotri said on Thursday. The special buses would be run from Delhi, Chandigarh and Baddi to different parts of Himachal Pradesh. PTI

Persons held across Assam in crackdown against child marriage

560 More than 560 people have been arrested in the latest crackdown against child marriage across Assam, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said on Thursday. He had earlier said the State government's efforts in the past few years led to over 12,000 cases being registered, more than 11,000 arrests, and an 81% drop in child marriages across 20 districts. PTI

Minors rescued from child labour in Delhi's Gandhi Nagar

19 Nineteen children, including five below the age of 14, were rescued from garment and artificial jewellery factories in east Delhi's Gandhi Nagar area, where they were allegedly made to work for as little as ₹10 a day, an official said on Thursday. Nine factory owners have been apprehended and nine factories sealed following the crackdown. PTI

Amount received by Rajasthan farmers in crop insurance claims

345 in ₹ crore. The Rajasthan government has facilitated the payment of nearly ₹345 crore in pending crop insurance claims to farmers across nine districts, officials said on Thursday. Agriculture Commissioner Naresh Kumar Goyal said around ₹318 crore was given to farmers in six western districts. PTI

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Concerns over the collegium system

Retired SC judge Justice Sanjay Kaul has shared that former CJI D.Y. Chandrachud may have discussed proposed judicial appointments with the Centre before the collegium met to discuss them, prompting a broader debate on the evolution of the collegium system and ways to improve transparency in judicial appointments

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The Story so far:
Retired judge of the Supreme Court Justice Sanjay Kaul has shared that former Chief Justice of India (CJI) D.Y. Chandrachud may have discussed proposed names for judgeship with the Union Government even before the collegium met to discuss them. He characterised this as seeking the government's 'pre-approval', which erodes the judiciary's autonomy.

Provisions in the Constitution
Article 124 of the Constitution provides that judges of the Supreme Court shall be appointed by the President after consulting the Chief Justice of India (CJI). Similarly, Article 217 provides that judges of a High Court shall be appointed by the President after consulting CJI, Chief Justice of the High Court and Governor of the State. The original Constitution provided for consultation by the executive with the judiciary before appointments to safeguard judicial independence as well as to ensure quality, as judges are best equipped to assess the professional and technical merits of proposed candidates.

The collegium system
As per process laid down in the Constitution, judges were appointed by the government after consultation with the judiciary till 1980s. In the First Judges case (1981), the Supreme Court had upheld the primacy of executive in judicial appointments since it is accountable to the people. However, considering the need to maintain independence of judiciary and insulate it from political favouritism, the Supreme Court in Second Judges case (1993) created the collegium system for appointment of judges. This was reaffirmed by the Supreme Court's opinion in Third Judges case (1998). The collegium currently comprises the CJI and four senior-most Supreme Court judges for appointments to the Supreme Court, and the CJI and two senior-most judges for appointments to High Courts.



The collegium system for judicial appointments is a unique process devised by the SC. FILE PHOTO

The detailed procedure for appointment, as per the guidelines of the Supreme Court in Second and Third Judge cases, is captured in the Memorandum of Procedure (MoP) for appointment of Judges prepared by the Union Law Ministry in 1998. As per the MoP, the collegium initiates the proposal for appointment of judges to the higher judiciary and sends the recommendation to the Central government. The Centre may return a recommendation in case of any objection or reservation with respect to any of the proposed names. However, if the collegium reiterates the recommendation, the appointment should be made.

The Parliament through the 99th Constitutional Amendment in 2014 had set up the National Judicial Appointments Commission (NJAC) to provide recommendations to the executive for the appointment of judges. The NJAC was to consist of the CJI, two senior judges, Union Law Minister and two eminent persons. This was however struck down by the Supreme Court in 2015 as it violated the basic structure of independence of the judiciary. Hence, the collegium process continues till date for appointments.

After the NJAC judgement, the government and the judiciary agreed to revise the MoP to usher in more transparency into the appointment process. However, owing to differences of opinion on some of the aspects of revised MoP drafted by the executive, it has not been finalised even after 11 years.

International practices
The collegium procedure for judicial appointments is a unique process that has been devised by the Indian Supreme Court, that has no parallel in any other democracy.

In the U.S., judges to the Federal Supreme Court are nominated by the President and confirmed by the Senate.

In the United Kingdom, the independent Judicial Appointments Commission comprises 15 commissioners appointed from the judiciary, the legal profession, and the public. This JAC selects candidates for judicial office in courts and tribunals. Appointment of Judges to the U.K. Supreme Court (UKSC) is based on a selection commission that consists of President of the UKSC, a Senior U.K. judge, and three other members that includes a member of JAC.

In South Africa, there is a Judicial Service Commission (JSC) that consists of 23 members, including the Chief Justice and representatives from the judiciary, legislature, executive, lawyers and academia. This JSC recommends names to President for appointment of Judges.

The way forward
The collegium system has ensured the independence of the judiciary from the executive, in the matter of appointments. Nevertheless, it has its own drawbacks like the lack of transparency and accountability. There is also resentment on account of alleged nepotism in this process whereby kith and kin of sitting judges are favoured for appointment to higher judiciary. The immediate reform would be to finalise the revised MoP that would bring in the required transparency and consultative process in appointments.

The long-term reform could be to revive the NJAC with a broader composition. It can include representatives from the legislature, the Bar Council and academia, like in South Africa and the U.K. This would make the consultation process more broad-based and inclusive. The judiciary could still be provided with a veto over the final recommendation to protect its independence.

(Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified.' He currently trains at Officers IAS academy. Views expressed are personal.)

THE GIST

- The collegium system, devised by the Supreme Court, has ensured judicial independence from the executive in the matter of appointments. However, it has drawbacks, including a lack of transparency and accountability
- The long-term reform could be to revive the NJAC with a broader composition. It can include representatives from the legislature, the Bar Council and academia, like in South Africa and the U.K.

Assessing the outcome of MLC elections

The electorate for these polls represents only a section of voters, unlike in general and Assembly elections

Sanjay Kumar
Arindam Kabir

Discussions highlight too much emphasis being given to the recent Legislative Council (MLC) elections across States. Even a sweeping victory or defeat does not necessarily indicate a party's loss or gain in popular support. This is because the electorate in these polls represents only a section of voters, unlike in general and Assembly elections.

Across Uttar Pradesh, 11 constituencies went to polls while Bihar saw eight seats up for grabs. Maharashtra and Karnataka went to the polls in five and four constituencies, respectively.

MLC elections are held for the Vidhan Parishad, the Upper House of a State legislature, which exists in only six of the 28 States – Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. A council can have no more than one-third of the Assembly's strength and never fewer than 40 members. It is a permanent house that cannot be dissolved. Members serve six-year terms and one-third retire every two years, so elections are staggered rather than held all at once.

Members reach the Council by five routes. One-third are elected by MLAs, one-third by local bodies such as municipalities and district boards, one-twelfth by graduates and one-twelfth by teachers. The remaining one-sixth are nominated by the Governor from among people with distinguished work. Voting is by secret ballot under proportional representation by single transferable vote.

Graduate and teacher constituencies are territorial, and the Election Commission conducts the polls. A graduate voter must have held a degree for at least three years, and a teacher must have taught for at least three years in a secondary school or higher institution. Both must live or work in the constituency, and neither is enrolled automatically, since each has to apply to be placed on a separate roll. This is why these electorates are so small. The Council has limited powers, it cannot vote on money bills, and the Assembly can override its recommendations on ordinary legislation. That is another reason these results say little about who governs the State.

Although these elections do not reflect a party's overall electoral performance, their outcomes offer some insight into its organisational functioning and strength. Winning these seats requires identifying candidates, registering voters months in advance and mobilising a small electorate to turn out – tasks that depend on the party machinery, not a wave.

Congress opens account in Nagpur
With its win in one Nagpur seat, the Congress managed to gain some headlines and open its tally. But the party should take this as a lesson, having failed to open its tally even in Karnataka, where it is in power. The BJP-JD(S) alliance swept all four seats there. A ruling party is expected to have the State machinery, cadre and local connect to win at least a seat or two. Failing to do so suggests a gap between the government's position in Bengaluru and the party's organisational presence on the ground. Congress leaders may rightly say that the result is no verdict on the government. But a clean sweep in a State where the party is in power cannot be brushed aside.

BJP's victory and cause for concern
It is fair for the BJP to celebrate winning 13 out of the 28 seats, which does reflect the strong organisational strength of the party across States. What can be seen as a setback for the party is that the graduate voters' constituency has been BJP's stronghold. In the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, according to the Lokniti-CSDS National Election Studies 2024 post-poll survey, BJP alone enjoyed 38% support among graduates and above, while it was 45% for the NDA. A party that has long counted on the educated, urban voter will be concerned to see that cushion thinning.

The loss in five seats in Uttar Pradesh, particularly Varanasi, should be a warning bell for the BJP as the State goes to polls next year. The party's performance in Uttar Pradesh in the 2024 Lok Sabha election left it short of a majority on its own at the national level, forcing it to depend on allies. Varanasi is the Prime Minister's own constituency, making the symbolism hard to ignore, even though the stakes are modest. The BJP cannot afford a repeat in 2027, and any sign that educated, middle-class voters are drifting away will worry its strategists.

Jan Suraaj gains ground in Bihar
The party opening its tally in Bihar can be seen as a sign of its growing organisational strength, especially after its founder, Prashant Kishor, won the Bankipur by-election in August, defeating BJP's Neeraj Kumar by 19,324 votes in a seat the BJP had never lost since 1995. Jan Suraaj had failed to win a single seat in the 2025 Assembly election. Two wins in three months show a party that is converting its campaigning into votes. Whether that carries over to a general election, where it must reach a far larger and more varied electorate, remains an open question.

On that count, the Congress has work to do, the BJP has reason to be careful, and Jan Suraaj Party has reason to feel encouraged. The sensible reading of these results is a modest one; as a rule of thumb in studying elections, we should not overread the data. These elections do not show the will of the entire electorate, but they do indicate a party's organisational strength and mark an important move in boosting the morale of the party cadre.

(Sanjay Kumar is a Professor at CSDS and an election analyst; Arindam Kabir is currently a researcher with Sanjay Kumar at the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS). Views are personal.)

IN THE LIMELIGHT



A scene from the 2026 Tamil film *Dorothy*. SONY MUSIC SOUTH/YOUTUBE

Animals as symbols of caste, masculinity and human relations in *Dorothy*

The animals in Karthik Subbaraj's period drama appear in moments of vulnerability and violence; fighting roosters and rams mirror male aggression, while dung beetles guided by the cosmos contrast with people who have clearly lost their moral bearings

Vasudevan Mukunth

Dorothy, the Tamil film written and directed by Karthik Subbaraj, was released in theatres on September 25 and has taken viewers by storm. It is set in rural Madurai in the 1990s. It follows two young men, Subbu and Karthi, and the rigid ideas of masculinity and caste that test their friendship. When Dorothy arrives in their village, her presence challenges all their assumptions. Sananth, Rishikanth, and Keerthy Suresh play the principal roles, alongside Muthukumar as a powerful moneylender.

But as the humans of *Dorothy* impose their systems of domination and control on one another, try as they might, the natural world itself remains indifferent to the social hierarchies they consider so crucial.

Understanding the motifs

In a recent interview, Mr. Subbaraj said he based the motif of the rooster in the film – which Subbu names and nurtures – on his research into Bahuchara Mata, a Hindu goddess associated with transgender communities and whose mount is a rooster. A festival centred on this deity is a guiding light in the film. Mr. Subbaraj also said the motif inspired the cockfighting scenes, and that he included it both to represent a piece of the Madurai landscape and to connote a higher meaning.

Many of the other animals of *Dorothy* are similarly a part of the material world of rural Tamil Nadu, even as they represent the human relationships unfolding within it. Some of the animals people capture and slaughter, force to fight, or turn into weapons against other people.

On the other hand, the scorpion and the dung beetle act independently of human concerns, and in one serendipitous moment, set Karthi's and Subbu's shared journey on a very different path.

The skinned hare suspended from the ceiling in the house of Veeraiya, the local moneylender and Subbu's father, paints an obvious picture of vulnerability stripped of protection, not coincidentally displayed in the home of a man who controls other people through economic dependence and caste power. There is also a disturbing parallel between the hare and Dorothy herself. The house is not just a place where people destroy vulnerable bodies but also normalise the cruelty of such actions.

Masculinity and dominance

Members of Veeraiya's community also breed, train, and pit roosters and rams against one another for their entertainment. The visual meaning is obvious: it is the men that are really aggressive and territorial, seeking dominance over others. Their masculinity is animalistic. Yet all the cruelty we see on screen, especially all that matters to *Dorothy*, is entirely human, arising as it does from caste, property, honour, and gender expectations, rather than anything imposed by nature.

When the ram headbutts that poor man to death, an animal is becoming an instrument of human judgment. The violence is organised and conferred a social purpose, turning the scene into a commentary on the men, who have also conditioned themselves to fight and prove their masculinity.

But then there are also the dung beetle and the scorpion, and the expansive verdant backdrop.

Significance of the landscape

The animals in the film were computer-generated, and what the audience is asked to take away from their presence and actions in certain scenes is what the filmmakers have intended. That said, they themselves are not out of sorts with what we expect.

The landscape itself, from hilltop grasses to weeds in the dilapidated pond, from overgrown shrubs to forests in the distance, are real in both senses and just as important. As cinematographer Tirru said in an interview, the filmmakers deliberately placed people against these views to reveal the smallness of the men's egos and the irrelevance of their prejudices within the larger world.

The scorpion is mindless of human authority and, by being itself, accidentally frustrates Karthi's plan for a murder. When Karthi is treated for the sting, Subbu asks the doctor whether the poison has left his body – a question as much about the literal poison as the foul ideas filling his head and heart. The scorpion has thus become an agent of redemption.

Lost bearings

The dung beetle, finally, made a curious, even amusing, appearance. It has nothing to do with the plot yet it cuts perhaps the most memorable figure. It appears rolling a dungball as three men brawl in the background. The choice reverses our usual hierarchy of attention, which is to put ourselves and our needs first. But as the men risk their lives over their pernicious social expectations, rolling around in the figurative excrement they themselves have laid, the beetle simply gets on with its own, thoroughly unbothered.

Dung beetles also find their way using the moon and stars, being guided by the cosmos itself, whereas the people nearby have evidently lost their moral bearings.

Overall, the animals of *Dorothy* do not create a unified allegory. The cattle, for instance, are just there to reinforce the film's rural locale.

But even though they were simulated on a computer, many of the animals that do make an appearance, especially in moments of violence and vulnerability, deserve our attention.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Video game publisher Electronic Arts announced the closure of the beloved RPG studio BioWare last week. A quiz on their celebrated space-faring series Mass Effect

Mohammed Hidhayat

QUESTION 1
Banshees are Reaper-indoctrinated versions of which species?

QUESTION 2
Which composer, known for Requiem for a Dream, led ME3's score?

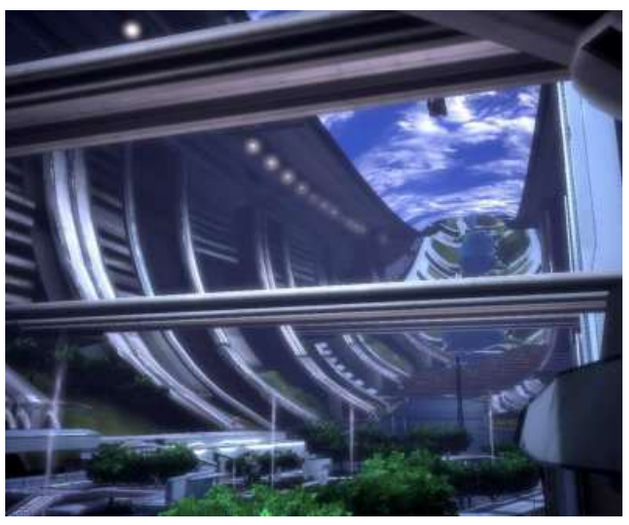
QUESTION 3
What is Garrus Vakarian's favourite activity?
a. Staring into the unknown b. Calibrations c. Dancing

QUESTION 4
Name the biological weapon developed to control Krogan population.

QUESTION 5
Fill in the blank. Quarians wear environmental suits because of a _____.

QUESTION 6
Who is the primary human antagonist that Shepard confronts near the ending? Name the actor who voiced the character.

QUESTION 7
Fill in the blank. The _____is a gigantic, worm-like creature believed to be inspired by Frank Herbert's Dune.



Visual question: Identify this enormous space station that serves as a central hub for galactic politics. BIOWARE

Questions and answers to the previous daily quiz: 1. The Workers' Party or the Partido dos Trabalhadores was formed in this year. **Ans: 1980**
2. Reason for Brazil's Congress and Supreme Court buildings being stormed in 2022. **Ans: Far-right candidate Jair Bolsonaro, the principal opponent of Lula, refused to concede the election and claimed that it was stolen/illegitimate. This led to his supporters storming the buildings**
3. Brazil's top political leaders were hit by scandal when this anti-corruption investigation exposed money laundering and corruption. **Ans: Operation Car Wash**
4. Significance of the number '13' in association with Lula. **Ans: In Brazil, voters punch in a two-digit number to cast their vote. Lula's official ballot number is 13**
5. In 2004, a New York Times article on President Lula infuriated him. Name the reporter and what the article said. **Ans: Larry Rohter; he said that President Lula had a drinking problem**
Visual: Here, Lula is seen with another global leftist leader and icon. Name the revolutionary leader. **Ans: Fidel Castro**
Early birds: Tito Shiladitya| Sudhir Thapa| Sunil Madhavan| Baburam Sapre| Suchit Narottam



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the difference between "dinner" and "supper"? (Nellai S. Murugan, Chennai)
The word "dinner" is normally used by Indians to refer to the meal that is eaten in the evening. Native speakers of English, on the other hand, use the word to refer to the main meal of the day. Some people have their main meal in the afternoon, while others have it in the evening. So what we call "lunch" may be referred to as "dinner" by native speakers of English. The important thing to remember here is that "dinner" is considered by some to be the most important meal of the day. "Supper", on the other hand, is something that is had only in the evening. And unlike "dinner", it is usually a very light meal. One can have it early in the evening or just before going to bed. Americans tend to use the word "supper" quite often. It is usually a meal eaten at home with members of the family. When you invite someone to have a meal with you in the evening, you usually ask them to have "dinner" with you, not supper.

How is the word "tete-a-tete" pronounced? (K. Sankara Narayana, Kurnool)
"Tete" rhymes with the words "date", "hate", and "late". In other words, the final "e" in the word is silent. The "a" which occurs in between is pronounced like the "a" in "bath", "path", and "mask"; the main stress is on the second "tete". Any idea what the word means? When you have a "tete-a-tete" with someone, you have a chat with him/her. A "tete-a-tete" is usually a private conversation between two individuals. Here are a few examples:

The Principal had a tete-a-tete with the Head of the English Department.

Rahul has a regular tete-a-tete with Shoba.

What is the meaning of the idiom "to be all thumbs"? (Keshav Murthy, Uduvalli)
When you say that someone is "all thumbs" what you are implying is that the individual is very clumsy when it comes to working with his hands. He is very awkward and keeps making many mistakes. A person who is all thumbs will not be good at things like painting, stitching, and sewing. Here are a few examples.

I never ask Govind to dust those expensive vases. He's all thumbs.

When it comes to catching, Das is all thumbs.

What is the meaning of "double whammy"? (K.P. Pillai, Kochi)
The expression "double whammy" first appeared in a cartoon strip, which was quite popular in America in the 1920s. Al Capp, the author of the comic strip "Li'l Abner" used this expression to refer to an intense stare, which had a withering effect on its victims. It's meaning has undergone a considerable amount of change since then. This is how slang dictionaries define "double whammy" – double the portion of something, especially something troublesome. When you get a "double whammy" of something, it is usually something really bad. Here is an example:

We thought he'd come alone, but he gave us a double whammy by bringing his wife and children.
Published in The Hindu on May 28, 2002

Word of the day

Fugacious:
lasting a very short time

Synonyms: ephemeral, passing, short-lived, transient

Usage: *The peace between the two countries proved fugacious as tensions soon resurfaced.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/fugacious

International Phonetic Alphabet: /fjuːˈgeɪʃəs/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



U.S. Federal Reserve holds rates despite sticky inflation

The U.S. Federal Reserve held its benchmark interest rates unchanged between 3.75% and 4.0% at its October policy meeting. The 12-member committee voted 10:2 for maintaining status quo while Governor Lisa Cook and Cleveland Federal President Beth Hammack voted in favour of a 25 basis points hike. The decision comes against the backdrop of sticky inflation with the central bank awaiting more economic data before changing the Fed Funds target range. The policy decision was broadly in line with market expectations, with Federal Reserve Chairman Kevin Warsh announcing the Fed would reduce the number of Federal Open Market Committee (FOMC) meetings beginning 2027. One of the FOMC meetings from next year will exclusively address broader monetary policy strategy than rate-setting.

Stock markets rebound over 1% on Fed interest rate pause

Indian equity benchmarks staged a sharp rebound on Thursday, recovering from recent losses as buying in the second half of the session lifted the indices, despite weak global cues and persistent foreign fund outflows. The Nifty gained 1.05% to close at 22,936.77, reclaiming the psychologically significant 22,900 mark, while the Sensex advanced 1.2% to settle at 74,151.04. "Despite volatility surrounding Sensex expiry, investor sentiment improved after the Fed kept interest rates unchanged," said Pabitro Mukherjee, deputy VP, research, Bajaj Broking. Higher U.S. interest rates tend to divert capital away from emerging markets such as India. Meanwhile, the rupee was under pressure, touching two-week low of 95.38 against the dollar before recovering to close nearly unchanged at 95.26. Foreign exchange traders attributed the recovery partly to likely dollar sales by the RBI.

SC rejects beneficiary disclosures of AIFs, FPIs without legal backing

Rapid expansion of Alternative Investment Funds, Foreign Portfolio Investors raises serious concerns over transparency, petition says; Supreme Court bench asks why MP wants to file public interest petition under Article 32 when she could have raised the issue in Parliament

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court refused to direct the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) to mandate full public disclosure of the details of ultimate beneficial owners who own and profit from Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs) and Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) operating within the Indian securities market.

A judicial order mandating full public disclosure of the individuals behind the AIFs and FPIs could not be justified without the support of an existing "legal framework of regulations," the court said.



AIFs, FPIs operated under opaque structures, says Moitra.

A three-judge Bench headed by Justice B.V. Nagarathna said it was ultimately for the Union government and the market regulator (SEBI) to put in a framework based on which the court could issue a mandamus for "full public disclosure". The court asked the Centre and SEBI to consider the need for bringing out suitable transparency Regulations.

"SEBI is the regulator. It has been granted certain powers. The situation in the country and in the international economy keeps on evolving," Justice D.K. Upadhyay said.

The court was hearing a writ petition filed by Member of Parliament Mahua Moitra, represented by advocates Prashant Bhushan and Cheryl D'Souza, who argued the rapid expansion of AIFs and FPIs in financial markets gave rise to serious concerns over transparency.

Unlike mutual funds, (MFs) which were subject to stringent public disclosure norms, AIFs and FPIs operate under opaque structures, raising risks of market manipulation, money laundering and tax evasion, the petition said.

AIFs registered with SEBI had risen over 30 times from 42 in 2013 to 1,528 in 2025, Ms. Moitra said. Their average Assets Under Management (AUM) had risen by more than 835 times from ₹1,437 crore in 2013 to almost ₹13 lakh crore by the end of 2024. Mr. Bhushan submitted Assets Under Custody (AUC) of registered FPIs was over ₹74 lakh crore in 2025.

In contrast, the total AUM of MFs in India was only about ₹68 lakh crore in 2025. While MFs were subject to strict public disclosure norms under the SEBI Mutual Fund Regulations, 1996 and SEBI Collective Investment Scheme Regulation 1999, there was virtually no public disclosure norms for both AIFs and FPIs, the petition said.

Justice Nagarathna said Ms. Moitra could have very well raised the issue on the floor of the House for discussion. Mr. Bhushan said discussions had hardly taken place in the House in the recent past. The senior counsel pointed to Ms. Moitra's expertise as a former investment banker.

"She is also an investor," Mr. Bhushan said. Then this was hardly a petition in public interest, Justice Nagarathna said.

"Is the court saying no MP can approach the SC under Article 32? As an MP, she is concerned about the fate of crores of people who are investing in the stock markets. She believes the opacity may lead to manipulation through AIFs and FPIs," Mr. Bhushan submitted. The judge reminded the counsel the court allowed Ms. Moitra's petition against premature release of 11 convicts in the Bilkis Bano gangrape case.

'Probe, when needed'

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, for SEBI, said disclosures of investments of AIFs and FPIs were made to the regulator and detailed probe was conducted when warranted.

H1 pharma exports rose 5% to $16.14 bn amid key NAFTA dip

N.Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

India's pharmaceutical exports rose 4.90% year-on-year to $16,135.93 million in the first six months FY27 aided by market diversification strategy even as shipments to NAFTA region that includes the all crucial U.S. market for generics slid more than 2%.

The April-September numbers, in comparison to $15,382.85 million year earlier period, highlight the scale of exports to Europe, pharma exporters body Pharmexcil said, reporting a 9.66% rise in the shipments at $3,288.27 million.

Europe accounted for 20.38% of the India's pharma exports particularly in Germany, the Netherlands and France, highlighting the opportunities for the exporters to deepen engagement.

Exports to NAFTA, the largest market, which contributed to 32.87% of the total, stood at $5,304.07 million, a 2.05% dip. Other markets that aided growth were Africa with exports rising 6.48% to $2,248.64 million, Latin America at 16.58% to $1,296.94 million and ASEAN 21.54% to $1,058.86 million.

Centre to re-open textile PLI portal

The Union Ministry of Textiles will reopen the portal – https://pli.texmin.gov.in – to receive applications under round four of the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) Scheme for textiles from November 1 to December 31.

The focus of the PLI will be on manufacturing of Man-Made Fibre (MMF) apparel, MMF fabrics and technical textiles.

Adani Airports, IHCL plan to build 8 hotels

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Adani Airport Holdings Ltd (AAHL) and Indian Hotels Company Ltd (IHCL) on Thursday signed agreements to develop eight hotels with over 2,000 rooms across Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Lucknow and Guwahati.

The hotels will operate under IHCL's Taj, Vivanta, Gateway and Ginger brands. Adani Airports will develop the properties, to be operated by IHCL.

Adani Airports has formed Adani Airport City Ltd. to develop a land bank of more than 655 acre across eight airports in seven States. In the first phase, Adani Airport City plans to invest more than ₹20,000 crore to develop about 22 million sq ft.

IndiGo Q2 loss narrows to ₹1,879.1 crore on fare gains

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

IndiGo narrowed its consolidated net loss to ₹1,879.1 crore in the second quarter of FY2027 (Q2FY27) from ₹2,582.1 crore a year earlier as higher passenger yields partly cushioned the impact of surging fuel costs amid geopolitical tensions in the Middle East.

The September quarter was marked by exceptionally high fuel costs and continued geopolitical uncertainty, alongside seasonally softer travel demand.

Elevated crude oil prices kept pressure on the airline's earnings.



Multiple challenges: Rupee depreciation added to the pressure by increasing the cost of dollar-denominated expenses. REUTERS

Fuel, biggest drag

Total expenses rose 18.6% to ₹26,188.4 crore from ₹22,081 crore. Fuel expenses were the biggest drag, climbing 67.2% to ₹9,966.8 crore from ₹5,961.8 crore.

Passenger yield–revenue earned/passenger kilometre– rose 34.3% to ₹6.30, helping revenue from operations increase 25.9% to ₹23,363.8 crore.

However, the improvement in yields only partially offset the higher cost base. Capacity, measured in available seat kilometres (ASK) fell 1%, while passenger traffic declined 4.7% to 2.75 crore. The passenger load factor slipped 2.2 percentage points to 80.3% from 82.5% a year earlier.

Rupee depreciation added to the pressure by increasing the cost of dollar-denominated expenses, including aircraft leases and maintenance.

Earthly automobiles



Green mobility: An employee of Volkswagen removes a dismantled steering wheel at the group's first Circular Economy facility to dismantle cars, at Volkswagen's EV factory in Zwickau, Germany. REUTERS

Equitas Bank tanks after CEO steps down

Reuters

India's Equitas Small Finance Bank said its longtime CEO P. N. Vasudevan would resign amid conflict-of-interest concerns as his daughter runs a non-banking finance company, sending its shares down as much as 20%.

Mr. Vasudevan, who has led the lender as managing director and CEO for over a decade, said in his resignation letter that investors had repeatedly raised the issue and that it was weighing on the stock.

Mr. Vasudevan has led Equitas since it started off as a microfinance institution in 2007 and oversaw its conversion to a small finance bank in 2016.

Secure $15 bn in NMC case, Shetty tells BoB

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Bavaguthu Raghuram Shetty (B.R. Shetty), founder-promoter of UAE-based failed healthcare venture NMC Healthcare & UAE Exchange, filed two interim applications in Bombay High Court seeking Bank of Baroda (BoB) to secure, earmark or at least disclose his $15 billion damage claim against it and preserve forensic imaging of its systems and $600 million NMC Health settlement papers.

In his application, he sought three tiers of protection pending final disposal of the suit, plus ad-interim relief in the same terms. He has asked Bank of Baroda to furnish security of $15 billion (about ₹1,43,700 crore), with interest as claimed.

The application rests on what it calls the bank's own conduct in 2026 wherein it disclosed in Annual Report FY26 it had a good case in proceedings brought by Joint Administrators of the NMC firms before Abu Dhabi Global Market (ADGM) Courts.

In a filing, BoB said, "the bank has not been served with such suit. It has not been served with interim applications, subject of today's press inquiries." And it made no provision and disclosed no contingent liability for these claims.

Oracle opens cloud to Google's AI chips

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

Oracle will offer Google's Tensor Processing Units (TPUs) via cloud infrastructure platform from 2027, marking the first time specialised AI accelerators will be available on a hyperscale cloud platform outside of Google's ecosystem.

Announced on October 27, the partnership will allow Oracle Cloud Infrastructure (OCI) clients to access Google's custom-designed AI chips alongside other computing architectures, expanding options for training and deploying AI models.

TPUs are processors designed by Google to accelerate machine-learning workloads. They offer an alternative to graphics processing units.

Mahesh Thiagarajan, president, Oracle Cloud Infrastructure said, "bringing Google TPUs to OCI gives customers access to multiple leading AI compute architectures on one cloud. The choice gives them the flexibility to choose the right infrastructure for the performance, throughput, and economics of each AI workload."

Under the arrangement, Oracle will provide power, cooling and data-centre networking needed to deploy accelerators while Google will supply TPUs and related software.

Victorinox targets 30% watch growth in India

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Swiss heritage brand Victorinox is sharpening its India strategy with a new entry-level watch collection priced at around ₹35,000, online sales through its website and an expanded retail network, targeting growth of at least 30% in its watch business in 2027.

The company, which currently sells watches priced between ₹60,000 and ₹2 lakh in India, plans to introduce the more affordable collection next year to attract new customers while retaining Swiss manufacturing.

Wheels India Q2 net profit almost doubles to ₹53.4 crore

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Wheels India Ltd reported a 92% year-on-year (YoY) increase in net profit to ₹53.4 crore in the second quarter ended September 30 as revenue grew 36% to ₹1,598 crore.

The company plans ₹400-450 crore capital expenditure (capex) in FY27, significantly higher than its annual spending of about ₹250 crore over the past couple of years, amid robust demand across business segments.

"In July, we said [₹]300 crores. But, every board meeting subsequently, including the one that was concluded today, we have asked for additional CapEx," CMD Srivats Ram said during the earnings call. He attributed the increase to strong customer demand and the need to expand capacity.



Exports rose 30% to ₹388 crore in the September quarter, with U.S. turning key growth driver.

Exports rose 30% YoY to ₹388 crore in the September quarter with the U.S. emerging as a key growth driver. Sales to the country rose by an estimated 50%, Mr. Ram said.

Earthmover wheels, which are largely exported, registered substantial growth, while air suspension systems used in Indian buses also performed well. Domestic demand for car, truck and tractor wheels remained strong.

It also benefited indirectly from the U.S. data-centre construction boom, which boosted demand for construction equipment.

Wheels India raised ₹430 crore during the quarter.

AB Foods' Primark split hinges on sales recovery, sugar turnaround



Split wide open: The Primark logo outside the store at Oxford Street in London, Britain. REUTERS

Reuters
LONDON

Associated British Foodssays (AB Foods) spinning off its budget fashion arm Primark in the FTSE 100's largest ever retail demerger will sharpen management focus and improve governance. Whether it unlocks value for shareholders is much less certain.

The separation, announced in April, will dismantle one of the last major conglomerates on Britain's stock market, splitting a fast-fashion retailer from businesses spanning sugar, tea, yeast and animal feed.

It comes amid a broader shift away from diversified consumer groups as investors increasingly favour simpler, more focused companies. Recent examples include Unilever's moves to split its ice cream and foods businesses.

The separation will end six decades of Primark ownership, during which AB Foods built the chain from a single Dublin store into a retailer with 511 shops across 21 markets. Primark now generates about half of group revenue and two-thirds of adjusted operating profit.

Intensifying competition

But the demerger comes at a difficult time. Primark is battling slowing sales growth and intensifying competition from China's Shein and Temu, while analysts expect AB Foods' sugar division to remain loss-making for at least another two years. *Reuters* interviews with investors, analysts and people familiar with the board's thinking suggest the split alone is unlikely to trigger a major re-rating of the stock. Investors want Primark growing again and sugar back in profit. The remaining AB Foods will comprise grocery brands including Twinings, Ovaltine, Ryvita and Jordans, alongside ingredients, agriculture and sugar.

Valuation gap

AB Foods' share price highlights the pressure for change. The stock is down about 15% over the last year and more than a fifth over the past decade, compared with a gain of more than 50% in the FTSE 100. At 13.5 times forward earnings, AB Foods trades at a discount of about 23% to clothing peer Next and roughly40% to Inditex and H&M. Analysts say the mix of retail, sugar and food businesses has contributed to a conglomerate discount that management hopes the split will eliminate. David Samra, MD of Artisan Partners, AB Foods' second-largest shareholder with a stake of about 5%, said better Primark sales growth and a return to profit in sugar would matter more than the demerger itself. "If you get those two things, you're going to have a very good outcome," he told *Reuters*. Far from undermining the case for a demerger, he views ABFoods' problems as the rationale for it.

"AB Foods' issues aren't ones that are standing in the way of this separation happening, they're issues that are the reasons why this is happening." The group, with a market value of £13.9 billion ($18.5billion) says the separation will improve board oversight, sharpen each company's investment case and allow shareholders to choose between Primark and what will become the FTSE 100's only pure-play food producer. Wittington Investments Limited, the Weston family vehicle that is AB Foods' largest investor with about 60% of the equity, says it supports the demerger and has committed to maintaining majority ownership of both businesses.

The real test

At Primark the task ahead is clear. It reported flat U.K. like-for-like sales in its fourth quarter to mid-September, a steeper decline in continental Europe and slower U.S. growth. Its adjusted operating profit margin also fell nearly 2 percentage points in 2025/26.

Jefferies regards Primark as "among the most disadvantageously positioned clothing retailers", in part due to pressure on its low-income customers and the time needed to build a home-delivery business. It forecasts negative like-for-like sales in 2027 and rising cost pressures the following year. Last month, AB Foods CEO George Weston said lower prices and increased marketing at Primark were gaining traction in the U.K., particularly in womens wear. But finance chief Joana Edwards cautioned against expecting a quick return to like-for-like sales growth in mainland Europe given weak consumer confidence.

Fed's confidence in the U.S. economy leaves Treasury investors in suspense

U.S. yield curve steepens after Fed decision, Warsh briefing; U.S. rate futures price in December hike; market participants question 'strong' U.S. economy; fiscal concerns are threatening to keep long-term borrowing costs elevated; Treasury yields have climbed across most maturities

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK



Uneasy lies head: The Federal Reserve building set against blue sky in Washington, U.S. REUTERS

The Federal Reserve kept interest rates steady on Wednesday as expected, but it was notable to comfort bond investors concerned about what a deliberate pace of policy tightening will mean for the outlook for longer-term government bonds.

The central bank described an economy strong enough to keep inflation elevated, yet refrained from raising rates immediately. That deepened uncertainty over how much further policy may need to tighten, analysts said, and over how much compensation investors could demand to hold longer-dated Treasuries, which have soared this year to their highest yields in two decades.

The Fed upgraded its assessment of the economy to "strong" from the "solid" expansion seen as of the September meeting, while describing investment as robust and job gains as keeping pace with the workforce. But how that all leads to price pressures coming down - the main priority for bond investors -was less clear.

"Ultimately, if we see strong growth, which (Fed Chair Kevin) Warsh is expecting, we're going to see more inflation, which means those fiscal deficit concerns and how to address them longer term become more relevant," said Anders Persson, chief investment officer for global fixed income at investment manager Nuveen in Charlotte, North Carolina.

Complicated future

A combination of resilient economic growth and persistent inflation could complicate the U.S. fiscal outlook, limiting the Fed's ability to lower interest rates when the economy turns and keeping Treasury borrowing costs elevated. The yield curve steepened following Warsh's press conference, with the long end selling off. The spread between 2-and 10-year yields widened to as much as 34.1 basis points after flattening over the last few weeks. There were different interpretations as to why. One was that Warsh did not give a definitive commitment on future policy action, which reduced rate-hike bets. He also suggested the Fed's last rate rise is starting to work and that financial conditions have started to tighten.

> The Fed upgraded its assessment of the economy to "strong" from the "solid" expansion seen as of the September meeting

The resulting steepening of the U.S. Treasury yield curve, however, underscores the growing tension between a Fed that is willing to wait for more evidence before adjusting policy and investors increasingly concerned about persistent price pressures and the risks of holding long-term government debt.

Treasury yields have climbed across most maturities from the belly of the curve - between 5 and 7 years - onwards following the Fed's latest decision, with longer-dated yields coming under particular pressure.

"The bond market selling off is because the Fed is going to have a hard time raising rates much higher without causing issues somewhere," said Byron Anderson, head of fixed income at Laffer Tengler Investments in Scottsdale, Arizona.

The long-end sell-off suggested that investors are also grappling with more than just the immediate outlook for monetary policy, analysts said, amid inflation uncertainty and fiscal concerns threatening to keep long-term borrowing costs elevated.

"Investors should prepare for interest rates to remain elevated with the Fed focused on bringing inflation back towards its 2% target," said Phil Blancato, chief market strategist at wealth management firm Osaic in New York. Financial markets are already pricing in the possibility of another increase in December, with expectations for further hikes next year adding to uncertainty over the policy outlook.

Misreading strength?

Market participants also questioned the Fed's assessment of the economy.

"What are they looking at to give the economy an upgrade? The moving average of weekly payroll gains from ADP was trending up between the July and September meeting, but it has been trending down since," said Brian Jacobsen, chief economic strategist at Annex Wealth Management in Menomonee Falls, Wisconsin.

"The Atlanta Fed's GDPNow forecast has gone from white hot to merely smouldering," he said.

As growth loses some steam, the economy may not need to weaken much to undermine the optimistic outlook, according to some observers.

Citigroup's chief U.S. economist, Andrew Hollenhorst, said Warsh was "overstating the breadth of strength in the U.S. economy, meaning he will likely have a relatively low bar for a downside surprise."

That uncertainty over the economic outlook can weigh on Treasuries at the front end of the curve, where yields are particularly sensitive to rate moves. But the pressure on longer-dated bonds reflects a broader set of concerns.

Investors holding 10-year and 30-year Treasuries face greater exposure to changes in inflation expectations and interest rates over time. When uncertainty rises, they may demand additional compensation to take on that duration risk, pushing yields higher and bond prices lower. If investors turn less confident about the long-run inflation outlook or seek more compensation for the government's borrowing needs, the term premium - the extra compensation investors need to hold longer-term bonds - can rise even without a corresponding change in expectations for the Fed's policy rate.

Microsoft: staff cuts, retirement, voluntary exits

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI



Firm moves: The latest offer follows steps such as the elimination of about 4,800 roles and voluntary retirement plan. REUTERS

The story so far: Microsoft introduced a voluntary exit offer for eligible employees in India, the U.S. , the UK and Canada, as the technology giant expands its artificial intelligence (AI) business and changes how work is organised.

In an October 26 announcement, Amy Coleman, Microsoft's executive vice-president and chief people officer, said the offer would give eligible employees considering leaving the company financial support and career-planning resources. The programme is available to employees in select teams, with participation depending on business priorities, customer commitments and workforce needs.

The latest offer follows two earlier workforce measures such as the elimination of about 4,800 roles and a voluntary retirement programme in which more than 30% of eligible employees chose to participate. Microsoft did not disclose how many staff, it expects, would leave under the new offer.

While the company has not explicitly linked the latest programme to AI-driven job displacement or cost savings, its workforce announcements, financial disclosures and account of internal AI transformation provide context for the decision.

Changing staff needs

Microsoft is restructuring even as its business grows. In its fiscal 2026 results, the company reported revenue of $331.8 billion, up 18% from the previous year and operating income of $155.2 billion, up 21%.

Kamal Karanth, co-founder of specialist staffing firm Xpheno, described Microsoft's voluntary exit offer (VEO) as "a timely manpower optimisation move" against the backdrop of operational efficiencies achieved over the last four fiscal periods.

He said enterprises strive for "non-linear scale and growth on manpower to revenue ratios" and Microsoft appears to have achieved this over the last four years. According to the four-year comparison, he shared, Microsoft's revenue grew 79.7% and its headcount rose 68.7% between FY2018 and FY2022. Between FY2022 and FY2026, revenue grew 67.4%, while headcount increased just 0.9%. "Achieving 68% growth in revenue with less than 1% net growth in headcount over the last 4 fiscals, denotes an operational excellence in play," he said.

Mr. Karanth said Microsoft had got several things right, including its "product and revenue mix, client mix, quality and pedigree of talent, AI tech stack impact on productivity, and efficiency of Cloud and AI infrastructure".

Comparing the two periods, he described the shift as "a successful switch up to non-linear scale and efficiency". He said the efficiencies achieved so far provided "sufficient headroom for the firm to slim down, optimise headcount and boost output efficiency as AI matures further".

In a July 6 announcement about job cuts, Ms. Coleman said the company was eliminating around 4,800 roles, about 2.1% of its global workforce, as it aligned its workforce and investments with changing business priorities.

She said Microsoft redeployed more than 4,000 staff into new roles over the preceding year. Ms. Coleman added the roles being eliminated in the round were not being replaced by AI while acknowledging that AI was changing how work was done.

Cost of AI business

Microsoft's financial disclosures show rising expenditure on research and development and infrastructure as it expands AI and cloud businesses.

In its fiscal 2026 annual report, the company said research and development expenses rose 9% to $35.6 billion, from $32.5 billion in the previous year. The company attributed the increase to continued investment in computing capacity, AI talent and data to support product development, as well as impairment and related expenses in its Xbox business.

The report also showed the cost of revenue in Microsoft's Intelligent Cloud business rose 44% to $57.9 billion in fiscal 2026. Microsoft attributed the rise to investment in AI infrastructure to meet growing customer demand.

The company warned that continued investment in cloud and AI infrastructure and devices could increase costs and put pressure on operating margins.

In the fourth quarter of fiscal 2026, capital expenditure, including finance leases, reached $41 billion, according to the company's earnings disclosures. Roughly two-thirds went towards short-lived assets, primarily central processing units and graphics processing units.

Gaurav Vasu, founder of UnearthInsight, said large technology companies such as Microsoft, Oracle, Amazon and Google would continue to direct a greater share of spending towards research and development and AI infrastructure.

"Over a period of time employee costs or wage bills will continue to fund AI investments," he said.

Mr. Vasu said Microsoft was "resetting the relationship between revenue growth, workforce cost and AI investment". Voluntary exits, he said, gave the firm another way to change workforce mix while protecting resources for current and future investments.

His assessment is Microsoft wants its business to grow without increasing its payroll at the same pace, while directing more resources towards computing infrastructure, products and specialised skills. Microsoft has not publicly identified this as the specific objective of its exit programme.

In a September 17 article, Kathleen Hogan, executive vice-president and chief strategy and transformation officer, said the company had learnt that simply giving employees access to AI tools did not necessarily transform how work was done. Greater gains came from redesigning entire workflows, changing processes and determining how people and AI systems should work together.

Microsoft cited several examples. In selected supply-chain workflows, the firm said it deployed more than 100 specialised AI agents and reduced cycle times by as much as 75%. Ms. Hogan also described a nine-person engineering team that delivered an initial product release in 35 days using AI throughout the development process.

These are firm-reported examples of productivity improvements. Microsoft has not said such gains led to the voluntary exit offer or fixed staffing needs in the teams covered by it.

Subscriptions to AI

The shift towards AI could also change how technology companies make money from their products.

Traditional enterprise software is often sold via subscriptions based on the number of users, commonly known as seats. AI services can generate additional revenue through the computing and model usage required to perform tasks, including those carried out by AI agents.

Microsoft chief executive Satya Nadella has described the company's evolving business models in the context of the value and usage of its services.

The company has also highlighted the importance of measuring the cost of AI usage against the outcomes it produces.

Mr. Vasu said this could lead to a business model combining user subscriptions with consumption-based revenue from AI and cloud services.

In such a model, a company could employ fewer people while spending more on AI agents and computing.

For customers, he said, the relevant measure would be the total cost of completing a business process, including AI usage, human review and exceptions that require human intervention.

Reducing the human effort involved in a task does not automatically make the entire process cheaper. The cost of AI usage, computing infrastructure and human oversight must also be considered.

What remains unclear

Microsoft's disclosures establish that the company is restructuring its workforce, investing in AI infrastructure and research, and redesigning selected workflows around AI.

Its financial results also show that these investments are taking place alongside strong revenue and operating-income growth.

But the company has not disclosed how many employees it expects to leave under the new offer, its expected financial cost or whether the participating teams have specific workforce-reduction targets. Nor has it said that AI-driven job displacement is the reason for the programme.

The extent to which the voluntary exit offer is linked to AI-related productivity gains or cost management therefore remains unclear.

TEHRAN

Iran Guards say four tankers on fire after hitting mines in Hormuz



REUTERS

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said on Thursday that four tankers had caught fire after hitting mines while attempting to navigate the Strait of Hormuz, a day after the U.S. military said it had demined key routes through the waterway. The IRGC, in a statement said the vessels had disregarded warnings from the IRGC navy. AFP

WASHINGTON

U.S. fires top military planner over 'leak of classified data', say reports



U.S. ARMY VIA AP

The U.S. has fired a top military planner, media reported, with some outlets saying the dismissal was due to the officer allegedly leaking classified information. Army Lieutenant General Brett Sylvia was removed from his role as head of strategy, plans and policy on the Joint Staff, the media reported on Wednesday. AFP

GAZA CITY

Five people killed in Israeli strikes in Gaza's south, says civil defence



AP

Gaza's civil defence agency and a local hospital said Israeli strikes killed five people and wounded several others in the Palestinian territory on Wednesday. According to reports, three people were killed in a drone attack in Rafah in the south and another person was killed in a strike in Khan Yunis, also in the south. AFP

UNITED NATIONS

India votes in favour of UNGA call for end to U.S. embargo on Cuba



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

India voted in favour of a United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) resolution calling for an end to the economic, commercial and financial embargo imposed by the United States against Cuba, reiterating that the restrictions should be lifted to help the Caribbean nation pursue its development aspirations. PTI

Israel to probe election after Netanyahu's bloc alleges fraud

Arab parties which could play a key role in government formation face unproven accusations of getting foreign funding; they are on track to win 19 seats between them, while the ruling and opposition blocs are well under 61 needed for majority

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's bloc on Thursday piled pressure on Israeli Arab leaders over unproven accusations of foreign funding, in a push to neuter parties that could hold the key to forming a government after an inconclusive election.

Israeli President Isaac Herzog called for an investigation into allegations of fraud but cautioned against stigmatising the entire Arab Israeli community.

Israel was nearing the completion of ballot-counting from Tuesday's election, in which neither Mr. Netanyahu nor the opposition bloc led by former military chief Gadi Eisenkot looked able to secure a majority in the parliament known as the Knesset.



A file photo shows Ra'am party leader Mansour Abbas voting at a polling station in Maghar, Israel, on October 27. REUTERS

With nearly 93% of the vote counted, Mr. Netanyahu's bloc was at 53 seats and the opposition forces led by Mr. Eisenkot on 48 - both well under the 61 needed to form a government. The two main Arab formations were on track for an unprecedented 19 seats between them.

The Netanyahu camp's accusations, which a key Arab party has rejected, could bring uncertainty to the electoral process at a time when the threat of a return to war with Iran looms over the region.

Polarised election

Israel's election saw soaring participation by Israeli Arabs as outrage boiled at calls by officials such as National Security Minister Itamar Ben Gvir to treat their community much as Israel has dealt with Palestinians in Gaza and the occupied West Bank.

Following Mr. Netanyahu's accusations of impropriety, Mr. Ben Gvir went so far as to encourage Israel to "immediately" order the arrests of Arab party leaders.

Ra'am party leader Mansour Abbas said he welcomed an investigation, adding that his moderate Islamist party had "no connection" with the accusations.

The Arab parties together have enough votes to take the opposition bloc over the finish line, but Mr. Eisenkot has baulked after attacks by Mr. Netanyahu, who warned his right-wing Jewish base that voting for the opposition would put Arabs in power.

Mr. Eisenkot said the official probe into the claims should run its course without interference, but also accused Netanyahu of seeking to "delegitimise" the election results.

Government officials did not offer evidence to back the allegations, and left-wing candidate Yair Golan accused Mr. Netanyahu of attempting to stir controversy after failing to get a majority.

Netanyahu lost seats, but escaped an outright defeat

NEWS ANALYSIS

Stanly Johny



Benjamin Netanyahu addresses his supporters at a rally after the first exit polls were announced in Jerusalem on Wednesday. AFP

Israel's October 27 election was framed by the Opposition as a referendum on Benjamin Netanyahu. For the country's longest-serving Prime Minister, the election was a battle for survival. For the Opposition led by former military chief Gadi Eisenkot, this was an opportunity to oust Mr. Netanyahu from power. With almost 90% of the vote counted, Israel is divided into three blocs, none of which can govern alone.

The numbers

On the latest count, Mr. Netanyahu's right-religious coalition has 53 seats, eight short of the 61 needed for a majority in the Knesset. His Likud is the largest party with 27 seats, down from 32 four years ago. His far-right partners, Otzma Yehudit of Ithamar Ben-Gvir (7) and Religious Zionism of Bezalel Smotrich (6), hold 13 between them. The remaining seats in his bloc come from the religious parties–Shas and United Torah Judaism.

The Opposition bloc, led by Mr. Eisenkot, has 48 seats, 13 short of a majority. His Yashar party, which was expected to beat Likud, finished second with 21 seats. His allies, B'Yachad of Naftali Bennett (12) and Israel Beytenu of Avigdor Lieberman (7), add a combined 19. But the main surprise factor was the surge of the Arab parties. They have 19 seats between them, with the Joint List winning 12 and the United Arab List (Ra'am) 7.

Likud's slide is real, but it is smaller than the Opposition had hoped. Mr. Netanyahu, a wanted man by the International Criminal Court, a divisive figure at home, and the leader of Israel's right, still commands the single biggest party and the single biggest bloc.

The possibilities

Mr. Netanyahu has built his career on one claim: that only he can "keep Israel safe". This election was the first test of that claim since the failures of October 7, a war in Gaza that has killed over 70,000 Palestinians, and a failed campaign against Iran with global economic consequences. Losing his majority and seeing his party shed seats shows that the claim has weakened, even if it has not collapsed.

But the mechanics of Israeli coalition-building favour the incumbent. As the leader of the largest party and the largest bloc, Mr. Netanyahu can expect to be invited by President Isaac Herzog to form the government. He will have 24 days to prove the majority. He has two ways forward. First, propose a unity government with Mr. Eisenkot and his allies. But it's not clear whether Mr. Eisenkot, who has also promised to form the government, would back Mr. Netanyahu as Prime Minister. Second, Mr. Netanyahu could win the support of one or two of Mr. Eisenkot's right-wing allies (such as Mr. Lieberman or Mr. Bennet) and form a Zionist coalition government. That would break Mr. Eisenkot's coalition.

But if Mr. Netanyahu fails to win a majority, the mandate would pass to Mr. Eisenkot, who faces a harder problem. His 48 seats cannot reach 61 without the Arab parties. Even Ra'am's 7 would take him only to 55. Mr. Eisenkot would need the support of the Joint List as well.

This is the Opposition's central dilemma. Two of Mr. Eisenkot's allies, B'Yachard and Beytenu, have strongly opposed any alliance with Arab parties. '

If neither bloc gets a majority, Israel would return to the polls within months, with Mr. Netanyahu serving as caretaker Prime Minister throughout.

Mr. Netanyahu has lost his majority, his Likud party has shrunk and his claim to be indispensable has been weakened. But the fragmentation of his opponents remains his most reliable asset. He has not won the election, but by denying his opponents an outright victory, he has found a way to cling to power, at least for now.

Ukraine says at least 14 killed in Russian attack on train station

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

At least 14 people were killed when a Russian drone slammed into a platform at the Dnipro railway station in central Ukraine, where a train was parked, Ukrainian authorities said on Thursday.

"Thirteen people were killed in a Russian attack on Dnipro. At least five more were wounded," Dnipropetrovsk regional governor Oleksandr Ganzha said on Telegram. He later said the toll had risen to 14.



Rescuers evacuate a wounded civilian at the Dnipro railway station on Thursday. AP

Dnipro mayor Borys Filatov said that "a drone hit a civilian electric train".

The state Ukrainian Railways operator said a jet-powered Russian drone had hit the Dnipro station. "The strike hit one of the platforms, where train No. 866 Dnipro-Zaporizhzhia was at the time," it said.

Oleksandr Pertsovsky, the rail company's chief, said an elevated threat level had been announced.

"But unfortunately there were still a large number of people on the platform," he said on Facebook.

Bangladesh court sentences Hasina-era minister to death

Agence France-Presse
DHAKA

A Bangladesh court on Thursday sentenced Md Mahbubul Alam Hanif, joint general secretary of ousted leader Sheikh Hasina's Awami League, to death in absentia for his role in the killings of six people during the 2024 uprising, while three other party leaders were sentenced to life imprisonment. Mr. Hanif also served as a minister during Hasina's rule.

The tribunal also ordered the confiscation of half of their immovable properties to be distributed as compensation to the families of people killed or injured during the uprising, Islam said.

As many as 1,400 people were killed between July and August 2024, according to the UN, when Hasina's government attempted to suppress the student-led uprising.

Republicans defend bastions, as Senate comes within reach of Democrats

NEWS ANALYSIS

Sriram Lakshman

As the U.S. heads towards midterm elections next week, the presidency of Donald Trump faces an inflection point, with the prospect of Republican control of Congress weakening. Since early 2026 at least, forecasts have suggested the GOP would lose the U.S. House of Representatives. Recently, however, trends suggest that the Senate too is within reach of the Democrats.

The GOP has a 53-47 majority in the Senate currently, with 35 seats being contested this year. Of these, seven are "toss ups", according to the Cook Political Report (CPR), a non-partisan election analyser. These seats are in Iowa, Arkansas, Kansas, Maine, Michigan, Ohio and Texas. All of these - except Michigan - are currently held by Republicans. Texas has not elected a Democrat from the Senate since 1998. Worries over the economy and cost of living, disillusionment with Mr. Trump's handling of these issues, and relatively lower expected turnout among Republican voters, have put the Republicans at risk of losing one of their bastions.

This week, Mr. Trump made his third campaign visit to Texas in support of GOP candidates up and down the ballot. Republican Greg Abbott is defending his gubernatorial seat against Democratic State legislator Gina Hinojosa, whom he leads narrowly in polls.

In the most watched State race, GOP candidate and Texas Attorney General Ken Paxton, who has been indicted on security fraud and impeached (and acquitted) for the abuse of office, is running against State lawmaker and Presbyterian seminarian James Talarico for the U.S. Senate.

Tight race

The contest is becoming one of the most expensive Senate races on record, as per an analysis from *Reuters*. Republican groups have spent multiples of what Democrat groups supporting Mr. Talarico have, while Mr. Talarico has raised more from individual and grassroots donations than his opponent has. Having moved Tesla, SpaceX and some of his other businesses to the State, Elon Musk has gone on to indirectly donate $158 million in support of Mr. Paxton. Still, the race continues to be tight.

Mr. Paxton's scandals have become a campaign vulnerability for him, as has voter concern over the economy in general. The Republicans have attacked Mr. Talarico as being too liberal for Texas on religious and cultural issues. For instance, his opponents have claimed that he supports sex-change operations in children. Mr Talarico has clarified that he does not support these procedures and that he voted against a Bill banning gender-affirming care for minors because it was too broad.



President Donald Trump throws hats into the crowd at a campaign rally in Chillicothe, Ohio, on Wednesday. AP

At a rally earlier this week in Corpus Christi, Texas, Mr. Trump attacked Mr. Talarico. "He's been a vegan and there's not a damn thing he can do about it," the President said, mocking Mr. Talarico attempting to eat meat and claiming that he gets sick after he eats it. Mr. Talarico has denied being vegan and has integrated barbecue-eating sessions into his campaigning.

But meat has entered the electoral conversation in more than one way. It has become a telling kitchen-table issue that voters are concerned about. There has been an uptick in chicken consumption as beef prices have been rising. The administration took measures in November 2025 and earlier this year to import greater volumes of beef at lower tariffs - a move that was meant to benefit consumers but angered farmers.

Price rise

Food prices, and more generally the cost of living, are at the top of voter concerns. The war on Iran has driven up fuel prices. Costlier petrol and diesel, along with Mr. Trump's tariffs, have pushed up the prices of other goods. Some two-third of Americans disapprove of how Mr. Trump is handling U.S. military action in Iran while a third support it, according to Pew Research Centre data from earlier this month.

Some 85% of voters say the economy is one of the most important issues and 84% say the same about the cost of living as per an AP-NORC poll conducted October 8-11.

A majority of each category of voters want to see "complete and total upheaval" or "substantial change" in the country. That the proportion wanting such change is 58% among Republicans and 90% among Independents poses a significant challenge for the GOP.

Democrats are faced with their own challenges, including not having a coherent and clear message or vision at the national level. Republicans also are perceived as stronger on crime and immigration.

The Republicans have 218 seats in the 435-seat House, all of which are up for grabs. There are 214 Democrats, one Independent who causes with Republicans, and two vacancies. Democrats need to flip three seats , giving them 217 seats (and Republicans 215), to win the House. The CPR's analysis gives Republicans 168 "solid" seats and Democrats 186 such seats. Adding the "likely" Democrat and "leaning" Democrat seats to this gets the party 220 seats. This does not even count the 17 "toss-up" seats which could go either Democrat or Republican, giving Democrats a strong chance of taking control of the House.

If Democrats win the Senate in addition to the House, the future of the second Trump administration will change course, with implications for government funding, foreign policy, judicial appointments and the possibility of investigations and impeachment proceedings against administration officials and the President.



Lucrative crop: Farmers harvest sap from poppies in a field in Badakhshan province of Afghanistan. AFP

Opium poppy cultivation surges in Afghanistan

Agence France-Presse
KABUL

Opium poppy cultivation in Afghanistan more than quadrupled in 2026 despite a Taliban government ban, the United Nations (UN) said Thursday, urging that impoverished farmers needed alternatives to the lucrative crop.

Cultivated areas reached 43,000 hectares (around 1,06,200 acres), up from 10,000 hectares in 2025, while estimated opium production jumped fivefold from 300 tonnes to 1,500 tonnes, the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) said in a report. Long the world's leading producer of poppies, Afghanistan was overtaken by Myanmar after a 2022 government ban crushed the trade. But rampant poverty has driven some farmers to return to the trade.

"Without opium, we cannot even afford basic food," Mohammad, a 22-year-old farmer in Afghanistan's northeast, told *AFP*.

Afghanistan's 2022 crackdown drove cultivated areas down from more than 2,00,000 hectares to 10,000 hectares in 2025. Myanmar cultivated 53,000 hectares in 2025, with no 2026 figures available. The Taliban authorities claim to have destroyed more than 22,000 hectares.

One hectare of wheat generated just over $770 in 2023, compared with $10,000 for a hectare of poppy, according to the UNODC. "Opium prices slightly decreased from US$ 570 per kilogram in 2025 to US$ 500 per kilogram in 2026, remaining well above pre-ban levels of less than $100 per kilogram," the UNODC said in a press release.

"The fourfold increase in opium poppy cultivation shows the difficulty in sustaining decreases in illicit opium cultivation when poor farmers have no alternatives to feed their families," said UNODC Executive Director Monica Juma.

Bangladesh presses India for a new Ganges treaty before expiry in Dec.

Dhaka fears worsening water shortages, crop losses, and declining fish catches as the 30-year water-sharing treaty expires on Dec. 12; they seek new deal that accounts for climate change and needs of the entire river basin amid strained bilateral ties and growing pressure on freshwater resources

NEWS ANALYSIS

Agence France-Presse
RAJSHAHI



In dire straits: The eroded embankment along the Padma river (known as the Ganga in India) at Namo Jagannathpur village near the Bangladesh-India border in Rajshahi division. AFP

With a 30-year Ganges water-sharing treaty with India expiring in December, Bangladesh fears failure to strike a new deal could deepen water shortages, threatening tens of millions of livelihoods.

In Bangladesh's parched Barind region, 72-year-old Bikash Soren remembers when the Ganges river flowing in from neighbouring India carried large boats past his village year-round.

"For almost three months a year, you hardly see the river flowing," the Protestant priest said.

Two farmers killed themselves last season, he added, after dwindling water levels left their rice and wheat crops in tatters.

Shrinking flows in the Ganges have also slashed fish catches in the river, known in Bangladesh as the Padma.

"Where will we find fish now?" said Abu Bakar Siddique, 55, who has switched to fish farming in ponds. "I used to catch many kinds."

The 2,525-kilometre (1,569-mile) Ganges flows through the world's most populous river basin, home to 655 million people including more than 50 million in Bangladesh, according to the World Bank.

The 1996 treaty, which expires on December 12, governs dry-season water sharing at India's Farakka Barrage, 20 kilometres (12 miles) upstream of Bangladesh.

But Bangladesh needs a new deal based on "mutual benefit and respect", Rashed Al Mahmud Titumir, a prime ministerial adviser who heads a technical committee on water-sharing, told *AFP*.

Water arguments over 54 cross-border rivers between India and Bangladesh stretch back decades, and the Ganges is among the most important.

Malik Fida A. Khan, a former Bangladeshi member of the Joint Rivers Commission (JRC), the body overseeing water-sharing, said India had built "additional dams" upstream.

"This time, the agreement must include provisions on climate change – and take the entire river basin into account," he said.

Soured relations

Bangladesh said India had not responded to its request to negotiate a treaty renewal.

New Delhi's Foreign Ministry said that "discussions regarding river-related matters" are a matter for the JRC commission, which held its last technical talks back in May.

The last officially confirmed ministerial-level JRC meeting was in 2022 – after a 12-year gap.

And a proposed water-sharing deal for the cross-border Teesta river has been stalled since 2011.

Relations between New Delhi and Dhaka have soured since Bangladesh's ex-leader Sheikh Hasina fled to old ally India, where she remains, following a 2024 uprising.

Ms. Hasina, sentenced to death in absentia for crimes against humanity, has vowed to return to Bangladesh from India in December, the month the treaty she signed expires.

Bangladesh's Prime Minister Tarique Rahman may also reportedly visit India before the treaty expires, but no visit has been confirmed.

Arguments date back to 1975, when India opened the 2.2-kilometre (1.3-mile) long Farakka Barrage. Bangladesh accused India of diverting most of the water. The United Nations intervened in the dispute and a deal was agreed in 1977. But water-sharing arrangements lapsed a decade later, bringing severe consequences, said Sheikh Rokon of Dhaka-based environmental group Riverine People.

"The Ganges suffered during the years without a treaty, and at least three rivers almost dried up," Mr. Rokon said.

One was the Gorai, which carries freshwater into the Sundarbans, the world's largest mangrove forest and a World Heritage site, helping limit saltwater intrusion as sea levels rise.

Bangladesh's Ganges-Kobadak Irrigation Project, designed to water 955 square kilometres (369 miles squared) of farmland, the country's largest, "became inoperative because of water scarcity", Rokon said.

In May, Dhaka approved the Padma Barrage, a $2.8-billion project intended to ease shortages and include a 113-megawatt hydropower plant.

'Disastrous situation'

The 1996 treaty has no automatic extension clause.

"If we fail to reach a deal, I fear the situation will be worse than what we experienced during the years without a treaty," Mr. Rokon added. "Demand for freshwater on both sides has increased significantly."

Even with the treaty in place, the Ganges-Kobadak project has shrunk to 550 square kilometres, according to Bangladeshi state news agency BSS.

"If the river does not carry enough water, the consequences could be disastrous," said Chowdhury Sarwar Jahan, a geology professor at Bangladesh's University of Rajshahi.

Bangladesh's agriculture-dependent economy is already reeling from the impact of climate change, which compounds shifting river flows, alternating dry-season shortages and intense monsoon floods washing away farmland and villages.

In Chapainawabganj district, the river has widened by three kilometres in recent years – nearly doubling its size – according to Bangladesh's Water Development Board.

Rehana Khatun, 50, described the "howling sound" as floods destroyed her home in Fielder Bazar village. "The river turned wild and started swallowing everything along the bank," said Ms. Khatun, who now lives in a bamboo shelter. "And the trauma stays with children long after the waters recede."

After 5th plenum, China's Communist Party takes steps to tighten discipline

Agence France-Presse
BEIJING



Guarded talks: Jingxi Hotel where the Communist Party held the fifth plenary session of the 20th Central panel in Beijing. REUTERS

Top officials from China's ruling Communist Party adopted measures to tighten discipline within their ranks at a key meeting in Beijing that concluded on Thursday, state media said.

The fifth plenum of the Central Committee, led by President Xi Jinping, adopted a decision on "advancing full and rigorous governance of the party", which includes reducing corruption among cadres, state news agency Xinhua said, without providing details on what those measures would entail.

Roughly 300 officials make up the Central Committee, whose plenums have previously represented key moments for Mr. Xi to cement his authority, with this year's being no different.

"The plenum seems to be used [to] prepare for Xi to secure another term at the 21st [Communist Party] Congress next year," Steve Tsang, director of the SOAS China Institute, told *AFP*.

"Tightening control, particularly in personnel matters, is a preparatory step to make sure his extension will go smoothly."

Despite speculation, Mr. Xi was not described in the readout as the "People's Leader", a designation that would have signalled further elevation of his stature.

The Chinese leader has waged a 14-year campaign against corruption that has ousted thousands of officials, including dozens of Central Committee members. Yet, he remains frustrated with cadres he deems are not implementing his orders.

'Unhealthy trends'

The plenum acknowledged that "party governance had been lax, superficial, and ineffective". By "turning the knife inwards and applying strict measures to curb disorder", the party had "put a stop to certain unhealthy trends that had gone unchecked...", it said.

As a result of his expansive purges, this year's plenum had the lowest turnout since former leader Mao Zedong's death in 1976, with eight Central Committee seats vacant prior to the meeting.

Fuming giant



Mount Semeru spews volcanic ash as thick clouds cover the peak, seen from Lumajang in East Java province, Indonesia, on Thursday. AFP

A year on, Tanzanians mourn poll massacre as critics face abductions, arrests

Agence France-Presse
DAR ES SALAAM

A year after Tanzania's bloody election, many remain traumatised by the violence, while government critics live in fear of abduction and arbitrary arrest, or facing treason and terrorism charges.

The October 29 election, in which President Samia Suluhu Hassan won with 98% of the vote after most of the Opposition was excluded, triggered days of protests that security forces brutally suppressed.

Rights groups and the Opposition say thousands were killed, while a government-appointed commission put the death toll at 518.

For 61-year-old Twaha Bomeza, life changed on election day when shrapnel lodged in his eye during a shootout to disperse protesters, leaving him in need of surgery he cannot afford.

"I tried to save myself, but I was shot. I fell down here and lost four front teeth," Mr. Bomeza told *AFP* on the streets of the economic capital, Dar es Salaam, displaying his dentures.

"I am still nursing an internal wound in my eyes," he said, adding that he now experiences shortness of breath and constant headaches. "My blood was spilled here, but a year has passed, and there is no more blood here," he added.

The Catholic Church held masses on Thursday to honour the victims, while the main Opposition party, Chadema, announced a seven-day mourning period.

"Tanzania has become a dictatorship – an authoritarian state that neither upholds the rule of law nor guarantees human rights," the Chadema said in a statement.

The streets of Dar es Salaam were quiet with a heavy police presence. "I feel sad today... As a nation, we need to learn that dialogue and negotiations are better than using massive force," churchgoer Noela Kigosi told *AFP* at one of the religious services.

'State of terror'

Tanzania has faced criticism from its western partners over the killings, and the U.S. ambassador warned on Thursday that they "will not be swept under the rug" in a post on X.



People light candles at a church in memory of victims of last year's election violence, in Dar es Salaam, Tanzania on Thursday. AFP

President Hassan, who was represented by her Prime Minister in Moscow this week for a Russia-Africa summit, has responded by trying to build closer ties with Moscow.

Tanzania is "tense", multiple analysts told *AFP*, with arbitrary arrests on the rise.

Another potential flashpoint is the treason trial of Opposition leader Tundu Lissu, whose verdict is due on November 6.

Mr. Lissu, who began a hunger strike this week to demand access to his lawyer, was arrested ahead of the election for championing a "no reform, no election" campaign.

"The country is not only in a mourning mood but also in a state of terror. We live in paranoia," rights activist Tito Magoti said.

Over the past week, another Opposition official, John Pambalu, was charged with treason, while a Tanzanian dissident, Twaha Mwaipaya, was abducted in Kenya and remains missing.

"The state is very nervous and they're ready to use a heavy-handed approach," Anna Bwana, director of civil society group Twaweza East Africa, told *AFP*.

"If you commemorate, then you're acknowledging what happened and you're acknowledging the numbers of those who lost their lives. And how can you commemorate when you're still kidnapping others," she said, adding that many had still not been able to bury their loved ones.

Fulgence Massawe, of the Legal and Human Rights Centre, said it was representing around 56 people facing terrorism-related charges as the state was trying to "silence all critics".

'Deny and delete'

Tanzania formed a presidential commission to investigate the election violence.

But, critics say it was established in "bad faith" to help the government "clean Tanzania's image" internationally.

"The state is trying to deny and delete the history of their complicity in the massacre that they conducted last year," Mr. Magoti said.

Amnesty International has criticised Tanzania for failing to hold those responsible to account, saying it was "weaponising counter-terrorism laws to silence critics and instill fear" instead.

Even if the state is suppressing the commemorations, many carry visible reminders.

Joseph Zakayo, 37, shows off a huge scar in his thigh where he was shot during the unrest. He can no longer operate his motorcycle taxi business. "My life has taken a major step backwards," he said.

SPINNING A WEB

Wily Warrican leads West Indies' fightback against Bangladesh



AFP

West Indies left-arm spinner Jomel Warrican took five wickets as Bangladesh was dismissed for 272 on day two of the first Test in Mirpur on Thursday. The visitors were 134 for four. **The scores:** Bangladesh 272 in 97.4 overs (Shadman 105, Hridoy 42, Warrican 5/53) vs. WI 134/4 in 48 overs (Campbell 54, Tagenarine 43 batting).

BACK TO WINNING WAYS

Duckett shines as England ends campaign on a bright note



AP

Ben Duckett hit 167 as England beat Sri Lanka by 55 runs to post a consolation win in the ODI tri-series in Lahore on Thursday. **The scores:** England 386/5 in 50 overs (Banton 74, Duckett 167, Brook 44, Cox 43) bt Sri Lanka 331 in 45.1 overs (Avishka 48, Kusal Mendis 89, Pavan 118, Dawson 4/49). **Toss:** Lanka; **PoM:** Duckett.

DREAM RUN

Rybakina makes sure of finishing the year as the No. 1 player



REUTERS

World No. 1 Elena Rybakina secured the year-end top ranking after beating fellow Kazakh Yulia Putintseva 6-2, 6-3 at the Pan-Pacific Open in Japan on Thursday. Rybakina became the No. 1 player for the first time last month during her winning run at the US Open, replacing Aryna Sabalenka at the summit.

SETBACK

Mirabai pulls out of World championships with back sprain



PTI

Mirabai Chanu pulled out of the women's 53kg competition due to a back sprain at the World weightlifting championships in Ningbo on Thursday. Gyaneshwari Yadav, the other Indian in fray in 53kg, competed in Group 'C' and finished an overall eighth with a total lift of 198kg, including 88kg in snatch and 110kg in clean and jerk.

India could be tempted to play Kuldeep and Varun

Having sealed the series, the visitor is likely to make a few changes in the last two games; the Kiwis will be hoping for a much improved show with the ball and a change of fortunes at the toss

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
AUCKLAND

India, with the series already sealed, will have the opportunity to give much-needed game time to the likes of Kuldeep Yadav and Varun Chakaravarthy when it takes on New Zealand in the fourth and penultimate T20 International here on Friday.

Both the spinners have played sporadically over the past couple of months with the team management packing the side with batters till No. 8.

But as stakes are significantly lower in the last two games, the Indians might just be tempted to experiment with their combination.



Wicket-takers: Both Kuldeep and Varun have the ability to strike in the middle overs. CREIMAS/BCCI

While Varun has battled indifferent form over the past six months, Kuldeep has time and again underlined his immense value to the side by picking up wickets in the middle overs.

In the pace bowling department, veteran Bhuvneshwar Kumar showed flashes of brilliance in the death overs of the previous game in Wellington, landing yorkers consistently in his final over.

However, he has been a tad expensive with 139 runs conceded off his 72 balls in the first three games.

Prince Yadav was preferred in place of Mayank Yadav in the last two games. It remains to be seen if Mayank returns for more game time or the team sticks with the impressive Prince.

There is still no clarity on the availability of Ishan Kishan, who missed the last two matches due to a groin injury.

Nitish Reddy has been playing ahead of Shivam Dube but now with the series in the bag, the former could be rested.

For New Zealand, the biggest challenge has been posed by the Indian top-order. Captain Mitchell Santner has been excellent with his left-arm spin but has not got much support from his teammates.

For starters, Santner would be hoping to win the toss for the first time in the series. Considering the conditions, bowling first has been the preferred template.

After Matt Henry, Lockie Ferguson has also been ruled out of the series due to a calf injury.

Match starts at 12.30 p.m. IST.



Tilak. CREIMAS/BCCI

'Batting at No. 5 makes me go for it from ball one'

Press Trust of India
AUCKLAND

India vice-captain Tilak Varma says moving down from No. 3 to 5 in the batting order has led to a slight change in his mindset and he now eyes boundaries from ball one instead of trying to settle in first.

"I already had the power game; I have scored runs at (number) three as well. Now, batting at number five or six, I think about going for a boundary off the very first ball only if it's there to be hit," he said ahead of the fourth T20I here.

"Otherwise, I focus on taking the game deep. I take a bit more time. Initially, I focus on singles and doubles, finding gaps for fours," he added.

Tilak said the team is determined to make it 5-0. "We are thinking this is a great opportunity to achieve a clean sweep".

Klinger happy with Giants' purchases at WPL mini auction

P.K. Ajith Kumar
KOCHI

The last time Michael Klinger came to Kochi he was an IPL player. A decade and a half later, he is back as coach of WPL franchise Gujarat Giants.

The Aussie, who played three T20Is and was a run machine in domestic cricket down under, will probably fly back to Melbourne in a happy frame of mind, having got what he wanted from Wednesday's mini auction.

G. Kamalini was the player he was most keen on. And the Giants got her for her base price of ₹40 lakh. He is also glad that he could rope in Ireland's Orla Prendergast.

"We had a really good squad before the auction and had a lot of bases covered, but to top up with some players who can easily play in the starting eleven for us was our main aim," Klinger told *The Hindu* on Thursday.

"So now we have got some difficult decisions to make come WPL time. But they are good problems."

Having made the playoffs in the last two editions, Klinger believes he has the team that could go all the way this time. "We have a mix of experienced players and youngsters," he said. "It is great to have champion players like Beth Mooney, Ashleigh Gardner and Sophie Devine."



Klinger. R.K. NITHIN

I was very happy to see Yastika score hundred for India in the Lord's Test

There are exciting Indian talents like Yastika Bhatia. "I was very happy to see Yastika score that hundred for India in the Lord's Test on her comeback after injury," he says. "I think she could play in the Indian T20 team too, purely as a batter."

Looking back to his own career as a prolific batter, he says it is alright that he could only play three matches for Australia, in which he made 38, 43 and 62, against Sri Lanka in 2017. He amassed 24,729 runs across First Class, List A and T20s.

At the IPL, he played for Kochi Tuskers, which existed for just that one season in 2011.

Sindhu enters the last eight; Malvika and Isharani exit

Press Trust of India
SAARBRUCKEN (GERMANY)

P.V. Sindhu stormed into the quarterfinals of the Hylo Open Super 500 badminton tournament with a 21-9, 21-6 win over France's Rosy Oktavia Pancasari on Thursday. However, Malvika Bansod and Isharani Baruah bowed out.

Malvika went down to Canada's Wen Yu Zhang 11-21, 17-21 while Isharani lost to eighth seed Line Hojmark Kjaersfeldt of Denmark 14-21, 19-21.

Australia seizes the advantage

Agencies
CAPE TOWN

Nathan Lyon dismissed captain Temba Bavuma late on the third day as Australia pressed for a series-deciding victory in the third Test against South Africa at Newlands on Thursday. At close, South Africa was 140 for four in the second innings, 40 runs ahead with six wickets remaining.

The scores: South Africa 329 & 140/4 in 47 overs (Ackerman 62) vs. Australia 429 in 125.1 overs (Renshaw 74, Inglis 102, Carey 80, Harmer 4/104).

India registers hard-fought victory over a spirited China

ACT

Uthra Ganesan
JALANDHAR

India coach Craig Fulton had admitted that the Chinese team at the Asian Champions Trophy was unknown and it was difficult to plan against. India was clearly the better side but struggled to find the gaps before prevailing 5-2 on Thursday.

After the goal-fest against Bangladesh, India was up against a Chinese side with a very clear plan – pack the midfield, deny the home team space on the ground and force it to go in the air, then defend with everything they have. It almost worked, the Indians having to adapt, relying on their experience to enter not only the Chinese circle but also to keep them at bay.

A long aerial pass from India's 25-yard line by Jugraj Singh was controlled just inside the circle by Sukhjeet Singh. He carried it a couple of steps ahead on the stick before unleashing a rasping hit over the head of the advancing goalkeeper Huanyu Wu in the 12th minute.



In the limelight: Harmanpreet scored a brace. X@THEHOCKEYINDIA

To China's credit, its structure held firm with a counterattack and a couple of shots on goal.

It finally levelled through Yang Peng's penalty corner conversion in the 26th minute, only for Mandeep Singh to be checked on a counter and hand India a PC of its own. Harmanpreet Singh made no mistake to restore the lead.

The big positive was India's sustained momentum either side of the break, something Fulton has admitted as frustratingly lacking. Two goals ins the first four minutes on resumption of action made it 4-1, Harmanpreet and Sukhjeet adding one each.

Another PC in the 36th minute for China and another goal made it 4-2 before Jugraj Singh got on the scoresheet with a PC.

Fulton would also be happy with India's pace and the fact that not only the aerials were used to good effect but also the midfield's ability to constantly rotate and stretch the opposition thin to move ahead.

The results: India 5 (Sukhjeet Singh 12, 34, Harmanpreet Singh 27-pc, 31-pc, Jugraj Singh 47-pc) bt China 2 (Yang Peng 26-pc, Chen Chongcong 36-pc); Malaysia 3 (Azimuddin Kamaruddin 10, Akhimullah Anuar 36-pc, Faizal Saari 50) bt Korea 1 (Song Haeseong 31); Japan 1 (Raiki Fujishima 40-pc) bt Bangladesh 0.

Former Dortmund star Schmelzer recalls the *Der Klassiker* battles

FOOTBALL

P.K. Ajith Kumar
KOCHI

Marcel Schmelzer has featured in *Der Klassiker* on several occasions. He has played for Borussia Dortmund in 14 seasons of Bundesliga, after all.

Dortmund's clash on Saturday with Bayern Munich would be a new experience for him. He would be watching the match along with Dortmund's fans in Kochi, at Padma Theatre here.

Schmelzer, who is in the city for the Bundesliga 'Z' Football Week, is looking forward to the game. After ending his career as a defender at Dortmund in 2022, he has taken up a coaching job at the club.

The former captain has fond memories of *Der Klassiker*. "My most cherished memory is our 5-2 win in the Cup final in 2012," he said. "It was an amazing game and an amazing season. I am hoping that we will get three points against Bayern on Saturday, too."

Schmelzer, who played 16 games for Germany, is part of the Dortmund coaching staff that will conduct a clinic for local players and conduct workshops for trainers. This is a joint venture by Zee Entertainment and Bundesliga Eagles FC as the local partner.



Schmelzer. THULASI KAKKAT

Eagle FC's chairman Shaffi Mather said the response from young players and coaches was excellent.

"We are glad that we could bring the Dortmund's coaches to Kochi," he said. "And Dortmund has a strong following here. There is a registered fans association for the club here."

Suresh Letchmanan, Managing Director, Asia-Pacific, Borussia Dortmund, said developing young talent was an important part of the club's philosophy.

Ankur star attraction as main draw begins today

WTT FEEDER CHENNAI

K. Keerthivasan
CHENNAI

India will have brute strength in numbers – and the seedings to match – when the three-day main draw of the World Table Tennis Feeder Chennai gets underway at the Tamil Nadu Physical Education and Sports University near here on Friday.

The host will look to turn its numerical advantage into a rich medal haul.

India has seeded players in all five categories – men's and women's singles, men's and women's doubles, and mixed doubles. It does not hold the top seed tag in just one event: women's singles where South Korea's Yang Ha Eun (World No. 64) leads the field.

The spotlight is likely to fall on Ankur Bhattacharjee, one of India's most exciting young paddlers. The 19-year-old, ranked 73 in the world, has enjoyed an impressive year, winning the WTT Feeder men's singles title in Olomouc (Czechia), finishing runner-up in Puerto Princesa (Philippines) and reaching the semifinals in Prishtina (Kosovo) and Istanbul. The reigning Commonwealth champion is confident of adding another singles title and a doubles crown with Akash Pal where the pair is the No. 1 seed.



In prime shape: Ankur believes he is mentally and physically at his best. FILE PHOTO: SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

"I am mentally and physically at my best, and I feel I can win here, too," Ankur, the second seed, told *The Hindu*.

Top seed Manav Thakkar (World No. 49), G. Sathiyan (85) and Harmeet Desai (101) will be Ankur's main challengers.

In the absence of Yashaswini Ghorparde, third seed Divyanshi Bhowmick, (111) will be eyeing a second Feeder crown in women's singles.

The qualifiers: Men:
Singles: Neil Mulye, Divyansh Srivastava, Rupam Sardar, Shridhar Joushi, Nikunj Attri, Sahil Rawat, Arjav Gupta and Jungmok Lee (Kor).
Doubles: Sounav Barman & Priyanshu Karmakar, Soham Mukherjee & Rupam Sardar, Rajiv Sahu & Aaron Farias, Shridhar Joushi & Rahul Malik.

Women: Kavya Baskar, Subhankrita Datta, Swara Karmarkar, Sampada Bhiwandkar, Ananya Chande, Avisha Karmakar, Garima Goyal and Kim Seoyun (Kor).
Doubles: Avisha Karmakar & Aarushi Nandi, Ditsa Roy & Subhankrita Datta, Sataporni De & Gungun Sahu, Advika Agrawal & Shriya Anand.
Mixed doubles: Shridhar Joushi & Pritha Vartikar, Rupam Sardar & Subhankrita Datta, Mehan Senthil & Ananya Muralidharan, Divyansh Srivastava & Ananya Chande.

INBRIEF



Vihari not to turn out for Tripura this Ranji season

Batter Hanuma Vihari will not turn out for Tripura in this season's Ranji Trophy, the northeast side's head coach Satrajit Lahiri confirmed. "Vihari has informed us that he will not play this season because of personal reasons. I don't know what they are. It's a big blow because last season he scored a lot of runs," Lahiri said after Tripura lost to Karnataka in its Ranji Trophy match at Mysuru on Thursday.

India loses to Afghanistan in FIFA u-15 WC and Festival

India lost 1-2 to Afghanistan in the quarterfinals for positions 81 to 88 in the FIFA u-15 World Cup and Festival in Baku on Thursday. The Blue Colts will face Kazakhstan, which lost to Hungary, in the semifinals for positions 85 to 88.

The result: Afghanistan 2 (Mohammad Mustafa 15, Shahzada Sultani 27) bt India 1 (Nibas Meetei Wahengbam 36).



Inter leaves it late, Mbangula helps Bologna sink AC Milan

Inter Milan returned to the Serie A summit with a nervy 2-0 win at bottom side Venezia on Wednesday, while a Samuel Mbangula, *in pic*, hat-trick sealed a 4-2 win for Bologna at San Siro to inflict a first league defeat of the season on AC Milan.

The results: AC Milan 2 (Cisse 14, 27) lost to Bologna 4 (Mbangula 8, 62, 86, Bartesaghi 60-og); Parma 0 drew with Udinese 0; Venezia 0 lost to Inter Milan 2 (Moreno 80-og, Halhal 82-og); Genoa 2 (Ehizibue 12, Baldanzi 28) bt Juventus 0; Monza 1 (Varela 43) lost to Napoli 4 (Hojlund 10, Politano 48, Marin 62, De Bruyne 67).

WTA Chennai Open: Shrivalli, Diya get qualifying wild cards

Shrivalli Bhamidipaty, ranked 640, and Tamil Nadu's Diya Ramesh have been given qualifying wild cards for the WTA Chennai Open 250 starting on Saturday. Shrivalli is making a comeback after recovering from a back injury. Last year, she reached the second round of the main draw.

Espanyol unveils Sarabia as new coach

Eder Sarabia was unveiled as Espanyol's new coach on Wednesday, a day after Manolo Gonzalez was sacked following the club's first round Copa del Rey defeat by fourth division Sestao River. Sarabia, 46, was the head coach of Andorra and then Elche, which he guided into La Liga.



Yusha and Unnati claim National u-19 squash crowns

Uttar Pradesh's Yusha Nafees and Unnati Tripathi clinched the boys' and girls' u-19 titles in the National sub-junior and junior squash championships in Jaipur on Thursday.

The results (all finals): Boys: U-19: Yusha Nafees (U.P.) bt Purav Rambhia (Mah) 11-9, 11-6, 11-6; **u-17:** Hridhaan Shah (Mah) bt Shiven Agarwal (TN) 11-8, 8-11, 11-2, 9-11, 11-2; **u-15:** Dhruv Johri (Har) bt Vedant Agarwal (Jha) 11-6, 11-8, 11-4; **u-13:** Aaron Arambhan (Mah) bt S.K. Aryan (Kar) 11-1, 11-7, 12-10; **u-11:** Agastya Uppal (Del) bt Yuvaan Verma (Raj) 11-9, 6-11, 11-5, 11-6.
Girls: U-19: Unnati Tripathi (U.P.) bt Akanksha Gupta (Mah) 8-11, 11-8, 11-2, 11-5; **u-17:** Saanvi Kalanki (MP) bt Riyansika Verma (Kar) 9-11, 11-5, 11-5, 11-7; **u-15:** Divyanshi Jain (Raj) bt Anika Kalanki (MP) 11-8, 11-2, 11-8; **u-13:** Alia Kankaria (WB) bt Riyaa Dalal (Mah) 11-13, 11-6, 12-10, 8-11, 11-7; **u-11:** Inaya Andrabi (Raj) bt Gaurvi Ajmera (Raj) 12-10, 11-5, 9-11, 5-11, 11-7.

Karnataka gets campaign back on track with innings victory

Leggie Shreyas returns a five-wicket haul to bowl out Tripura for 180 after seamers Vyshak and Manvanth strike early on the final day; home team coach Vinay wants more from from his batters

RANJI TROPHY

Ashwin Achal
MYSURU

Karnataka's wait for a first win ended with an innings and 116-run drubbing of Tripura in their Ranji Trophy Elite Group B match here on Thursday.

Having managed just two points from their previous two outings, the victory and the seven points it earned offered Karnataka some breathing room.

The home team wrapped up the proceedings shortly after lunch on the final day. Contrary to expectations, seamers V. Vyshak and Manvanth Kumar did the early damage on a last-day pitch, claiming two wickets apiece.

Vyshak triggered the slide by removing night-watcher Parvez Sultan (14) before taking out a well-set Sridam Paul (50, 81b, 2x4, 3x6), who

edged one to wicket-keeper K.L. Shrijith.

Manvanth then joined the party by dismissing Tripura skipper Manisankar Murasingh for eight. Shrijith followed up with a stunning one-handed catch to send Sentu Sarkar (15) back to the pavilion.



Wrecker-in-chief: Shreyas, right, ran through the Tripura lower-order to wrap up the contest. K. MURALI KUMAR

Leg-spinner Shreyas Gopal cleaned up the tail soon after the break.

Karnataka head coach Vinay Kumar was pleased to register his first win in charge, but admitted that the team's performance had been far from convincing. "If you ask me, we definitely could have done much, much better as a team. The kind of standard we have as the Karnataka team – a much better performance is expected from the players," Vinay said candidly.

Karnataka's lack of attacking intent with the bat against an inexperienced Tripura attack was hardly befitting a team with championship ambitions.

"We could have definitely batted a bit more freely. But when I spoke to the batters, they said the pitch was not that easy. It was keeping low. With smaller teams like this (Tripura), they know their business and stick to the basics. That is why the batters felt it was not that easy to score runs," Vinay said.

"We could have been a bit more aggressive, especially because we hadn't won our previous two games," he added.

The scores: Tripura — 1st innings: 194.

Karnataka — 1st innings: 490/9 decl.

Tripura — 2nd innings: Bikramkumar Das c Mayank b Shreyas 26, Hrituraj Roy c Rohan b Shreyas 13, Babul Dey lbw b Shreyas 28, Sridam Paul c Shrijith b Vyshak 50, Parvez Sultan c Rohan b Vyshak 14, Mandeep Singh (not out) 20, Manisankar Murasingh c Shrijith b Manvanth 8, Sentu Sarkar c Shrijith b Manvanth 15, Bikramjit Debnath c Shrijith b Shreyas 3, Sandip Sarkar run out 0, Abhijit Sarkar b Shreyas 0; Extras (b-1, lb-2): 3; Total (in 78.1 overs): 180.

Fall of wickets: 1-33, 2-46, 3-96, 4-128, 5-133, 6-145, 7-163, 8-178, 9-179.

Karnataka bowling: Manvanth 10-1-42-2, Vyshak 15-6-31-2, Shreyas 23.1-6-36-5, Bhatkal 8-1-16-0, Shikhar 22-5-52-0.

RANJI TROPHY SCORES – ROUND THREE, DAY FOUR

Elite:
Group A:
At Vadodara: Baroda 616 drew with J&K 303 & 316/6 in 96 overs (Sahil Lotra 96 n.o., Abdul Samad 143). **Points: Baroda 3(17), J&K 1(2).**
At Nagpur: Goa 220 & 195 in 76 overs (Manthan Khutkar 70, Shivendra Bhujbal 45 n.o., Harsh Dubey 4/38) lost to Vidarbha 442/8 decl. **Vidarbha 7(19), Goa 0(0).**
At Puducherry: Uttar Pradesh 333 drew with Pondicherry 172 & 211/8 in 98 overs (Ritesh Gudge 41, Aman Khan 62, Kartik Yadav 6/42). **U.P. 3(16), Pondicherry 1(2).**
Group B:
At Vijayawada: Andhra 231 & 184/3 decl. in 32 overs (Ricky Bhui 72 n.o., Karan Shinde 53 n.o.) lost to Chhattisgarh 237 in 107.3 overs (Amandeep Khare 89 n.o., T. Vijay 4/76) & 182/5 in 35.1 overs (Anuj Tiwary 60). **Chhattisgarh 6(7), Andhra 0(3).**
At Hyderabad: Punjab 431 & 240/6 decl. in 78 overs (Vihaan Malhotra 53, Prabhhsimran Singh 68, Uday Saharan 55 n.o.) drew with Hyderabad 380. **Punjab 3(12), Hyderabad 1(14).**
At Mysuru: Tripura 194 & 180 in 78.1 overs (Sridam Paul 50, Shreyas Gopal 5/36) lost to Karnataka 490/9 decl. **Karnataka 7(9), Tripura 0(0).**
At Rajkot: Assam 281 & 94 in 44 overs (Parth Bhut 8/17) lost to Saurashtra 387 in 131.4 overs. **Saurashtra 7(13), Assam 0(7).**
Group C:
At Ranchi: Delhi 515/5 decl. drew with Jharkhand 131/4 in 47 overs. No play on fourth day. **Delhi 1(4), Jharkhand 1(5).**
At Bhubaneswar: Odisha 194 drew with Services 40/0 in 12 overs. **Odisha 1(1), Services 1(1).**
At Pune: Gujarat 223 & 446/5 decl. in 101.1 overs (Aarya Desai 151, Jaymeet Patel 119 n.o., Urvil Patel 96) drew with Maharashtra 330 & 141/4 in 47 overs (Digvijay Patil 55 n.o.). **Maharashtra 3(12), Gujarat 1(9).**
At Thiruvananthapuram: Bengal 350 & 198 bt Kerala 141 & 120 in 38.4 overs (Pradipta Pramanik 6/51). **Bengal 6(18), Kerala 0(8).**
Group D:
At Dehradun: Rajasthan 272 & 290/5 decl. in 101.4 overs drew with Uttarakhand 194 & 38/0 in 9 overs. No play on fourth day. **Rajasthan 3(9), Uttarakhand 1(4).**
At Chandigarh: Chandigarh 685/5 decl. drew with Himachal Pradesh 559/6 in 177 overs (Innesh Mahajan 121, Shubham Arora 96, Pukhraj Mann 51, Vaibhav Kalta 82, Akash Vashist 126 n.o.). **Chandigarh 1(1), Himachal 1(1).**
At Mumbai: Mumbai 430 & 97/0 in 10.4 overs (Angkrish Raghuvanshi 67 n.o.) bt Haryana 270 & 256 in 85.3 overs (Himanshu Rana 46, Nishant Sindhu 44, Samant Jakhar 40, Anuj Thakral 40 n.o., Tanush Kotian 8/81). **Mumbai 7(21), Haryana 0(13).**
Plate:
At Rangpo: Nagaland 187 & 208 drew with Sikkim 184 & 117/5 in 46 overs. **Nagaland 3(4), Sikkim 1(9).**
At Ahmedabad: Arunachal Pradesh 111 & 431 lost to Manipur 364 & 180/6 in 48.4 overs (Ronald Longjam 70 n.o., Langlonyamba Keishangbam 51). **Manipur 6(12), Arunachal 0(0).**
At Nadiad: Meghalaya 562 & 60/2 decl. in 22 overs drew with Mizoram 430 in 168.2 overs (Lalhruaizela 51, Chinmay Sutar 125, Joseph Lalthankhuma 95, Khiangte Vanrotlinga 66, Abhishek Kumar 5/95). **Meghalaya 3(12), Mizoram 1(4).**

Rigorous training routine works wonders for Badoni

Vivek Krishnan
RANCHI

As the persistent drizzle prevailed and prevented any play on the final two days of the Ranji Trophy contest between Jharkhand and Delhi, Ayush Badoni flashed a shy smile. The 26-year-old's expression was emblematic of his mixed emotions at the end as he was adjudged the Player-of-the-Match for his fourth double hundred in First Class cricket in a rain-marred draw.

Badoni's individual accolade, for scoring an unbeaten 210 on Tuesday, came after the fourth day's play was called off by noon on Thursday. Both teams had to be content with a point each.

Delhi would be justified to be annoyed by the gloomy weather. It had reduced the host to 131 for four after amassing 515 for five declared in its first innings. "We were well ahead. It is unfortunate that the rain played spoilsport, and we have not been able to get six points," skipper Badoni told *The Hindu* after the game.



Making a statement: Badoni won the Player-of-the-Match award for his unbeaten 210. R.V. MOORTHY

The stalemate shouldn't detract from Badoni's prolific form. He has racked up double tons in his last two games, bolstering his First Class average to a formidable 63.84.

The middle-order batter explains his current surge as a response to two subpar red-ball outings for India-A, against Australia-A and South Africa-A, in 2025.

"Last season, the games didn't go very well for India-A. I wanted to make a statement. The dream is to play for India. So, I am just thinking now to make as many runs as possible and not give away my wicket," he said.

A rigorous training routine, in keeping with the demands of the format, has also worked wonders.

"Having played two to three Ranji seasons, I realised that I needed to alter my preparation," Badoni revealed.

"In the build-up to this season, I practised for six hours of batting in a day. We play for six hours everyday in a Ranji game. So I trained like that from morning to evening, with breaks for lunch and tea".

Indian Navy and Army ensure semifinal spots

MURUGAPPA GOLD CUP

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI

Indian Navy sealed the second semifinal berth from Pool-B with a 4-2 victory over Malaysia Junior Team in the 97th All-India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup hockey tournament at the SDAT Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium here on Thursday.

Indian Army advanced as the second team from Pool-A after Railways and Punjab National Bank (PNB) played out a 4-4 draw. The result denied PNB the seven-goal winning margin it needed to qualify.

Navy will face Pool-A topper and defending champion Indian Railways in Saturday's semifinal, while Pool-B winner Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd. (BPCL) will take on Army.

Navy, which needed only a draw to progress, dominated play and created several scoring opportunities. It took the lead in the eighth minute through Bhavin Kushalappa after Sushil Dhanwar had struck the left post two minutes earlier.



On target: Selvaraj poised to fire in Navy's second goal. R. RAGU

Malaysia drew level in the 27th minute when Muhamad Harith scored from close range, having earlier sent a shot just over the bar.

Navy regained the lead in the 30th minute. Sanjit Toppo's drag-flick off Pawan Rajbhar's penalty-corner delivery was deflected into the net by K. Selvaraj.

Rajbhar extended the lead in the 36th minute with a close-range flick into the top of the net. Nitesh made it 4-1 in the 43rd minute, before Muhammad Aizat pulled one back for Malaysia a minute later, diving to push the ball past a defender from close range.

The results: Pool-A: Indian Railways 4 (Sheshe Gowda 26-pc & 28-pc, Lovepreet Singh 31, Jaswinder Singh 47) drew with Punjab National Bank 4 (Gursimran Singh 11-pc, Naveen Antil 57, 59 & 60).

Pool-B: Indian Navy 4 (Bhavin Kushalappa 8, K. Selvaraj 30-pc, Pawan Rajbhar 36, Nitesh 43) bt Malaysia Junior Team 2 (Muhamad Harith 27, Muhammad Aizat 44).

First thought was always to come back to Blasters: Luna

ISL

Sankar Narayanan E.H.

The footballing landscape has shifted in India and Keralam since Adrian Luna had to leave Kerala Blasters FC on loan to Persik.

In the time he was away from his beloved KBFC, the State added an 'm' to its name, the club welcomed new owners from the UAE, and the Indian Super League – after a truncated and delayed season that led to Luna's exit – moved to a club-led model.

Luna, a household name in Keralam since 2021, admitted he was relieved when he finally got the message to return 'home'. "If you have to wait six months to get the deal, it affects you as you don't know when or if you will start. But once you begin training, you forget about this," Luna told *The Hindu* during a virtual interaction on Thursday.



Fan favourite: Luna... one of KBFC's own. FILE PHOTO: THULASI KAKKAT

"When nobody speaks to you, you start thinking, 'maybe this is it?' But until anyone told me it was over, I didn't look for any other options. My first thought was always to come back to Kerala."

The 34-year-old Uruguayan said he agreed to the Indonesian loan strictly to "help out the club" through a tough spot.

"Everybody knows what happened in Indian football. I told the previous owner, 'I don't want to go, but I will because you are asking me to help you.'

"I had a conversation with my mom and she said: 'These people helped you when you were very low, so you have to pay them back'. In gratitude, I decided to go," he explained.

Luna insists he doesn't worry too much about who owns the club or runs the league.

"Football is football. When you step on the pitch, you don't think about who's running the league or who is the boss. You just play like when you were a kid."

On head coach Ashley Westwood choosing Indian players for captaincy this season, Luna said: "My role doesn't change with or without the armband. It's the coach's decision. I still have the same commitment and respect for everyone at the club."

Through all the turmoil at KBFC, Luna never once doubted the bond between the team and its supporters, the Manjappada.

"You stand with your club like you stand with your family. I understand they were disappointed by past results, which is fair. But I knew they would return because this is the club they love, and it's a way of life here".

Manisha in the title round

Sports Bureau

Manisha Bhanwala (59kg) was the third Indian woman to enter the final at the World wrestling championships in Astana on Thursday. Manisha shocked World championships bronze medallist Laurence Beauregard by pinning the Canadian in the second period.

Then she beat Mongolian Olympian Bolortuya Khurelkhuu 6-0 and pinned Kazakhstan's World under-23 bronze medallist Altyn Shagayeva to reach the title clash.

In men's freestyle, Vicky (97kg) was defeated 12-2 by Japan's Asian champion and Worlds bronze medallist Arash Yoshida in the quarterfinals.



Vaishnavi — India's new orchestrator



The left-arm spinner may not have burst onto the scene but is making a case for herself with stellar performances for the National team. Those who have followed her from close quarters believe that the 20-year-old is just getting started

Lavanya L.
VADODARA

The year was 2025. Left-arm spinner Vaishnavi Sharma had made her T20I debut for India against Sri Lanka in Visakhapatnam. She went wicketless but conceded only 16 runs in her four-over spell. After the game, she was snapped sheepishly skirting around the press conference room.

"*Jis baat ka dar tha, wahi hua mere saath* (What I feared has happened to me)," a nervous Vaishnavi had told the BCCI videoperson tailing players for their post-match vlog.

Almost a year and seven India fixtures later, Vaishnavi – now 14 wickets old in international cricket – was not any less nervous when entering the sprawling but sparsely populated media room at the BCA Stadium in Kotambi. She had just taken a sensational five-wicket haul to help India clinch the third ODI against Zimbabwe. This after coolly picking four wickets in the second fixture a few days earlier.

"*Aise kya?* (Is that so?) I am surprised," Chandrakant Pandit, director of cricket at the Madhya Pradesh Cricket Association, exclaimed on hearing about her jitters.

The Vaishnavi he knows is not someone he associates fear or hesitation with. "When I began at Madhya Pradesh in this capacity, I was looking for young talent to give them exposure. Vaishnavi was around 13 then, if I remember correctly," he told *The Hindu*.

"We had a truncated BCCI short-format tournament right after the Covid-19 pandemic. BCCI allowed us to field a squad of 22 because no one could enter or leave the bio-bubble. Vaishnavi was selected and immediately showed promise. It was more about her attitude than her bowling. So I put that 13-year-old in the senior team."

Pandit is not an easy man to impress. He's known to like discipline and order. So it meant something when he said he had not seen a player more confident when approaching him. He quite happily played into that confidence by constantly telling her, "You should be playing for India."

Competition for places

Vaishnavi has not been a regular starter in the National side. India's experiments with a seam-heavy attack and fellow left-arm tweaker N. Shree Charani's meteoric success mean Vaishnavi has had to bite her cheek and wait. She was not selected for India's T20 World Cup campaign in England and Wales a few months ago.

"Something about her destiny has always been like this," Lovekesh Chaudhary, her childhood coach and relative, said.

"For the under-19 T20 World Cup, she wasn't picked initially but was later chosen... she did splendidly. In the Women's Premier League, she didn't get picked first and was then roped in as a replacement. She also missed the World Cup. With Vaishnavi, things get delayed, but they eventually happen. She's not the one to sit back and feel bad that a chance was lost. She is beyond this stuff. It pushes her even more," he explained.

Having two left-arm spinners opens both up for scrutiny, often by being pitted against each other. Shree Charani is a taller bowler and is fast through the air. Vaishnavi is shorter, more loopy and uses her fingers to give the ball more revolutions.

Shree Charani likes squeezing the batters for space while Vaishnavi draws them out, uses width to trick them with turn. But Vaishnavi knows comparisons barely matter if one doesn't use the chance presented to them. It's what helped her dust off the disappointment of missing out on the World Cup.

"The months between my T20I debut and now were good (even if she missed the tournament)," Vaishnavi said after the game on Wednesday.

"I got a good gap to work on myself, to get stronger physically and mentally. It gave me space to figure out the requirements of the game, be it with the ball, bat or in the field. I had the space to develop my game a little more," she added.

During this time, Chaudhary, her 'Chandu sir', coaches of the Madhya Pradesh team and the BCCI's Centre of Excellence and India bowling coach Aavishkar Salvi were voices in her airwaves. But this wasn't a 'too many cooks' situation. There was synergy in what everyone wanted Vaishnavi to master.

"First, [they taught me] to stay calm," she chuckled. "They wanted me to follow the batter from start to finish and repeat that constantly to get better results."

Bhawna Srivastava, the MP u-19 women's coach who saw Vaishnavi as a raw spinner eager to master control, remembered how the desperation to play brought an inkling of doubt to her approach to cricket.

"Serious conversations with her happen rarely. She spoke about working on her batting so she could evolve as an all-rounder. It's hard to stay patient, but it is important. Just one wall had to break and she'd get through," Bhawna said.

The value of repetition

Training under Chaudhary and at the MPCA had some fortunate intersections. Both involved mixed gender training hours. Both believed in allowing youngsters time with senior players for skills to evolve.

Somewhere, it also helped Vaishnavi figure out settling into a side with people far more experienced. Much like the Indian National team.

"Vaishnavi played in the higher divisions and also with the u-19 boys in training. Yashbardhan Singh Chauhan, who has captained the India u-19 team, is among the players who train at my academy (Tansen Academy). There are a few others who have played the Ranji Trophy and Cooch Behar Trophy. Vaishnavi has trained alongside them," Chaudhary revealed.

Whenever Vaishnavi is in Gwalior, training goes on for a six-hour block from morning till evening with Lovekesh. She has worked extensively on using the crease, using her fingers to give more revolutions to the ball and more. There's also knowledge exchange with fellow spinners.

Bhawna believes Vaishnavi's probing quality as a person trumps that same gene as a player. "She was quite curious right from the start. The mindset was to keep taking wickets... she'd have a lot of questions if she wasn't able to and would chart out the next course of action. She always wants to learn, it is why she has made it this far," Bhawna felt.

In the two ODIs she featured in recently, Vaishnavi hurled her bag of variations at the Zimbabweans, who had no answers. Her 37 dots bowled in the second game were the joint second-most (along with Sayali Satghare), while she had 46 dot balls in the third fixture, the best in that clash.

"She bowled from around the wicket because the batters were stepping out. These are things she didn't instinctively know before, it is good to see her implementing the things she is learning," Bhawna added.

Target practice became a key part of training.

"I've worked on gaining more control of the ball. I worked on a single wicket and bowled deliveries into one particular spot. It's a simple strategy with a focus on the stump line. My coaches also pushed me to have greater belief in my stock ball," Vaishnavi said.

Innovations within variations

She's also tried to use potentially slow surfaces, like the one that the BCA strip eventually became, to even attempt innovations within variations. "If you can manage more revs on the ball, it will turn... you could also deploy the arm ball against certain batters. It was a good bowling surface."

Despite not being as tall as someone like Shree Charani, Vaishnavi can dip the ball, something Chaudhary calls "a natural gift". Her evolving flight, however, has come from years of innovating against older players and taller male batters in training.

She made it to the MP senior team when she about 13, revealed Pandit

"When she started out, there weren't many revs on the ball when she bowled. We made her understand that the ball's spin is in our hands. Getting turn or not, meanwhile, isn't; that's on the pitch. We see her doing drills to keep the rotation in the hand," Bhawna said.

"We do see a marked improvement in how she's doing it. She's able to spin the ball on any kind of pitch and manage decent turn in the process. It's a big plus point."

Just one flipside though. An intelligent cricketer also always wants the validation of return. Wickets are a bit of an obsession for the cherubic, jovial tweaker.

"I called her after she took four wickets in the second game. Towards the end, she kept saying, 'God, please give me one more wicket'," and the TV mics caught it. So I told her: 'Speak carefully, Vaishnavi, everyone's listening'," Chaudhary quipped. "But in all that fun and games, there's aggression. She is hungry for wickets and is a fighter," he said, proudly.

For Pandit, the worry has always been to ensure confidence doesn't become overconfidence. "She is a bold bowler and she feels like she needs to deploy variations with every ball she bowls. I keep telling her that it might not always work and that it might not always be necessary

"You can learn to settle into a rhythm and then change it up. But she wants a wicket at any cost. I keep reminding her that it might backfire if she loses her line. She's a match-winner, but needs to stay grounded as well," he explained.

The impact of that intervention is visible. Vaishnavi was expensive on her ODI debut against Australia in Hobart earlier this year, going at 8.5 runs an over in her four-over spell. Zimbabwe is a weaker batting side, but she will be buoyed by a stingy 3.9 economy rate. In the third game, though, constantly varying the line and length also resulted in a no ball and five wides, something Pandit has noted down for later.

Bhawna is silently hoping that the innocence in her finds a way to endure. "That excitement she has, that's what makes a player perform. Once that goes away, one starts getting very jaded with their craft. I hope she finds a way to keep that sense of wonder in her as she goes along," Bhawna said.

The work doesn't stop for the 20-year-old. She's already called Pandit to book coaching blocks. "She's a bold girl. This is only the start," he added.

Vaishnavi has been late to every list and early to every wicket. Sooner or later, history will stop keeping track of the difference.

CREIMAS BCCI

THE GIST

- India's experiments with a seam-heavy attack and fellow left-arm tweaker Shree Charani's meteoric success mean Vaishnavi has had to bite her cheek and wait
- In the two ODIs she featured in recently, Vaishnavi hurled her bag of variations at the Zimbabweans, who had no answers
- Her practice sessions under Chaudhary and at the MPCA have involved mixed gender training. It has helped her evolve

Whenever Vaishnavi is in Gwalior, training goes on for a six-hour block. She has worked extensively on using the crease, using her fingers to give more revolutions to the ball. There's also knowledge exchange with fellow spinners

Vaishnavi knows comparisons barely matter if one doesn't use the chance presented to them. It's what helped her dust off the disappointment of missing out on the T20 World Cup